

Prologue

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He threw the jumbled thoughts down on the page before they fled his mind, never to return. *Remember, remember!* Domicer urged himself as the quill gently kissed the parchment.

Our way is collapsing, and its tales of chivalry and honor are coming to end. Oberath is becoming a realm of industrial witchcraft. The Emperor's Musketeers have hunted the King's noble warriors down to near annihilation. In a final effort to save the Commonwealth the King made an uneasy alliance with his great rivals from all corners of the kingdom, the great strength of all of the gods' men united under one wing. Many of us will not survive to return home, but even still in our people's hearts we will be immortal.

The wet ink had not yet begun to dry when a wide prideful smile made it from corner to corner on Domicer's lips. He lifted the quill gently off the smooth waxy paper and looked up, and as the ink dried and its letters began to harden into the pages, Domicer felt his smile soften and dissolve.

Click. Clack. Click Clack. The sounds taunted him. The very sparse hairs on his arms stood straight and his chest suddenly felt a bit heavy.

Who is that? What is she doing here? She's ruining it. Ruining it all. She is. Domicer almost accidentally complained about her out loud instead of in his head. Who would he even complain to?

Could he call the guards? They were ferociously elegant, dressed in pretty gold armor with bright blue cloaks and wielded their longswords and crossbows, standing firm, distantly in dark corridors. Each carried faces with scars and stared off into nothing. *Seasoned swords sworn to our liege.* He felt a sudden flash of courage, and his heart began to beat hard. *They protect me– I know this.* What noble men wouldn't?

Could he call the people? Well dressed and groomed lords and ladies, scholars and their sons, dukes and their daughters, laid sprawling across the floors. Young women climbing ladders to summit bookshelves, mothers holding their babes with one hand and their tomes in the other as they sat at their tables, fathers lecturing sons, pointing to maps and illustrations and texts, speaking of politics and tactics and trade and the like. *They adore me, I know.* And Domicer adored them, enough to stand between them in his most feared enemy. *Feared?* No, Domicer did not fear.

Could he call his family? Domicer's younger half Kieran loved to read about the Witchhunters and the Beastslayers, he read next to Reese's old mason jar full of fireflies, the latter of which lit up the tables more than any of the lanterns. Back then, Reese would always take Kieran out to catch bugs, butterflies to let loose in the gardens, worms to throw in his terrariums, fireflies to keep out the monsters. He sat right next to Kieran, or laid, to be exact— reading about plants on his bed made of chairs. Those two would read for hours but would insist they were in those pages for days.

His mother watched the boys on the table's other side, a large shadow covering her face and body, leaving only her hands and fingertips easily visible. While other sons stood taking lectures from their fathers, Domicer's sister Artemis stood taking them from the Duke, and the Duke could throw questions ten times as hard as the others and he would catch answers back ten times as fast.

My blood, they are here for me. I know. Yet Domicer didn't dare speak. It was among all these walks of life that *she* stood out, out of place, out of the reaches of Domicer's comprehension. No one dared regard the stranger girl. Maybe she wasn't there, maybe... Domicer's mind was playing games with him *again*. What other explanation was there? She was an anomaly, an absurdity impossible to ignore yet everyone had been doing so flawlessly.

Others walked and were followed by the groaning and wailing of wooden boards, but as the *stranger* girl trotted along she was followed by the gentle playings of a percussionist slamming sticks into a block of wood. A scholar's cloak would play a rustle as they walked, a guard's armor played harsh clanks, the ladies jewelry played delicate tinkles, but *hers* played this mechanical jingle, like dangling bells on a key chain held by a twitching madman sewn into the linen of her cloak. And what a cloak it was.

A hooded wool tunic and a linen canvas meshed into one, rustic, almost like sandstone, only on it were the splatters from a palette of vibrant blasts of color that clung to the edges of her sleeves and sides of her collar. Under the cloak lay a wool sweater, with strangely uniform colorful dyed etches all over, resembling some sort of animal with tiny rubies for its red eyes that placed bumps on Domic's skin. Where the jingles played from the hanging strips stood a metal mouth, followed by a row of teeth. The *stranger girl* grabbed it and yanked it upward, devouring the fabric strip up to the opening of her neck, making a screaming ripping sound. Again, no one paid any mind to it, no one but Domic.

Her heels rose like ramps, her shoes long and tall and her legs had been sheathed in dark blue leather armor, strangely carrying all sorts of uniform seams and rivets. He could barely see her face. Somehow the shadows from the shelves had seemed to climb from her legs up her body and her clothes and her neck, only stopping to rest on her head. Her hair though, was clear to see.

Silky, long, and made of great waves that crashed against the shoals of her shoulder and flowed over them with a choppy elegance. The wave's water was sleek dark and blue, reflecting the night sky as it cascaded down to the ending strands where it splashed into vibrant streaks of violet cyan and indigo. As she got closer his mind and heart began to rail against him, punching his abs from the inside, ramming into the sides of his stomach, begging him to do something. He hardly could; his fingers and feet felt frozen stiff and bones as if they were burned hollow. But as stiff as he was, he was still a warrior, of courage and resolve. He inhaled and braced.

“Hell-Hello?” Domicer almost slapped himself. What a courageous warrior he was. He cleared his throat and tightened his chest, though the fear was doing most of the tightening for him. “Who are you!?” He tried to sound brave, but his terror clung to his words as jitters. *I have to be brave like Artemis. Have to be? No, I am already brave, I always have been. I know, I know.* A giggle taunted him back. He swore he could see her open mouth and pearl white teeth in the shadows. He shuttered as the clacking and tapping got closer. *Is she coming for me?*

When she stepped closer for the last time, the candlelight on his desk shone onto her rosy cheeks and into her big eyes. Its embers danced around her hair like they were afraid of setting it ablaze. He said nothing, didn’t dare move, only could barely muster to move his eyes and try to meet her face. Her eyes paired with her prismatic hair like the clouds did with the sunset, and like clouds, her irises were milky and misty. She had a sharp chin, smooth cheeks, and quaint wide lips. Her skin was smooth and porcelain, freshly polished, but carried a couple loose freckles around her upturned nose and its pinched nostrils. Those pupils of hers stared into him, peering through his eyes into the back of his mind where all his horrors cowered still. Soon after, those quaint lips opened.

“What are you wearing?” Her voice was smooth, sweet, and deeply curious.

What am I wearing? The rainbow fairy girl thinks he's the one who needs to explain his appearance. Had it been less amusing, he may not have played along. Domicer wore his royal tunic, as he always did, carefully measured and tapered for his strong arms and broad shoulders. Shiny silver and platinum dotted him all over, from the caps on his shoulders and his elbows and near the gauntlets on his arm to the greaves on his legs, to the upper half of his cobalt-colored tunic. He gripped at the royal blues and pulled it forward for her to see, his leather shuffling as he did so. The fabric was soft spotless and fluffy like the fur coat of a cat.

“It’s a tunic. The Sacrosanct wear it,” he said proudly as if that wasn’t common knowledge. She kneeled, looking down to inspect it.

“What’s that symbol? Is that a unicorn?”

“A what?” She pressed her slender fingers against the emblem on his shirt. Her prismatic long nail shoved into Domic’s chest. She pointed at the emblem ingrained on his tunic– a golden emblem of a horse and a sword pointing from the top of its head, ending right below where the mane began. It had two great golden gorgeous wings that spanned from one end of the garment to the other. “Oh! That’s a pegasus. It’s the Sacrosanct coat of arms” he proudly stated, puzzled by why she didn’t recognize it. *She must have grown up under a rock.*

“The wings are golden... is that a metaphor?” She sounded like a child hearing a story about dragons for the first time. *Is she toying with me?*

“Who are you?!” Domic declared, sounding more angry than he meant. The chatter in the study had grown louder and louder, making the *stranger girl* harder and harder to hear. Among the chatter was the distant crashing of waves, they grew louder and louder as they crashed and crashed.

She paused, then let out a chuckle. “Right, I probably should have started with that. My name is Amelie, and I am a... how should I put it...”

“A Journeyman?” He jumped in, then immediately regretted not saying journeywoman instead. Was she one of the wandering traders who came to share exotic goods and tales before vanishing? *If she wants to vanish, now would be a great time.*

Amelie’s eyes lit up as she smiled, clearly impressed. “Yes! Kind of. More like a tourist.”

“A torest?” Now he felt like the one who grew up under a rock.

“It’s people who like to visit places I guess.”

I guess? She doesn’t even understand the words she’s saying. She was wasting time with a charade, Domic knew, but somehow he couldn’t stop himself. “So, you’re just here on an adventure then?”

She laughed, pulled out a chair close to him, and sat down. “Sure, I guess. I’m here for other things as well.”

“Such as?”

“Such as...” She took a second to ponder her answer. “I’m also a jailbreaker and an engineer.”

Engineer...? “What is an engineer?”

“It’s... like a builder.”

He stared at her awkwardly for a moment. “You’re also a jailbreaker? Are you going to help free our allies at Ashrend?” Domic spoke with a great deal of respect.

“Ashrend?”

“The fortress. It’s where they hold our people—hundreds of them. Maybe even thousands.”

“Not jails like that.”

“From army camps then?”

“No. From the prison of life.” She smiled and waved her hands around the air. “And all its boundaries.”

He looked at her in awe and horror for a moment. “Do you take lives? Is that what you are saying?” His muscles began to tense up. He could feel his jittering right hand move closer and closer to the pommel of his sword.

She chuckled. “Whoa, I didn’t say that. Life has different dimensions. Different forms. Different ways of representing itself. Isn’t that remarkable? We are just flesh, yet we can see and think and imagine. We have aspirations, passions, perceptions, and journeys. Yet we don’t see other lives as so. We confine them to the land they were born, the people who surround them, the bodies they are born with, the personalities we expect them to have. I’m a prison breaker, but I break people out of the confines of our lives.”

“Whats outside our lives?”

“Crowns.” She smirked. “We could all be kings and queens. There is a world where you are a king. Where you met the right people, was told the right things, got lucky at the right times. Yet right now, you are not one. Is it because you lack kingliness? Or because this world lacks a throne worthy of you?”

Maybe there are those worlds, and maybe that's why no one's heard of them. “I break people from the confines of their lives, but not like you.” Domeric said reluctantly as he looked down. The armor on his shoulders, mail on his arms, gloves on his hands, each felt heavier and tighter by the second, and his skin started to get warm and sticky. His scabbard began to feel heavy on his hip, as if it were filled with seawater around his sword. The smell of salt went up his nose.

“So... who are you? You have to tell, since I answered first.” She said very nervously, before she chuckled and grabbed the book from his desk. She read it out loud in a mocking tone. Domeric hid his rosy face before he snatched it back. She got as far as ‘Many of us will not return home’. There seemed to be a sudden frown. He frowned with her, for some odd reason.

“Don’t be sad.” He said with a small smile. “We’re not afraid of death.”

She looked shocked. “Why?”

“I’m not a coward.” Domeric said dully. “To die for the greater good, it's no easy thing but... anyone real man would do it.”

“How do you know?”

He looked back for a moment. “That it will be for the greater good?” She nodded. “I suppose I just need to have hope.”

“Hope? You’re going to potentially give up your life, which is all you have, and you’re just going to hope it amounts to something?”

“I suppose so.” He wore a smile with pride. “But our hope isn’t blind or stupid, it separates us from our enemies.”

“What will you be after?” She asked, bright sparks from candlelight danced in her pupils as she did so. “If you don’t die for the greater good of course.”

“After...” He sighed. “After we win? I never really thought about it. It’s hard to think I’d ever see the end of it I suppose.”

“So... you hope that your death will have great meaning, but you don’t hope that you won’t die at all?” She gave a concerned chuckle. “You should go charging into the battle hoping to return to the ones you love!”

Battle... “The battle... how do you know about that?” He stared at her. “Are you spying on me!?”

She laughed. “What is there to even spy on? You’re just moping at your desk like an emo.” She coughed into her hand. “I meant... you just don’t seem to be doing much that’s worth spying on.”

He scoffed. “We’re soon to embark on a great battle. Not that you would know. You don’t even know the king’s sigil.” Water began to get well in his eyes.

“You’re *about to*? I thought you were writing. When is this battle?”

“It’s in...” Domic eyes dropped a bit. His mind searched and reached but found nothing. Suddenly, he felt faint and dizzy. *It’s soon, no, it was...* “Wait. I’m confused.” His voice cracked a little.

“Alright...” She seemed discontent and unsatisfied. She looks at him. “What are you doing? Right now?” Her eyes grew skinnier; her brows sunk down.

He cautiously looked back, before nervously gripping the table’s edges. “I’m here to enjoy time with my family and people and my comrades?” His voice grew shaky and unsure. *What does she want from me? She can’t do anything here. No one can. I know.*

She looked concerned, scared for him even. It made Domic feel uneasy. “Why are you actually here? You can tell me!” She urged gently but firmly. “I don’t want to scare you but you have to stop lying to *me*.” He glared back. His nails began to mine shavings from the tabletop as they ground down and back and forth upon it. “Why are you actually here?”

Lying? Me? Domic doesn’t lie. Telling the truth had cost him far more than a scolding before, and it hadn’t stopped him then. “I don’t have to entertain you. Is there a reason you’ve come here to chastise me!?” A tear fell into his mouth as it opened and closed. *Salty*. His hands trembled. “I’ll have the guards remove you. *I will*.” He hissed. “*I will and—*” He raised his hand to call them over, but she snatched it down. Her smooth skin soothed his nerves, as did the rainbow daggers that were her nails, colorful blades leaving trails of red as they slid down his forearm to his elbow. The trails of red were quick to harden and turn sickly pale before slowly regaining their healthy color. He wanted to nudge but she said something that turned his bones to stone.

“What’s the last thing you remember?” While her nails acted as daggers on his skin, his continued acting like pickaxes and shovels as they dug into the grounds around them— the palms of his hands and the caps of his knees, the sharp tingles and jolts rocking Domic’s limbs. He wanted to curse them, only he knew that the sensations were one of the few things that kept him there and whole. His throat tightened and the air grew thick and coarse.

“Wait, I’m confused.” He lamented between gasps. That woman— *Amelie*. She looked disconcerted and uncertain. The waves crashed.

“The last thing.” She begged. “Before you spoke to me, before you wrote in that book, before you came here, *what were you doing?*” She cried for answers.

The interrogation had Domic shaking as he could only answer in “uhms” and “uhs” until he heard the waves from the beaches crashing against the study hall doors and saw the water and seaweed slowly crawl out through under them. “Water.” Domic declared. *I can taste salt on my tongue. I can feel it seep into my wounds. My skin is soaked. My body feels on fire.*

“So, you remember water?” She looked extremely concerned, yet curious. “Water, okay. Were you in the water?”

“... Yes” His voice began to break, and his right leg started jittering and bouncing up and down. The nails had mined ores of blood. Even the table was trembling now.

“Okay, what were you doing in the water?” The doors slowly nudged open as more water began to flood in, along with urchins, shells, weeds, and the like.

“I was... I was drowning. I think I’m dying.” He spoke in terrified upset whispers, his leg bouncing fast enough to shake the floor but no one seemed to notice. His head dropped and hung down. “This might be it.” His voice sank with each word. The water turned red as it rose, climbing higher and higher and growing darker and darker. Crimson waves filled with sand and salt splashed all over the shelves and the people, soaking the tomes and their pages and the people and their robes. They did not notice.

“Listen, look at me.” She said again. “You’re still here. You’re still able to talk to me. You can think and dream and wish.” Domeric didn’t respond, he just nodded. She sat on top of the table, getting closer, as her voice became soft and cheery. “That means you’re still alive. Not just surviving, but you’re alive! I told you before. Life is more than just air and water and meat. But only if you acknowledge it. As long as you are you, as long as you have whims and wishes that the world can’t convince you aren’t real... there’s still hope. You understand?”

“You have to wake up!” His chest grew tighter and tighter. He could barely breathe. “Wake up!”

I know. Wake up, I know. I know.

Suddenly, a great boom parted the waves in the study, forming a funnel that took the books out from their shelves in a whirlwind. The doors had burst open. There a boy stood, an image of Domic, in all his vicious grace. His head was smoldering, only the smoke was ink black and disheveled and fell downwards over the sides of his face, condensing into long silky strands. Obscured amidst the shadow, he could make out an eye— a goblet of wine, down to the hue of its color down to the deepness of its red ring and down to the glimmer of luster in an odd corner. The other of his was gone, lost to the darkness. In place of a blue tunic and metal armor he donned dark black furs with red leather armor, the garments of bone strapped with crude rope sparsely covered his body, the rest was left exposed save for his red trousers and leather straps that criss-crossed all over. On his pale ghastly gray-white skin were scars of red ink, blood-like tattoos that resembled daggers and blades and crosses that followed his arms and wasteline. The tattoo's red streaks accompanied the many veins in his lanky arms. His legs were long and skinny. His body had been stripped bare of all its fat, leaving only corded lean wiry muscle. He held in one hand not a longsword but a blade with teeth like those on Amelie's jacket— only instead of shiny gray metal his was dark red and black with the red dripping off. Where his abs lay half a dozen gashes, each making a blue spotlight where blades broke his skin. They were deep and gaping, massive holes in the walls of his stomach and chest, shooting deep blue beams, and soon after seawater poured out of them and onto the ground below.

“UP!” He heard her voice again.

Domic's eyes shut. *I'm awake. I know.* Then they opened.

Domeric Raimes I

– *Bladeslinger* | *Oberath* –

A dark red abyss where only the faint silhouettes of fish feasting on corpses gave him company. *Have I died and gone to hell?* Juices drained from his eyes and strength from his limbs and air from his lungs. Besides the fish gracefully swam the shadows of arrows with triangles for heads and v's for tails, some of them dragged great crimson clouds behind them before they too were swallowed by the sea. From far away he heard what sounded like a drawbridge being raised over and over and over, a grinding gear making *thump, thump, thump* sounds. Domeric almost mistook it for his own heart.

Everything was heavy and crushing. Domeric's chest felt tight and empty. His head was pounding and his limbs were weak. As his lungs began to empty the color started to drain from his vision. *Hell. I am in hell*, he thought as everything got darker. Amelie had been too late and now he was a drowned corpse in a bath of raspberry salt, doomed to be crushed under the weight of the oceans and gasping for air till the end of time and to be feasted on by fish. Then he saw it. A massive curved shadow looming above him like a small black sun, he could scarcely make out its sails, wings, and rudder. *The Cladwing*– the great pride of the royal fleet– swam with the elegance of a golden siren. The King's craftsman worked tirelessly to make the most nimble, gracious and mighty ship his liege ever seen, with flapping golden wings, royal blue sails, and a great big waterwheel in the back that churned water into a white froth. As he gazed upon it, a sudden wave of pride crashed into him, drenching his legs and fingertips with strength and vigor. *We are the sons of Maverick.*

But, however tirelessly the king's craftsmen had worked, the Wychen had worked harder still. No feat of naval carpentry can change what their bolts did to the ship's boards. They flew in a barrage from the sky. The sails went first, the shadow of the falling mast loomed over the water. Next went the deck, the wooden boards exploding into splinters. The hull followed, and soon enough, the ship was a ship no longer. He could see shadowy figures clamor and jump overboard as she was shredded to gibs. His heart sank harder and he wished to sink with it, all the way to the sealake floor. Boys flew overboard-- the ones that didn't get cut in half by the bolts-- and he could see them flailing in the water and hear them screaming in his head, the sapphire banners fell and sank, and with it the royal insignia of the flying holy horse. The finest vessel designed in the Commonwealth chopped to pieces by some turret. Domic made a small whimper in the water as he watched. Suddenly, the cold dread burned into hot rage, and he began to rise as fast as the bubbles that came steaming out of his nose up to the water's surface. Domic was wrong; he wasn't in hell, he was below it, frozen stiff watching everyone else burn. If the battlefield was hell, then the devils would be there, and Domic couldn't stand idly by as they basked the world in flame. His arms and legs flailed like a dying fish, the sealake's surface came closer and closer to slamming him in the face. He was almost there but his vision began to go black. His arms stopped feeling like limbs and more like sticks strapped to his body. His mind began to go away, and all he could think about was the dream. *Up, up!*

His head punched through the surface of the water, his mouth as wide as a whale's, the air rushing through his veins, bringing color back to his vision and thoughts back into his mind. *I could take that breath of air for eternity*, he thought. He looked around-- arrows still flew, young corpses littered the water's surface like lilies, with their boyish hair for pink flowers and empty bodies for the pads. Huge explosions appeared in the water as boulders rained from above, and anybody caught in the explosions turned to red mist. The horrified crew of the destroyed ship screamed, some of them swimming downwards to face drowning instead of the bolts and boulders. Domic would not join them. *I will never go down again, only up*. Up to *Ashrend*, its great balistas and spires looming above in the distance.

It would take more than a few destroyed ships to stop the King's sons. They would seize the fortress. They would kill the Artificer and hang his head on the walls along with the Commonwealth's banners. He thought of the Wychen, all comfortable and plump and fat and warm in his people's halls. *Those men will reap.* Calling them men was a stretch. They were filthy demonic beasts wearing the skin of men, with no qualms of murdering and enslaving their way across the world. Those *creatures* have not anything to offer this anyone—not valiance nor righteousness—only greed, appetites, and low cunning. Everything they touched turned to shit and nothing better proves that point than Ashrend Fortress itself. The former hunting outpost and commerce center had once been the Chasseur's pride and cultural hub, armed to the teeth with weapons and mounted turrets, filled with butcher shops. Domic's siblings would often visit with the Duke, while Domic admired the bustling sounds of street stalls and the beauty of the tall black brick walls. Now, they say brave warriors are paraded in the halls like cattle. Domic would throw him out, he swore, to every god there was and will be. He swam, now with air in his lungs and blood back in his veins, he powered through the water like a shark.

The water crashed against his head. *That girl's hair...* That was just a dream, but a mad part of him believed he had a vision. The King's grandson Horen had a vision of uniting all of Oberath under the Commonwealth when he was just a boy, and that vision had dictated the future since. *Am I mad? Important people have visions. That was no vision.* The Lord? *Have I served well enough? Did he reach his hand out to me?* Domic had to have lived for a reason, he decided. He flopped onto the black clay bank that buffered the black hundred-foot castle walls from the red water. Some parts of the clay kept souvenirs—fallen blades, burnt pieces of leather, fragments of skull—all lay under the bank half covered like seashells on a beach.

The wall rode atop a massive black cliffside, its terracotta edges crumbling bit by bit from the pounding of war. From the wall's parapets came small blasts of smoke along with sharp cracks and booms that rang out. Something whizzed near Domic, finding the clay near him and shooting a plume of black clay out of the ground like a geyser. Domic looked down to see a few panicked soldiers, some in gold and blue armor, others in black and red furs, some young and pale, others old and bloody. He stared blankly before one of their chests exploded and spat out red vomit before falling into the clay, the other soldiers and Domic instantly hit the ground. His training had kicked in, but even so, his heart was booming and his fingers shook like a boat in the storm. Domic scanned the field for his comrades while the ground was booming with gunshots. He saw the ballistas spitting into the sea, the spiders crawling over the watchtower roofs, but not the 32nd battalion.

“Captain!? Anyone!?” Domic cried out as he lay on the sand, but the only response he heard was the beating gears of crossbow turrets and the sounds of boulders slamming against the clay and waters. *Thump thump thump*. Each loud sound made him jolt out of fear— the fear that he would die before even getting to fight the enemy, before he would even see an enemy. *I will not die with a clean blade*. He staggered his way through the beach's graveyard, walking with a strange frustrated shock. He forced his dry lips open. “CAPTAIN!? CAN YOU HEAR ME?” His head was pounding, as was his heart. The red sun was gorgeous but blinding, it ripped the clouds ahead in two to glare straight into his eyes. *Thump thump thump*.

The next time he tried to shout no words came out, only a cocktail of blood and seawater that he nastily spit out onto the clay. He staggered forward, vision doubled and legs almost buckling under the weight of his weapons. He saw a helmet in the distance, the metal shell had a luster of silver and a plume of blue, with an open visor and dagger blue eyes that could be made out even from this distance. The captain was crowded around by other boys, most of whom were shorter with cheaper gear. Domic felt his chest loosen as he took a great exhale. He should have called out, but instead just wandered closer, the distant unintelligible talking drawing him. He wanted so badly to hear someone's voice— not screams or barked orders for once.

“You hear the gears on those things?” The Captain with the blue plume cried, half in frustration and half in awe. “They’re so... *smooth*. I think that’s more than thirty shots with no pause, no delay, not even a squeak from its cogs. Our’s can’t even go two shots without sounding like a dying horse.” *Captain Tavick*. Domic smiled. His mentor stood tall and staunch, with a full frame and weary skin. He seemed well kept, mostly shaven save a slight stubble and donned a shiny clean suit of armor, but his eyes told a different story– the weariness of war had gotten to him. *It’s clearly getting to him at this moment*. “I can’t wait to kill the bastard who mans that gun.”

“You have to hand it to this Architect. I’ve never seen craftsmanship like this before.” A second knight responded, clad in chainmail with a blue cloak draped over his body. Eidrick stood with the same height as Tavick but with far worse presentation. His beard and hair were overgrown, and his face wore numerous scars. While Tavick’s eyes held a hint of weariness, Eidrick’s made it clear he hadn’t slept for weeks. “They think we can beat this with a few fancy ships and a bunch of barbarians?” *Barbarian*. Domic nearly flinched, even though he had heard it a thousand times. “What the hell was high command thinking?” Eidrick continued. Domic was less pleased to see him than his captain.

The opposite could be said when Domic caught a glint of the shaggy birdnest that was Kieran’s hair, as well as his overly long and loose fitting black furs and endearing looking blood tattoos. Most Bladeslingers like knives and bones and skulls and arrows on their skin, but Kieran’s made a beautiful vine with fruit and roses that climbed his torso. He sat there, looking lost as always with an awkward face and big upturned nose. Kieran did not speak to the others often, as opposed to his buddy beside him, who taunted Eidrick with his scoffing.

“It comes down to the swordsman, not the sword, otherwise we should all just pick up smithing for the cause instead.” Domic recognized Hardrian from all the way from when he first set his eyes on the 32nd from how narrow his torso and obliques were. His tattoos were all crows and wine, his hair was long, loose, wavy and soft, and fell exactly where he wanted on each part of his face. He was short and skinny, though with shapely muscles, with a small freckled upturned nose. The freckles were a vibrant red and his eyes were like small pretty coals. Hadrian got on Eidrick’s nerves but it made no matter. Hadrian could spit on the fiercest soldier in Oberath and they would do nothing about it, unless they didn’t know him well. *He’s very good looking until he opens his mouth.* “Besides, don’t give the Artificer all the credit, his engineers do most of the work.”

“Edge-in-nears?” Eidrick scoffed. “Did you hit your head when the ship crashed?” He spoke to the other two Sacrosanct Lumiknights, Mathis Baker and Leylo Baker, scanning for their laughs. The short and stocky pair had shed most of their armor. Mathis stared off into the distance watching the ships get destroyed in the distance, his mouth was agape. A massive black-eye seemed to have found its way on his face after the crash. Leylo sat on the ground frozen and unmoving. They had both watched Mertos get blasted to bits by the ballistas when their ship, *the Ladylome*, was torn in two.

“Engineers.” Domic harshly whispered as he corrected him. The cogs in his head turned like the balistas. *A vision. I knew it. No, I’m mad...* Tavick made a yelp sound that would have been funny under different circumstances. Kieran and Eidrick whipped around. “You were here the whole fucking time?” Hadrian asked. Tavick let out a sigh of relief and gave him a hug. Kieran ran up as well, wrapping his arms tightly around Domic’s chest.

“We thought the worst. Do you know how hard we were looking for you?” Tavick barked.

“No.”

“Thank god!” Tavick laughed like a drunk old man. Domic punched him on the shoulder jokingly before blowing on his knuckles, forgetting how tough Tavick’s armor was. That made him laugh harder, he roared like a loin. *It’s not that funny.* “You’ve heard the word before, no? *Engineers*” He mocked his voice in a brooding tone. “You sound like you have.”

“Why do you care,” Domic said.

“I’m curious.” He shrugged. “We might die here so I may as well find out while I still can.”

“Whose ‘we’?” Hadrian asked. Eidrick told him to shut up for Domic.

“I don’t remember.” Domic lied to Tavick. *Am I supposed to say I dreamt of it?* The absurdity briefly washed over his mind before he opened his mouth. “What’s our next move?” Domic’s hands were shaky, and his breath grew restless. “Why are you all just waiting here?”

“I don’t know! What are we waiting for?” Hadrian tested the Captain’s patience. “Let’s just go in.”

“No.” Tavick spoke sternly. Domic looked closely at the wall that towered over them. Ink black burn marks dotted the walls for when the Lumiknights shot their firework barrages to try to screen the ships from the turrets and Musketeers. The smell of powder from their barrels clung to the air with the blood, salt, sweat and clay. Domic’s battalion hugged the wall close, but the Wyche Musketeer’s plumes of smoke could still be seen as they turned into clouds and drifted freely off into the sky. In the distance, he could see shadows run up to where the drawbridge once was and fire shots up at the wall before collapsing into the ground. “We’re waiting for the next barrage?” He said solemnly.

“That’s right. We just learned the hard way that even when the fireworks splatter over all the turrets they can still see— not sure how. Blinds the Musketeers at least. Either way, whether the rest of the Regiment realizes it or not, the plan is set. First barrage for the ships. Second barrage is for when we charge through the gate. Each wave is timed with the barrage.”

Domic stared at Tavick, stared at how Hadrian and Kieran’s hands hovered around their rappel hooks, and how the whole company had crowded themselves around this random segment of the wall. “We’re not joining them? Are we cowards!?”

Eidrick laughed. “Fuck no! I like breathing.”

“That’s right Dom-- well, not the coward part. If we can’t rely on the fireworks, we’ll need some other distraction.” Tavick gave the boy an impressed smile.

“You’re going to leave them to die, use them as a distraction to sneak into the fortress? What of our brothers? What of honor?” *What kind of knight are you?* He heard himself say in his head but not out loud.

Tavick’s huge smile dissolved. “It seems unchivalrous, I know, but it’s our best chance. I wish the command saw this coming, but it’s too late.”

“Don’t be so dumb, *Dom*. They’re charging the turrets, with or without us.” Hadrian pointed out in the most pretentious way possible. “You always praise the king so much. He wants the fortress back. A true loyal servant of his would be willing to forsake his courage for a brief moment if it meant raising the odds of victory.”

“He’s right...” Kieran agreed. “Dom, they would want us to. If we can sneak over, we will have a better chance.” Domic contemplated. *Do we truly have to be so slimy?*

“Sorry lad. It wouldn’t matter if you wanted to or not– I already ordered. Now you must follow.” He spoke, bluntly honest. *Yes sir*, Domic said in his head with sarcastic enthusiasm before putting his hands around the rope and beginning to spin it in a small circle. It rang loud crisp wispy sounds in the air as he handled the steel string, and soon enough Hadrian and Kieran joined the band.

“Remember, everyone!” Tavick yelled. “If you find a man with half his face missing, you grab him on the spot! The Artificer responsible for the deaths of thousands of people, and is the cog of the Wychen War Machine! We will break into his fortress, seize him, and spill his secrets. No kingdom has ever had their inventions flourish so fast. The Royal command insists they have some sort of trick, and that trick is within our former fortress!”

Domeric clenched his teeth as he closed in on the wall. What sort of barbarities exist in the Artificer's playhouse? What sort of horrible rituals had he performed to bless his empire with such power? He did not want to see at all. *Soldiers, innocents, even children have to see it, endure it. If they can, I have to.* "I can skate up there no problem. It would be faster." Hadrian cocked a bolt in the side of his boot, the sound made the hairs on Domeric's arm stand straight. The first time he tried blade-skating was on his village's rooftops with Kieran and Artemis. He slipped on a bird's nest, tumbled onto the brick roof of the Armory, breaking his ankle when he landed before sliding off and falling onto the street below.

"I don't think that's a good idea." Kieran said bluntly. "That wall is nearly fifty feet high, we should save our energy." Kieran was right of course, but part of it might have been to save Domeric the embarrassment. The whistling began. *The fireworks.* A huge flash of white could be seen over and above his head, though he kept his eyes to the ground. A huge blast erupted behind them where a boulder became part of the ground, showering them with black clay. Domeric and Kieran jolted as Hadrian carelessly flung the black clay off his black hair before throwing the hook upwards where it dangled and snatched onto the side of the parapet. Domeric and his brother followed suit, waiting to hear the metal clink against the stone and giving the rope three stress test pulls before grabbing tight. The firework's whistling grew louder as they approached from the ships' cannons— the ones that were left at least. He placed his feet flat against the black brick and soon enough the wall had become the ground, and the ground the wall. The rope tensed and made weak groans, and the trio began to walk. He barely could make out the small silver caps in the distance, who were taking potshots at the boys who were still making it out of the water.

The winds began to blow, they howled in his ear relentlessly. Domic thought of the Musketeers at the top of the wall, and their massive guns and big axes. *If they look down...* Domic would be a massive fish in a tiny barrel. He looked down at his Sacrosant comrades, all waiting carefully in their silver armor, crossbows loaded. *Can Tavick shoot them before they shoot me?* The rope creaked. *The rope won't give way... it won't! I know, I know...* Even if it may, it was worth it, Domic had to fight them, he had to hunt them down. *Will I scream if it snaps? Would they understand it's not my fault?* He stepped, and his leather bottom of the boot slipped a little. Though, the small slip felt like for a moment he had fallen off the wall to the ground, where his bones would break in one great snap. He would be a mangled mess in front of them all. *Would they laugh? Would they just sigh and shake their heads?*

Domic imagined the crack of the barrel and the jolt of his body, of him dangling lifelessly like a fool in front of all his friends and foes. The gray purple hands, the blue white hands, the red pale ones, they all pointed and laughed. *Laughing at me.* His chest was tight, his ribcage felt as if it was collapsing on itself. *What if they shoot me in my eyes? Mother loves my eyes...* He could hear the breathing in his ears, and it drowned out the screams of horror and the sounds of gunfire. His hands shook and his legs were vibrating. He was half breathing, he felt no air in his tight lungs but could hear his panting over Kieran, who was screaming something. Kieran was above him now, him and Hadrian. *Did I stop walking?* Domic looked down again. His battalion had turned into ants way below, and suddenly he felt a huge breeze against his sides. His hands were slippery. The rope creaked. *Creak, creak.* Kieran was screaming more, he could see Hadrian's mouth open and close. *Am I going to be a shame again? It cannot be.* Why did it always come to this? He ruminated about this battle for days and nights, he told himself he would not shy away at the true moment so many times yet here the moment was, and here he was, as shy and shameful. *I can't, I wish I could.*

'dom.'

I must be brave and strong, like Tavick, like Artemis.

“DOM!” Kieran’s shout made Domic want to cover his ears. He was shouting but Domic did not hear, only saw him yelling as they were strung on the rock wall, like climbers, back when brother Reese would bring them with cables to scale the Render cliffsides. *I am a king’s son, a cherished son of the Gods. Courage is my duty.* It felt like his head was being pinched. He imagined whole crowds cheering for him now. *They’re chanting for me to do it. I have to.*

“Domic!” Kieran’s eyes grew big and watery and pleaded with him. “Please Domic, we can do this! We have to go up!”

Up, up! Domic heard the girl’s voice still in his head, along with the jingles of her metal and the clicking of her boots. *I will never go down again.* He said that, hadn’t he? *I will never go down, only up.* Domic’s hands tightened around the rope. He moved one foot after another.

Karina Kenning I

– Dark Arts Academy | Oberath –

She always thought lowly of those who listened to gossip. Of course, she herself did all the time, but it was different for her– the others always would hear a mutation of a mutation corrupted by envy and arrogance and hope, and think it pure. Karina was a better listener than that.

But it was more observing than listening– observing arrogance in their smiles, or admiration in the eyes. Their gullibility, their delusions, their favors and peevs, their presumptions about how the world actually worked. She should thank them, for the only honest things they end up saying are about themselves.

“They say his mind works differently– that I heard he can see colors others can’t, imagine events days before they occur!” One of them chanted in awe and wonder, an enthusiastic young boy with big dumb eyes that fit well with his pretentious scholar uniform. “It gives him military and political genius.”

“That’s a given.” A Musketeer answered, thankfully interrupting the boy before he broke into song. He had toned muscles, a bushy beard, and a handsome young face. He wore illustrious and shiny purple armor, with jagged edges all over, perfectly highlighting the bulges around his arms and shoulders. A musket with a barrel the size of a small the size of a spear and an obsidian dual sided axe lay strapped to his back. *Lavender Crystalmail. Must be rich... handsome as well.* She already despised him. “But it’s not truly his vision that makes him so great, it’s his might.” He droned on. “His prowess in battle is uncontested. When the Pirate King rampaged the Fissures, it was Carrow who buried a spear in his chest! They say he fought with the strength of a thousand men!” The gods always loved to waste good cheekbones and pretty eyes on morons.

“You’re both wrong.” A shrewd old man answered, gray haired and bearded. This one wore no mail, instead donning a dusty captain’s uniform, and while the Musketeer’s armor did well to accentuate his biceps and shoulders the captain’s uniform did the same for his beer belly and love handles. “It’s neither about strength nor intellect. You wish to know the real reason? It’s because he is *ruthless*. His father was strong and shrewd too, yet it did not matter for when the heretics rose up against him he did not show the makings of an emperor.”

“Blasphemy, you old lunatic!.” The young dreamer spat. “The Late Shade Emperor displayed nothing but wisdom and virtue, just like his heir.”

The old man grew louder. “You call it wisdom to treat your enemies and let them slaughter you in your own halls? I call it a lack of conviction! It’s time we pay the heathens back in kind– under a decisive, ruthless leader.” The old man had a point, she agreed, but to what degree? The Shade Emperor, in the wake of his fathers murder at the hands of the Sacrosanct delegates, had waged a destructive war that had united all of Oberath against them for the sake of conquest. No matter how powerful they were, they were outnumbered three to one.

“I wouldn't expect anything less of my liege. He destroys any opposition.” The templar said in agreement.

The yapping eye candy was of no interest to her, nor the old glutton, nor the up-jumped poet. It was only earned by the mass of muscle bundled up in the corner, like links of white sausage rolled into a massive mess with oily strands of silver hair holding it all together, laying sprawling around the chunks of meat. She couldn't avert her gaze, so she called for him like a songbird. “*You sir.*” Her voice was full of wonder and intrigue. “What do *you* believe?”

“Believe about what?” He spoke cranky and reluctant, as if he knew the entire conversation ahead of time and was weary to repeat it. Karina would not tolerate it— some gloomy sod acting like she was dull.

“About his liege! Of course!” She acted excited to talk about it, as if the Emperor's mere title was going to make her kick her feet and giggle.

“His liege...” The sunken man began to rise. The candidates all stared. There were fang marks all over him, on his shoulders and near his ribcage. The mark of a hand lay on his right cheek, his face looked clammy and his lips were so cracked bits of skin fell off as he spoke. He exhaled like a dying mule, wheezing as he spoke with malice and hatred, spitting venom to his audience. “His liege is—” He quickly lowered his voice as he could hear the rest of the Gunknights marching, their rhythmic steps shaking and rumbling the whole floor as the storm approached. “His liege is *mad*. Totally crazed, insane, and delusional. He kills not with strength but with the arcane, the product of centuries of toiling and unnatural experimentations. He is all that is cruel and unholy in this world. He is ungodly— no, he is the soul of a demon himself wrapped in skin.

“How dare you!” The young boy's voice cracked as he screamed in protest. Karina was proud of herself for not chuckling out loud. “You're the only mad man present in this castle!” *Also, the only man*, Karina added in her head.

“Palace.” The Musketeer corrected him. A distinct correction of course— palace was a much more praiseworthy title than castle, it had prettier decorations after all. What more could she expect, of course *he* would only care about *that*. He stared down the sunken stranger with his dagger diamond eyes. “In what hell would you know? I will not tolerate this nobody to make snides about his liege.” His fingers fumbled around his musket’s handle, before hoisting it up and aiming it with a remarkable form that the military community has been tragically unaware of.

“Nor will I.” The fat captain rose to his feet as well, drawing an iridium sword as he did so. It was a family heirloom— old, fancy, strong as a needle, sharp as his chins. “Speak more slander and I’ll hack you to pieces” *Is he made of cheese!?*

Maybe they would all kill each other and she would go home with a promotion. She smiled at the thought. “Hack at me will you?” The strongman mocked as he towered over all of them.

“Should you continue making problems!” the Gunknight said in a sugar sweet voice, trying to hide his shaking.

“I’m making no problems boy, but if you want to start, the Emperor’s going to need some servants to wipe down this room.” He snarled, before being interrupted by a booming shout.

“Hail Karroy!” A man in purple armor clicked his heels and slammed his musket butt into the ground, the wood making a clunky echo in the hall. Half a dozen guards came in double file, then spread apart in unison. *Now those are marksmen. Maybe one of them should audition.*

“HAIL KARROY!” Everyone in the room, save the sunken man shouted at the same time. His liege did not notice the one absent cheer, for his state was perplexingly offputting and dismal. A walking soup of alcohol and elixirs and potions, and he smelled of it too— old burned herbs, tar, fermented grains, and aged sap. The air around him was sticky. Clacks against the floor sounded out as the Emperor used a stick with an amethyst at its head to help him walk. He drooled where he went, the drool glowed purple and bounced on the ground a few times before solidifying. His skin was gross and patchy, and extremely loose. It reminded her of a peach left out in the sun too long, and a deeply disturbed part of her wanted to pick it off, only she knew under it wasn’t warm sweet nectar but some concoction of sorcery, gluttony, extravagance, and the damnation from gods. His purple cloak poorly drooped over his hunch back, doing a poor job at fitting his body.

“What are we doing here?” Karroy asked. “Why are these strangers in my room? Deal with them you lunatics!”

“My liege, those are the candidates you chose.” The most senior Gunknight answered.

“I... chose?” His eyes were slightly bloodshot. He looked confused and angry. “For what, an afternoon picnic?” He panted as he spoke.

“No my liege, for...” The Gunknight sighed and leaned down slightly, and lowered his tone in a quieter but still distinct volume. “For case green.”

The king suddenly jolted his head upwards. “Shut up!” He smacked the templar on his head, his fist denting it and hitting the soldier on his dome, making a comical *bonk* sound. The templar yelped in pain and staggered backwards. “Why the hells are you speaking of it here, you fucking fool? You want them all to know about it? Did you all hear?” The king asked the applicants.

“We did, sir!” The loyal dreamer volunteered before she could say anything. *Fuck. I hope he gets killed first.* Now the king knew, and he had reason to put their heads on spikes. Hopefully her head gets to go next to the pretty man’s instead of the fat crone or the huge freak.

“Sir? Sir!? SIR!?” The king spat out, so outraged he choked on his spit a little. “The next time you address me, you will say *my liege*.” He said with disgust. “Understand!? Have you no respect for prestige or royalty?”

“No, no, no my liege!”

“No? Are you moronic? Are you simple?”

“No my liege!” he profusely apologized.

“No? Then you’re not wary of our customs since you are not one of us! Can you believe this men?” The king shouted. “A traitor among us in disguise! Dispatch him now!” The sounds of guns clicking made the boy almost fall to his knees and start crying.

“No my liege, I am so sorry my liege.” The scholar begged. “I just wished to serve you my liege, I got carried away my liege, please.”

“Alright then, serve. Answer me, are you a sacrosanct in disguise?”

“No sir, not at all!” he cried out.

“Prove it. You’re a scholar right?”

He straightened his voice. “Yes my liege.”

“In what?”

“In history and military strategy, my liege.”

“History then, huh? What fish populate River Nox?”

“I-I don’t know that!” the boy proclaimed. “I study history and military?”

“Fish are important to our culture, our cuisine, our trade!” He carelessly gestured his arm in the air before sighing. “Fair enough, history is it? What fish dominated the river 200 years ago?”

“I don’t know!”

Suddenly, a flash of darkness erupted from the amethyst-stick, and the boy suddenly was reduced to his screaming shadow on the wall when the purple mist cleared. The black shadow was permanently etched into the wall, no matter which way the light shone. Where the boy was, a small pile of ashes now lay. The applicants besides her and the hulking man gasped and stepped back. The guards all made a face. *Just another evening for them.* The Musketeer and the Captain both looked a bit pale and their fingers began to shake. Karina’s were perfectly still.

“Ha! You thought this was a walking stick?” He cackled. “I catch them coming each time—godforsaken Sacrosanct spies. They can change their skins, you know, I’ve witnessed it before. They can change the color of their face and length of their hair in an instant. But they cannot change their degenerate culture, and their revolting lack of true noble civilization.”

Now, does anybody here know what fish are in that river?”

“I do, my liege!” The seasoned captain stood up. “Darthfinn, the Rampler, and the Toadfish, though the toadfish is technically a crustacean.” He smiled moronically and looked around to boast his greatest life achievement. “My father was an angler in the lakes.”

For the first time since she first saw him, the Emperor smiled, quite deviously. “That’s right. This one must be one of us, unlike that sorry dead piece of shit over there. Now you have a strong knowledge of ‘history’, but what of your prowess in battle?”

“Better than almost any man living, my liege.” *Somehow I doubt that.* He took a great war axe from behind his back. “Allow me to prove my skills to you, firsthand.”

“Go on then. Prove it.” He motioned to the tallest one of his men. He took off his helm, revealing the rugged face of a middle-aged man, with choppy white hair and a scar that took out one of his eyes, leaving a black hole. He held a crystal axe and his armor was so shiny Karina could almost see a perfect reflection of herself in its shoulder blades. “This is Sir William Lionhart!”

“My liege, that’s William.” The man pointed to one of the guards. “My name is Sir Oakmont—”

“Shut the hell up.” The king’s voice was stern. “This warrior, whose name is not important, is a tried and tested veteran. He is famous for his valor at the Ambush of Ashrend and the Defence of Castle Umbara. He’s cut down over a hundred men, suffering only one wound to his eye throughout.”

I can beat him, but let’s see how the captain fares first. “My liege,” she said, “we would love to prove our skill in battle with this renowned warrior.” She gazed at the captain. “How about the most seasoned of us start? Lest we not give off a good first impression.”

The captain stammered, then collected himself. “My liege, allow me to duel your warrior!”

“Alright, alright, alright.” The king had grown tired and bored. “Old one, you go first. Fail to defeat him in solo combat, and you will be disqualified from the position.”

“As you command, my liege.” The older captain walked up to the warrior and swung his axe at the warrior’s head. The warrior ducked under it, and kicked the captain so hard he flung across the room. A huge thud was heard as he bounced off the wall and landed on the ground, and he did not get up.

“Oh. I had such high hopes.” The Emperor said sarcastically. “*Disqualified!*” Another blast of darkness came out from the king’s stick, and the captain joined the scholar as a black portrait on the wall. His ashes didn’t even make a pile, and dispersed randomly across the floor.

Oh gods. He’s going to kill everyone except the winner.

The warrior laughed, sadistically and cruelly, and pointed at the shadow on the wall. The king began cackling with him. “He didn’t even get to swing more than once!”

“Fret not- I will be swinging plenty.” The Musketeer moved in on the warrior without warning, swinging rapidly and ferociously. The first caught the warrior offguard, the second almost made him stagger to his feet, but the third he saw coming, and he deflected it with one blow before quickly giving another swing, dehanding the challenger. The Musketeer screamed in shame and pain. “No!” he yelled, then fell to his knees, the blood dripping from his handless sockets onto the marble floor.

“He thought he had a chance.” The warrior called out to the king. “He got kind of close.”

“So close.” Carrow jeered. “Too bad.” Then, predictably, a flash of darkness later and the kneeling soldier’s last moments were now a token on the wall, a sizable pile of ashes lay where he once knelt. “Now you, go.” The Emperor motioned to her. “I hope he doesn’t hit your pretty face.” He sneered before turning around to his guards. “What the hell am I going to do if they all lose. I guess we could find another batch.”

“We already did that twice, my liege.” One of his men said.

“We did? When?” He coughed and some glowing elixir juice came out. “Well, third time’s the charm, as they say.”

She began to walk towards the warrior. He looked at her deviously and impatiently, licking his gross lips as she approached. She feigned a trip over the dead captain's puny little sword, and fell right at the ashes, letting out a scared yelp as she did so. The whole room erupted with laughter, and she quietly grabbed a small handful of the ashes with her left hand as she shamefully got up. "If you give up now, I'll let you serve as my handmaiden!" Carrow cried out.

She approached slowly, pretending to shake and jitter as she did so. "Let's get this over with." The warrior said as he ran up to her and swung. She used her right hand to block the swing with her shortsword, but he was clearly much greater in strength, and pushed her weapon down as the sword began to reach her shoulder. She used her free left hand to throw the ashes in his eyes– he yelped and staggered backwards, and lowered his blade momentarily. In a flash, she lunged on him and began to jab her dagger in his head.

"Die. Die DIE!" She yelled as she stabbed him in the head over and over, like a knife into a watermelon it tore fast through the crust and even faster through the mushy red insides. Splashes of blood splattered over her and her clothes as she relentlessly dug into him. She knew he was dead, and the more she stabbed the more disgusted she felt, but the king wanted a show, and she would give him one. The room fell silent by her tenth stab, and after the fifteenth, she finally threw her dagger to the side and turned to face the king, and curtsied.

"My liege." She said, saltily.

At first, the king's face was one of shock, but it quickly turned to one of pure bliss and childlike excitement. "Oh my gods- that was perfect. Did you see that? A dozen battles he said?" He snickered, then began to almost choke on his laughter.

Noticing a window of opportunity, the sunken weary man grabbed his blade and lunged at the king, managing to get inches away before his guards could react. She wondered for a split second if it would have been a good thing– the Emperor’s madness would drive the Wychen to defeat, surely she knew that. But the Emperor had two sons, one a wrathful madman, the other a greedy glutton and drunk, and they were not surrounded by the well studied minds Carrow was. Either way, Oberath would never know. Karina often impressed herself with her gunplay, but this time she outdid herself. In a room with a dozen guards, a girl, and four corpses, Karina got him first, she swung the musket around her shoulder before anyone reacted and took a quick shot. It was bold– if she missed and hit Carrow, ending up as a shadow or a head on a stick would be the lucky outcome. *Fortune favors the bold*, she told herself in relief as the hall erupted in applause and respect. The hulking man’s head had a massive window in it, and all his muscle and meat now lay still.

“Thought you could best me, did you!” The Emperor cheered as if he did anything. “Foolish coward.” He kicked the man’s head in the window, and his boot got stuck in it for a moment before he had to pull it out, as if it was stuck to mud, making a gross splotching sound. The king turned to Karina. “It appears we have a selection! A talented warrior and my savior.” He walked towards her. “A woman too, eh? Well, it’s important to keep... *an open-mind!*” He gestured to the dead warrior’s corpse, whose head was ripped open.

She didn’t find it funny, but cackled extra hard. “Open mind! That’s a good one, my liege. I would be honored to kill just like that again in his majesty’s service.”

“Tell me about yourself, then, girl.”

It’s my lady. She clicked her dress shoes and smiled. “I am Lady Karina Kenning, daughter of the former Grand Admiral and sister of Castellan of the Render. I have never placed under first rank in any of my courses, I have mastered four trades, including Gunsmithery, Brewing, Spelunking, and Leathworking. I put down four rebellions, and won two skirmishes against Commonwealth forces in the Render and the Shoals.” She made her voice as sweet and cheery as she could. “*The Arcane Archer*, they call me.”

The Emperor smiled as men marched in with a table in and a map, their boots storming on the ground with echoes. “I hear your enemies call you something else. *Limbthinner*. I don’t blame you, sieges are far more effective, though the songs about them don’t sound as good.” She watched as they placed the pieces on the Render, run by the savage Chasseur, where all the dead go to die again as mushrooms. The red lands were brutish, with rapid rivers running through the body of it like veins. The *Sickle*, massive inlet of ocean water that was shaped as such, hung around the Ashrend Fortress ready to take it down in a swing. The swing came in the *First Royal Regiments* naval fleet that was storming the stronghold at this very moment. She was not afraid. *Percius will throw them back into the water.*

Ashrend itself was the Wychen’s purple. *Purple*. If the Chasseur were red and vicious and the Sacrosant blue and sophisticated, it only made sense that the Wychen would be the best of both. The Fissures were a great amethyst carpet on the board, riddled with giant cliffs and ravines, that indelicately rolled out onto the Render and the green forested Glades.

The Wychen tried to take the Commonwealth surprise once by piercing through the most densely wooded region, getting up to fifty miles from the Meadows before they were stopped by the Rangers and King Maverick’s Lumiknights, who was still a prince then. The King’s Meadows were a cobalt blue, and unbesmirched. Fitting for their pretty castles and shiny armor. Karina dreamed of torching the plains and jumping up the floating islands before storming the Castle Hearthmark herself.

So many nails, yet the coffin could not stay closed. Every time the Wychen got close to stepping foot on Sacrosant land they were thwarted. The Crown had too much space and too much meat. They grew smarter too— Artemis, or the *King’s Tiger*, and her Vanchist Legion had been chasing their best armies across the map, retaking the King’s lands as she went.

“Case Green!” Carrow announced while licking his lips. “We’ve tried everything, from pushing through the trees to raiding the shores— we hold three of the Core Castles, and for what? The King’s colonies still stand, the Meadows are untouched, and our gains are stalling. We need to move fast, before we are unable to deal with our debts, the war machine needs feeding! We grow, our technology grows, yet we can’t sustain this growth without conquest!”

“Of course my liege. What are you proposing?”

“My dear Lorynce and commander Ralf are facing Artemis and Maverick a few hundred relays south of the Shoals, right above the Redstone Bridge. They command the two strongest armies Oberath has ever seen. Two armies, against their three. But they are weak and exhausted, and we have steel and scorpions. Once my son prevails he and Ralf will head down over the bridge to destroy the invaders of Ashrend Fortress.”

Only a fool would be so certain. There's always some sort of trick. She'd studied the King's Tiger extensively, her ambush tactics, ballista formations, and distributed corps system— they say she hand picks her units from the best outfits across all four territories. With her and Mavrick's pegasus riders by his side, Lorynce ought to tread carefully. “And after that?” She asked.

“The Crown will have no choice but to dedicate more men to the Render to replace their lost men. This means they'll withdraw their support to the Glades in the East, leaving only Marand and his rangers. We will strike from there!”

She smiled. “What is my role in all this, my liege?” Her eyes sparkled in the purple candlelights, as if she didn't already know. The scented lavender almost dispelled the Emperor's nasty aroma.

“Commander Thragde is dead. Marand put an arrow in his socket. Maybe you'll have better luck— women are smaller after all. We hand control of his Scorpion Legion to you, you will assume his role to take advantage of the chaos in the Render and cut through the Glades while the royals are distracted. Then we'll pincer through Maverick's Meadows on both sides. They'll collapse like a house of cards.” He smiled. “I can't wait to make use of those fields. A waste of land, filled with fields and pastures, it could use some proper industry. I trust that this is a responsibility you can handle?”

“Of course my liege. Which sectors of the Glades do you need conquered for this operation?”

“All of them.”

All of them? That's his 'grand strategy'? “As you wish, my liege.” She bowed.

“Good. I’ve scheduled a carriage. It’ll take you just South of Castle Greenhouse, along with the Castellan of the Glades, who I’ve grown tired of scolding for today. Outside of Marand’s archers, our spies tell us that the royal court plans to send Prince Arryk to the Glades. Meet my fat son Malkan by the ravine gates, he will bring you up to speed. After which, you will bring Rangers to heel, and the Coward Arryk too if he doesn’t run away first.” He laughed maniacally. “Oh my god! I can’t wait to hang Maverick’s head in these halls! WHO CAN STOP ME!?” He held out his arms in a shower of enthusiastic applause surrounded by ashes, shadows, dead men.

Sable I

– Constable | Amberwick –

Don’t cheer so loud, she thought to herself as the townspeople roared, the men, the woman, and of course the children, who always cheered the hardest. *They can always hear*. Perhaps almost a decade of peace had made people complacent, or even comfortable. It was a slow process– the guards slowly began to knock off more often, parents stopped teaching their children how to fight, men spending their nights in taverns instead of the workshops and target ranges.

Sable's guard would never be let down, not again. The three of them rode in unison through the settlement square, where a small withered statue of a bearded man holding books and a hammer was hailed by lanes of maple auburn leaves and hickory wood. Sable's white horse, Dyelabon, whinnied and neighed as her hooves stomped on crumpled leaves and rotten apples, which made squishes as dying cries with prints left in the ground to mark their graves. The prints would never stay for long however, the winds of change would come in, whether as a light breeze or a gust or a hurricane, and it would move the dirt back in its place. Maybe in a day, maybe in a hundred. *The wind never loses. Change is all there is.* The Morric had been fools to try and challenge their very way of life. Nomadic people, that's what they were, people of the wind, their customs and weapons had always agreed. To settle in forts and castles as if the winds couldn't make wood stone and steel tumble down... *Fools.* She was one of the fools of course, she thought it would be good to stop running, stop riding, stop the searches and the hunts and the roams, start living under the same roof with family every day. They promised her so and she believed them, she was young and wanted an escape from the hardship. Now her escape was the hardship.

The cheers began to die down as they came from the impasse of the valleys, where only a few families stood as fishermen and hunters who lay traps built from sticks in the rivers and woods. They were unarmed, for Windlocks would paint a rabbit onto the earth and dissolve a fish into the water in which it swam, so more delicate methods would be used.

Red leaves fell in Sable's hair, stuck to her auburn hair she swatted violently to get them off as they clung to her with all their might. The final cheers died out as they cleared the valley. *Home, for now.* Not for long. Only once did they ride out from the earshot of the villagers were they finally allowed to speak, and predictably, the first one was Jayce, who rode to her left on his chestnut coated horse, a fair touch darker than his copper hair. "I reckon we'll run into the shades tonight. We should have brought Cassia instead of this scholar." He was trying to make her mad, and he would succeed. He liked her, she could tell. Did she like him back? *Likely not.*

The “scholar” threw an acorn that she tucked into her saddlebag at his head. She was a skinny girl with big pretty doe eyes, and wore a beautiful windguard, a layered tangle of colorful fabrics to keep the wind and all it carried away from the skin. The dyework on her windguard was impressive, as most things Samara did, red from berries and cream from terracotta and brown from bark, elegantly layered over her neck, lush soft and gently bouncing as they rode. She was gorgeous the way Sable wished she were when she was young. Sable’s features were rough where hers were soft, eyes sharp where hers were sweet with long lashes, hair loose and tangled where hers was long and shiny, her frame lean and built where hers was willowy. That was then— now, her face had grown hollower, her cheeks wider, her eyes more sunken, her hair longer and in more auburn tussles. Her freckles began to blend in a bit more with her skin. In her youth, she would look at a girl like Samara and feel an overbearing wave of envy.

Jayce would try to win her over, Sable knew, but could he try harder? Wearing a thrown together windguard with mismatched colors, ugly coarse tough fabrics flopping in his face in the wind, he looked a jester and her a princess. “Say that again, I’ll have your head.” She spoke with so much angst. Sable was not surprised, Jayce mentioned that “loathsome” Cassia, a good shooter and Hanny’s archenemy for a reason that largely depended on her attitude that day.

“Alright, alright. Don’t throw those things, it’s impolite. Not to mention a waste of food. Throw it slower so I can catch them at least.”

Crunch crunch. She munched on the acorns. "The ants will eat them. That's not a waste. You catching them is a waste." *Are these two flirting? In front of me?* Love was in the air— Sable could not see it but when the gusts blew hard she could feel it caress her cheeks and bring water to her eyes. She almost even caught her bitter self smiling. There was never a good day to ride out not knowing if you would return, but if there was, today was it. The feel of cool breeze, the smell of maple sap and oak resin, the sound of song birds singing, though the singing songbirds struggled against the sound of the two lovebirds. The sun set on top of the hills in the distance, its orange beams shooting through the gaps in the trees and striking Sable's body all over. *The moon will be on us soon.* Dusk was settling. They rode past rivers and lakes and squirrels and mountains. The tales say the roads were made centuries ago by the Expeditionaries, a group of adventurers set on mapping all of Amberwick out and connecting it corner to corner. It was those tales that made Sable want to wear the Constables star since she was a girl. She placed a chunk of wild carrot in Dyelabon's massive jaws, patting her neck all as she did so. The sun was lower now, almost gone, and everything began to blacken.

"Here. Dismount. Locks loaded." *Click, click.* She rolled her eyes. *Of course I had to remind them.* Sable carefully tied Dyelabon's hitch around a tree three times. "We walk on foot, and we are quiet. Find bushes or trees or rocks. If they find you before we're ready, I can't save you, remember that." Sable carried a small metal box while the two ran to a batch of trees to prepare for battle and kiss in behind her back. She ran to one that had that copper shade to it and slammed a small pointy carved stone dagger in its bark where it poured out a putrid smell like a pot of rot. *Perfect.*

She climbed the large tree with the grace and speed of a chipmunk. In her younger years, before she tried being a mother, she would scale cliff faces and rocks all the time, much to her late parents' dismay. At the tip of the tree the winds began to howl at her, and slam into the tree, rocking the entire thing like a raft in the white waters. The tree almost flung her off but her grip was iron. She placed the metal box at the top before she dug the dagger into the side, and stamped her toes against the trunk as the dagger cut to the ground. A big thud rang out as she landed in a clutter of flying leaves, and as the leaves fell to the floor Sable hastily slammed the other box into the trunk and ran to the trees, grabbing on to the first sturdy branch she found. *They always forget to look up.* When the flying leaves fell to the ground, the Shades had arrived.

It takes some experience to know exactly when , but the wind gets *colder* and *dry*, like there's ice and sand in the air– it scratches the skin and makes the vision blurry. It feels off, the rest of the air is always so warm and humid, it's as if mother nature herself ran in horror when they arrived. Sable always felt she was one with nature, but she was not a mother, not anymore. She would not fail on both counts, and when shades walked the trees wailed and the leaves turned to ash. She did not run in horror, not when the shades grew close and their darkness closer, not when they hovered under the branch she desperately clung onto, her strong arm growing weaker and the weaker branch breaking off. A splinter or two fell onto the shades. They had long legs where they stomped, and looked like walking pools of tar, with demonic rainbows coursing through its dark body. Its eyes gleamed as it stomped on the ground, the leaves dissolving into ashes as it groomed the grass around it to purple, making a small ring around the monster. She could hear it *sarling*, the wretched creature. The moon was fully upon them now, and the light shone hard on all.

Wind kept blowing as gales and gusts, it grew cold and stale and dry as Sable knew it would, and the metal box at the trunk vacuumed it up before exploding in a small burst of metal shrapnel and splinters, taking the trunk out in one bite. The box up in the leaves sucked up far more air, but it wasn't rigged to blow, only to hold until its thin tin shell broke. The tall brown leaves came down to smack the ground, and the shell shattered into a thousand pieces, blasting wind in each and every direction, shooting rings of gusts like a tornado imploding from the inside, taking out the trees and the bushes in a violent burst. The shades flinched, their big purple lights that were eyes flashed and blinked rapidly in the pain. One of the four didn't even survive the explosion, being reduced to shredded ribbons on the ground.

The brass barrel glided in the wind with her body, she cocked the liver back and slid on the leaves, they formed a small whirlwind in front of her before she shot. There was the high pitched squeak of a hawk, a gorgeous shrill. She couldn't see what it fired, only the leaves getting blown away in a burst, some of them smashed into the ground. There was a purple circle of corrupted grass by the shade, but a massive circle of moving and crushed leaves beelined towards it. The shade took the compressed air and imploded into gibs. A quick flash of light came and died, and left behind scattered pools of still tar. The third took a hit from Jayce, which blew a chunk of it into the sky then from Samara, before dwindling into pieces of tar on the grassy ground. *Food for the worms.* She quickly cranked her bolt four times as the last shade approached her, its body bearing holes where she could see light. The splinters and shrapnel had cut dagger-like wounds through it. With each crank the pump of the windlock worked, and soon she fired into the last shade. In one last shrill like howl and a blast of wind, the monster's legs were shredded into rainbow ribbons, leaving it a crawling mess of arms and a head. The squeaking from the gun was music to her ears. She loved the way the trigger felt on her fingers, the way her calices ran on the edges of the brass, the way the bolt caused the gears to turn to cause the pump to suck in more air. The creature began to scream out, screeching so loud Sable couldn't wait to end it. It crawled to something, into the forest towards the treeline. "What the hell is it doing?" Jayce cried out before being aggressively shushed by Sable. In the corner of her eye she saw Samara' punch Jayce in the arm and scold him, she couldn't hear her do it, but could see the "arm thing" she did when she wanted to yell at someone. She followed the crawling shade. *I should shoot it. Why haven't I?* Something drew her to it, the curiosity was unbearable. It crawled its way to the woods before it suddenly burst, the pop emitted a flash of light, its rainbow tar body falling over the ground and corrupting the grass it fell on. Among the critters in the bushes and the trees on his sides that lay a sign, though it said nothing. She walked past it and into the woods, where she followed the vague sound of water flowing. She had been around her before— there had not been a river or a lake or a pond at this part of the woods. But there was water. Like a cat, she followed the itch her mind had until she happened upon a stone brick shrine, where water flowed out and onto the mud ground, the blue seeping into the orange leaves. The bricks held small cracks and were uniform in shape, though each

had a slightly different shade. The wind blew, she could feel the water soak the air as a moist gust hit her face and blew her hair behind her ears.

The water glowed blue, a light blue with lighter blue specks bouncing around inside. There were fairies swimming in it, it was clear and pristine enough that Sable wanted to bathe in it. She stopped closer, and in such clear water saw her reflection perfectly. She had the rough edged high cheekbones, furrowed brows, angled eyes, long nest of auburn hair. There were moles and freckles by her cheeks and nose, along with freckles. She didn't even notice the boy's face at first, his freckles aligned almost exactly with hers, his eyes the same rich bold browns, his hair all rich and rustled like hers. She gasped, and it felt like blood stopped reaching her face.

"A boy!" Samara shouted in surprise. Jayce shushed her as a mocking joke and got no response. Samara ran closer. "He must be drowning!" Sable knew somehow that he was doing just fine. She watched motionless as they dragged his faint face and dangling body out of the water. A satchel fell off of his shoulder, where a book fell to the ground. The bubbles danced in the water. Sable felt so faint. Jayce started doing chest compressions. "Breathe into his mouth too Jayce!"

A book? She walked over and held it, the cover was old and made of leather that must have seen a dozen storms and then some. Tattered, deteriorated, yet somehow, still legible. When she opened, she was surprised to see pages in perfect condition, save for the specks of dirt her fingers loosely dropped onto the pages. Her face was already feeling drained, and her fingers felt the same as she carefully flipped through.

Lumiknights of the Sacrosant

Clad in silver or gold armor, and gemstone swords, the Lumknight ride legged and winged horses through the lush Meadows. They hold flare blasters, fireworks, flashlanterns, and crossbows.

A winged horse... That was the most ludicrous part that she had read. Men in steel suits used to roam the world, it was said. The boy was holding a relic from some ancient time.

Rangers of the Terra

Donning their green cloaks, netmasks, and wooden bows, they fire arrows from the darkness of the greenery, laced with venom from plants and creatures alike. They hold bugnets, hornet hives, poison darts, and boomerangs.

A hornet hive? Was this a relic, or something from an ancient tribe that passed the map's edges? She never knew hives to be a weapon, only a home for the ants. *Some distant land, or a fairy tale this boy made up.* There could be distant lands, for all she knew, their map's edges were narrow compared to the width of the horizons.

In the North the mountains grew so tall that the wind would blow any man off, in the West the lake stretched far and wide and no one had crossed it without running into the Shades in the water, which were known to take any vessel and crush them in one blow. In the East was just an empty barren wasteland of cracked dry land that stretched beyond anyone had ever travelled, not that there had been any reason to. It was so vast yet so devoid of any life, even seeing an insect or a shrub at the map's edges was rare. *The East.* Had he somehow come from beyond the East? How he could have crossed and summoned a pool where he now lay was unbeknownst to her. The South was riddled with the massive ravines, scars seeping corruption onto the grass floor, with Shades grappling over. *A land beyond, where knights jostled on winged horses...* Sable smiled at the thought. As a child, she would always dream of catching the winds somehow, and fly amongst the birds. *God should have given Dylebon wings,* she thought. *She is beautiful enough, she deserves them.* Maybe if she found this distant land, they could put a pair on her. She flipped to a random page, where a diagram of a bronze fan lay. The illustrations were faint, rigid, and three dimensional, showing the in depth features of the fans rigid sides, wide base, and flaps. The golden etches were a great many rings, each a different size. *The Flabellum,* the page said, with nothing else. A blast of water shot out, coarse coughing came with it. His chest heaved and thudded against the leaves, smashing them into dust.

"It's working! He's awake!" Jayce chanted.

The boy's eyes opened. They were brown, so chestnut brown. The faintness returned. She remembered how her freckles matched his, like the same stars on the same skies. Her chest felt a pinch, she wanted to cover her face. It was so red, she knew, though it was hard to explain to herself why. She could barely breathe, even with the wind blasting into her throat, her body was scarce for air. She watched him rise gently, as if he had a blanket over him and just had a bad dream. The leaves blew into his auburn hair, they got stuck in the turtles within. Suddenly her legs turned to gel. The leaves flew in the air and eyes were to the sky when her face vision went black.

Percius Kenning I

– *Castellan of the Render* | *Oberath* –

“He killed them in their sleep?” Percius sounded appalled as the keys jingled in his hands. They were like the air around them— cold and wet. *A cowardly action.* He would never say it out loud, but he wished he could. “Nasty business. I wonder what could drive a man to do that.”

“I’d expect more from Carrow’s own boy.” Orellius admitted, the two of them stepped in small puddles as they heard rats scurry along the dungeon halls. *When I run this place, there won’t be puddles nor rats.* “Thank the gods Lorynce is the heir.”

He stepped into the dungeons, built centuries ago by the Chasseur, where they would throw poachers in the cells and let them die of thirst or hang them in the courtyard. The bricks were built from the black clay on the shores near the trident and laid down by the Hunter Lord's slaves, which back then were mostly the King's captured Lumiknights. *How things have changed.* Percius chuckled to himself. A droplet from the mossy ceiling above fell onto his long stringy hair as he pointed his finger and began counting the cells on the left.

One. There was a starving man, must have been in his middle ages but looked like an old crone. Limbs were paper, all thin and ghost white. *Two.* The waft of shit and vomit was so heavy in the air it hit Percius like a punch in the stomach. The girl sat sobbing in the corner, her twisted hair was so long it covered a quarter of the cell. Percius' stomach kept twisting and churning. *What did these people do?* *Three.* The man just stared. He might not have even noticed Percius. He tried not to notice their belongings, their clothes, the color of any of their eyes. War was war but that didn't mean he had to enjoy having it burned in his mind.

Four. She was way more well fed and kept, meat on her bones and color to her skin. Her skin had sparkles, her hair had a tint of green, and her eyes were tall and large. *A forest girl?* "Are you the painter?"

"Don't you mean *a* painter?" She asked with no respect.

"I need your help." He clicked the lock and opened the door. She hardly turned to look at him, staring blanking at the wall, twirling her minty hair with one hand.

"Fine. Only because you won't feed me real food if I say no, right?" She spat at him.

"I was a prisoner of war once. I didn't get 'real food', only sawdust mixed with a bit of stems and leaves and a tiny *tiny* pinch of flour. But they called it bread— they being *your* people, the same ones who killed my father." Percius surprised himself with how steady his voice was, in the past when he would talk about such things his fists would turn to steel. "I'm not going to hurt you, but you ought to be more grateful. Look to the people on your left and right. You could look like them."

She sneered at him. "Only because *he* hasn't come down yet." He felt something weird in his stomach.

“That crazy son of a bitch.” Orellius complained.

Whatever he was doing in these cells, Percius wanted to know nothing and have no part. “It’ll be alright. If you help me, I can protect you.”

“You *can* ’t.” She cried out, like a wounded animal. “He does what he wants with all of us. If I couldn’t paint I’d be spider food, and that’s if I was lucky.”

But you can paint. And I need *the* painter.”

“Why do you say *the* painter? Wouldn’t any painter do?” He didn’t answer, only gently lifted her up by the arm. He felt poor— she was about his little sister’s age. She groaned as he lifted her up and the three of them began to walk. “Is painting some sort of impossible craft nowadays? None of you can paint? I’ll teach you, how’s that? Then you can just kill me and be done with it. What’s that saying— give a man a deer he feeds for a day, teach him how to hunt and he feeds for a...”

Her voice faded to the background as Percius guided her through the halls. It wasn’t any painter they needed, nor one with great imagination or experience. This girl had some sort of talent— a steady hand that allowed her to draw with the uniform precision and speed of a machine. Of course, they had machines for this, but not here, they were put together thousands of relays away. The uniformity was critical, more than the eye for color or the taste for expression. “I’m not just some nobody here, I can change things.” He finally explained to her, though he felt it was partially just out of guilt. “I’ll be the head of the garrison here, in charge of defense, repairs, maintenance, construction...” A spit ball slammed into his eye as he spoke, cutting him off.

“Bastard! You run this chamber of horrors? I may suffer for all my life but you’ll suffer for eternity after you die— sometime soon I hope!”

“I can take out her tongue if you wish.” Orellius offered as he unsheathed a dagger from his waistband.

“No– no! Absolutely not. Not one more word from either of you.” He snarled and tugged her along, less gently this time. He spoke directly to the girl. “I understand your anger, but I’m following my sword duty to my people by protecting what is now my holding. There is more to this stronghold than war. This place will be needed to hunt, to facilitate trade, to hold criminals, to train soldiers. I’m not just a soldier, I’m a mason, a smith, a builder,—”

“A bastard, a fat bastard with a fat nose and two chins.” She complained. *Did I have too much supper last night?* He joked to himself. “Tell yourself whatever you want.” She said, “Where will you make me put you? A castle? A bridge? A palace? You Wychen love dancing in your palaces. I hate painting palaces by the way, not that any of you care.”

“You’ll see when we get there.” Orellius explained. They climbed a tower of stairs from the dungeon, each step polished and sleek black, the torches made from bone. When they summited the steps the full view from the parapets of Ashrend brought the full prowess of the stronghold in view—centuries of history told through the various facilities in all corners of his eye. The three were running now, passing by sprinting soldiers all the while, some of whom carried wounded.

Bone and blood, and ash and clay. The architecture held their symbols well, from the walls down to the decorations. In the courtyard were many tanning stands and fat renderers. In times of peace, men would be walking by with buckets full of melted fat and buckets of glands and meats. The meats would be cut piece by piece from the monsters in the very butcher halls underneath their six boots where men would hack with massive blades cut from bone at chunks of meat and talons.

Those were in times of peace. The massive fireworks and fireballs and flares launched from the Commonwealth ships below looked like shadows of the sun in the air as they hurled themselves fruitlessly at the Stronghold walls. The sun and its followers all kissed the already blood red sky, which had been tainted by the dust-off of all the minerals within the black clay all over the Render. *Doomed by the gods*, Wychen and Sacroscant often said. Percius had to squint as he ran, he could hear the valiant Musketeers fire off the parapets into the crowds of unwelcome visitors below while they reached the next tower, Percius almost slamming his body into the door to let them into cover. The girl and his comrade exhaled in relief. He was thankful to be in the second line of walls and not the third, for he heard Bladeslingers were already coming over the outermost line.

Percius grabbed a torch that glew amethyst and ushered them to follow him down the stairs, going so fast down his feet were close to flying as he skipped down. The ground rumbled and boomed still, and the sounds of yelling and clamoring echoed through every hall. This was the third time the royal regiment attempted to retake the stronghold, and each time was poorer than the last. *No inventive strategy, no tricks up their sleeves, this is what makes us Wychen and them... them.*

“Can you really make a painting in under five minutes? With no mistakes, perfect straight lines, the like?” Orellius asked. She uncomfortably nodded. “We’ll see for ourselves, and if your talents prove as useful as I keep hearing, then we can offer you some better amnesty, conditions, and maybe a paid position here at Ashrend if the assimilation protocols get implemented.”

“Fuck all that. I want to see my family. Don’t tempt me with constellation prizes.”

“Where does your family live?”

“In god’s clouds next to the pearly gates.” She looked at Percius’ musket. “Can I be accommodated?” Percius wasn’t amused. “It’s fine, you two will bore me to death anyway.” The moss grew thinner and the air grew dryer. They emerged from the dungeon halls and into a polished stone corridor where half a dozen Musketeers marched down with haste in their glowing purple crystal shells, and they were followed by an alchemist sprinting with three massive spiders on his leashes, each more hairy and gnarly than the last.

“Musketeers, remarkable aren’t they? Adept equally with melee as they are with gunplay. I heard that muskets have almost completely replaced bows, not just for warfare, but also for hunting.” Percius said.

“Not where I’m from, they don’t.” She spat. “You people need handicaps for everything, can’t shoot a bow, can’t paint, can’t show manners to a woman either. The thought of you baboons running throughout our woods and putting metal balls into our animals disgusts me.”

“Would it be that much better if we used big wooden sticks instead?” Orellius laughed, his big beard catching some of the spit as he did so.

“Here we are,” Percius declared. They stood among a three way intersection, the left pointed to a trophy room where the heads of the greatest behemoths in the Render lay from across dozens of generations, to right the studies and anatomy of all sorts of beasts across Oberath. Percius stepped forward, where a big purple brick wall with a massive silver moon lay in front of them, he pressed hard against it and it opened. The halls were silver and white, marble and gold. Paintings dropped everywhere, of forests full of critters, of waterfalls and rivers, of animals and man, of happy feasts and sorrow endings. One had a prince in shining armor and no face, one of a witch stirring a cauldron of cold green goo, her hat hovering over her face, one had a river where a reaper rowed using the stick of a scythe as an oar. They were large and small, green, blue and gray and red. “Fetch the Arachinist. The largest, most vicious venomous ones we can find.” It was more about the psychological aspect than anything, nobody could ever suspect such a thing. A morbid part of him wanted to see their faces when it happened, but he shoved that thought deep down.

“Choosing which one?” A sneering voice followed by a chuckle sounded out behind him. Percius said the quickest prayer of his life before turning around to greet the, apparently, three of his new visitors. The Artificer stood among him first, the man was a foster brother among Carrow’s two boys where the mad cunt Loryence had essentially adopted him as his little partner in crime. Loryence allegedly found him face down in the snow while he and Malkan had been mountaineering, and afterwards they nursed him back from the brink of death, unfortunately. He had never seen his eye before, only heard the tales, but there it was, eaten from his head by frostbite, and had now become a massive white orb, like a snowball. The rest of his face on that side was cracked black, but the right of his was fair and ghostly, and he had half silver medium long silver hair carelessly dropping over the side of his head. Besides him was his infamous enthusiastic assistant, a girl named *Bellacca*, she had gorgeous long silver hair and purple eyes, along with her smooth gray skin. Her ears were long and slanted and carried a huge amount of different jewels. A big metal boiler laid strapped to her back, for what purpose Percius did not know. He heard she was the Artificer’s lover, but he really doubted someone would make love to that creature. The third was Loryence himself, standing to the Artificer’s left, a handsome man in his mid twenties, he had jagged teeth and big slanted eyes, along with a perfect middle part. He was the tallest in the room, and had the best clothes by far– a purple embroidered tunic with dragons on the front– but that was to be expected for the heir of the empire. “It doesn’t matter which one.” The Artificer continued, hissing like a snake. “They won’t even take a second look. Who would?”

Percius bowed to the heir. “My prince, I’m pleased to make your acquaintance. I’m–”

“I know who you are.” Lorynce dismissed him. “Castellan of the Render, why would you want to oversee such a godforsaken place, so full of beasts and red horror? Why not the beautiful shores of the Brynnic, or the idyllic trees of the Terra, or better yet why not at our beautiful home itself? The Emperor was quite fond of Lord Kenning, if I do recall.”

The most godforsaken part of this place is to your right. “My place is needed where it matters most, on the battlefield. And where you see beasts and horrors, I see meat that feeds thousands, bones that can be made into weapons and tools and glue and fertilizer, fat that can be turned to fuel, clay that can be turned to brick. This place stands among the greatest beasts Oberath has seen for a thousand years, a hundred hunters could be surrounded by ten thousand of the Render’s most ferocious and pick them off one by one behind these walls, turning them into supper in the mealhalls and goods in the market without a single one making it inside. The Commonwealth think that their attack will not be repelled, as if they have the strength of ten thousand beasts! And we have more than a hundred hunters— two thousand Gunknights armed and strong, not to mention the war machines and monsters we have at our disposal.” Percius fell to one knee in front of the prince. “My prince, I am your man. I will destroy the attackers alongside you, and, when the Commonwealth is toppled and you rule Oberath as the new Shade Emperor, I will run your Render for you, turning what you see as a backwater alley for savages into a prosperous state, shipping goods to the states across the world!”

“New Shade Emperor?” The prince glared, his eyes grew bigger and angrier, and his hand hopped to the hilt of his hammer, a big massive anvil on a stick, with obsidian skin and amethyst jewels near its head. “Are you insinuating that his liege might find his end soon? That would be treason, I believe.”

“My liege,” Orellius begged. “He did not mean as such. He was only pointing out, that, well as time goes, old men tend to—”

“It’s alright.” Percius called his man down, and spoke to the liege himself. “I meant no offense to my prince. Honest. Like I said— I’m *your* man.” He puffed up his chest and stood tall. The sound of his breathing got loud.

The three of them began to snicker. “Don’t toy with the boy.” Bellacca laughed. “He’s about to wet himself.”

“Rise, *friend*.” Lorynce laughed. Percius staggered awkwardly to his feet and grabbed his glove, before he was rapidly hoisted up like a sailor with his flag. “The Wythen could always use more men with real grit like you. Not like these other fools, they grovel at my feet. You grovel at my feet too. Do you know why I’m not bothered by you like I am with the fools? ‘I’m your man.’” He began to holler, the Bellacca did as well, even the painter girl. The Artificer didn’t only look at him with his one good eye creepily. “All the others,” Lorynce continued. “They just kiss my ass. You claim you are my man. That’s your vote of confidence. What I hear is that you can run the Render right? One day, my father put a boy raised by the father of a pasturage in charge of the Brynnic. He had wits and charisma, and a certain amount of enthusiasm for conquest we love to see! But, the Brynnic is not his way. My father made a mistake.” Percius opened his mouth to say something but Lorynce shushed him. “No, if you spoke anything about what I just said I’d have to cut out your tongue. The pasturage boy ended up dying in a shipwreck from a seastorm he didn’t foresee. He could govern and kill and be dutiful but we killed him with our philosophical negligence. My brothers can be like my father, he may have put you here but you have yet to earn my vote of confidence. So, will you run my Render for me?”

“I’ll run it.” Percius pledged enthusiastically. “I’ll run the fuck out of it.” Lorynce stared at him for a moment.

“Why should I believe you?” He said slowly and equally skeptical as he was curious.

Percius stood up straight and cleared his throat. “Onwards, you have this!” The Painter said cruelly.

“When I arrived here, the boys were using their horns to call the beasts in, sending out decoys to lure them into their trap. They had stripped the old balistas with greater shinier more modern ones that would fire five times as fast and ten times as accurately. They sounded their horns and sent out decoys, bringing hundreds of the beasts around the local area. Before the new turrets, it would take a hundred good bladeslingers, and a hundred garrison units as well. The boys celebrated, they shipped all their massive chunks of meat back for the Wythen people, bringing back all the gold in return. They gorged on sweets and ale, not knowing the travesty they caused.”

“Travesty?”

“They hunted four species down to extinction. Another nineteen almost as near. Each had a unique variety of bone, of tusk, of meat flavor, of value to us. We will never get to use the four, and not the nineteen for some time. If I had arrived a week later, we would most likely have lost most of the beast variety save the spawns that sell for coppers compared to the others.”

Lorynce glared at him. “Who caused this outrage?”

“A green spoiled boy named Marvin. Runs a crew of his minions as they drink and shoot their way out of everything.”

“Hang him.”

“I already had him demoted, sir—” He looked into Lorynce’s eyes. They craved. Percius remembered Marvin’s snobby face calling him weak for having a bit of foresight. *Fool*. He thought of having the royal family at court, with a crowned Lorynce feasting at his tables. The meat is collected and fat is churned, but the beasts are sustained and they grow and can foster, in a new cycle of land of hunting that combines the technological might of the Wychen and the martial talent of the Chasseur. A new way of life for them all. But for Marvin? Percius affirmed his stance. “Consider it done.” He nodded to Orellius to have it done. He turned to look at the Artificer. *Would he fit in this new way?*

The Artificer would hunt every species to extinction, save two, and then keep them all in a labyrinth and call himself the new god of beasts. Percius’ new way of running things won’t have any room for a man like that. “I underestimated you.” He called out to the Arachinist. “Fetch webbed spiders. Not Venomous ones.” The monster smiled. “I am pleased you are among us.”

I wish I could say the same.

Lorynce continued as he walked off. “I’ll trust you can hold this fortress for me. I must depart, my invasion force is leaving.”

“Your invading force? We are being invaded right now?”

“I know, I’m deeply sorry. But, we must depart for a naval invasion of the Redstone Bridge. Me and my Amphibious Raiders will take the bank, attack from behind, then come down the bridge and relieve the invaders.” *Smart man.*

“I can guide you to the underwater boats. They are experimental, I’ll warn you.”

He did not turn his head to respond. “I have faith in the engineers. I have no need for an escort. Good luck, friend, and the same for your sister.”

Domeric Raimes II

– *Bladeslinger* | *Oberath* –

By the time Domeric had the parapet’s brick edge in his hands, Hadrian’s slender pale legs waited for him. He smiled, his lips were red. *So red, and wide...* He reached his hand out, it was only then Domeric realized the boy had climbed with no gloves. His skin was cold and so soft, except where the rope had branded calices into his palms and fingers. Domeric was hoisted up. “There you go! You beat your brother even though you froze for most of it, he was leading by so much too! I’m proud. It’s like that old wive’s tale about the turtle and the hare. Or, was this more like the other way around?” He put his bright slender finger, and its long nail, against his lip as he sarcastically made a look. Kieran reached the top as well, but refused Domeric’s hand and insisted on hauling over on his own, he crudely stomped into the wall and used his arms to lift himself over with great struggle. They then began to run for the nearest guardhouse, keeping their heads low like angry geese. His boots bounced like pillows on the ground.

“They don’t know we’re here!” Domeric said.

“You don’t know that!” Kieran panted, Domic wanted to grab his hand and tug him along but his lungs were failing as well. *I can still taste the sea.* He nervously scanned the battlements. *If they know we’re here, where are they? Why have they not begun shooting at us yet.* The sky heard the question and called its answer. The unbearable churning of gears finally cut off by a piercing whistling that cut the clouds and soared through the red sun-kissed sky. Giant white balls hurled their way towards the fortress, with trails that broke off into sparks that looked like small stars. When they reached the wall, they sizzled and sparkled in the air before growing into a massive flash. Domic flailed his arm in front of his face, but he was too slow. The last thing he saw was his brother, Hadrian’s shiny obsidian eyes, and a glimpse of his forearm.

Before a sheet of white took his eyes, as if they covered his face in snow. While Domic blindly flailed about, a second whistle sounded followed by a sharp metal bite that tore into the side of his stomach, causing his legs to buckle under. The brick ground slammed him in his right cheekbones. He screamed and groaned and moaned and cursed. He felt Kieran’s grubby hands grab his boots and tuck hard, they scraped the floor as he was dragged like a chair. He heard Kieran shouting as his back slid on the floor and the wisps of Hadrian’s throwing blades, and the cracks of gunpowder. The noise and pain was maddening. The light was worse. *It’s so blinding.* He felt himself walking into the sun, the sheer brightness getting closer and closer. A girl’s shadow appeared in front of the white rays, she smiled with her quaint lips, her navy hair dancing, the prismatic ends twisting around the sun like tentacles. *Battle. I know, I know.*

The dragging got harder before things dimmed. Kieran was towing him all the way to what seemed to be a nearby guardhouse, with the dark spruce wood door and curved mossy brick frame greeting him first, followed by the smell of candles and damp air. His brother was panting and gasping when he kicked the door open and continued to drag Domic inside the guardhouse, the dimly lit black hall had water dripping on their heads from the ceiling, some of them falling on Domic’s face to join his tears.

He used his glove to rub them off. *Kieran shouldn't be seeing me like this*, he thought, though it was too little too late. There was some mauve torchlight, along with lavender candles next to plates of bread, chains that dangled from above like strings with no puppets, and a weapons rack that was already emptied save a broken mace, a musket with no stock, and an axe that was missing a head. Domicer didn't even notice he was still groaning in pain until Kieran put a hand over his mouth. "Shhhh! I know it hurts, but you need to be quiet. Please!" For some reason, that made him want to groan louder. He heard Tavick scream and curse, and the clicking stampede of spiderlings.

"Shoot them! To the left and straight ahead!" Eidrick yelled. He heard the thrums of the strings on their crossbows, and their arrows whizzing, and the crashing of a shell of metal onto rock. Volleys of musketballs flew, one through the dark oak door and inside the guardhouse hall, exploding into the wall above Domicer and showering his hair with debris.

"*Shit.*" Kieran muttered with dread as Domicer held his hand over the wound— a ball dug a small trench in his side right below his ribcage. He tried to press against it, but it was squishy and gross and burned the harder he pressed, so he stopped. "I think there's more. *They're coming*" That made Domicer's throat get icy and dry. He coughed coarsely, some blood wetting his mouth as he did so. Kieran ran up to where wooden boxes of musketballs and salted meats lay and jumped on top to peer through a small window, the red sunny sky shone gently onto his black irises. Domicer felt his fingers fumbling around for his blood vial while Kieran scanned. *Under my hip, always. Always.* He found the vial with his right hand while covering the wound with his left. He used his mouth to open the cork as quietly as possible, though the 'pop' still sounded louder than the fireworks. *I hate fireworks.* They had done nothing to blind the enemy and did everything to blind Domicer. "Dom, they see me. I'm going to run out."

"They'll shoot you if you try." *Don't leave me, please.*

"They'll miss," he said, sweat forming beads on his temple, falling onto the floor to become part of the puddles. "If I leave, they'll chase me and not notice you." He kicked the boxes to Domicer's corner, tucking him in a shadow. "We'll be back!" He sprinted, a ball whizzed through the door and almost caught him in the back, only it missed and hit the doorframe.

Domeric poured the blood vial over the wound, it smoked and sizzled like bacon in grease, causing his body to heave and him to bite his lip through the pain. It was hot, and he could feel the flesh grow back and the new skin slowly patch over– though it would be redder and looser and scarred for the rest of his life– it was sharp and jabbing and the cold air seeping inside made it burn more. He winced but stuffed his hand in his mouth when he heard the running got closer. *They* had heavy boots laced with steel on the bottom that left massive thuds on the ground. The door kicked open. The gun barrel slowly came into view, the candlelight shone in the reflection under the ironsight. He bit into his hand so hard blood started to gush into his mouth like juice from a pomegranate. It added more pain but made the pain quieter, and amongst all the gunfire and wheezing arrows and clashes of swords and blades, it was quiet enough.

The Musketeer's breath smoked in the air, the mist shot out and rose up along with the candle's smoke. The barrel was shaking and the ironsight swayed left and right. The Musketeer began to clear the corners, but completely missed Domeric sitting behind the boxes in the shadows with his legs tucked tightly into his chest and his hand tucked ferociously in his mouth. "Where did he go?" A thick deep gruff dotted Domeric's skin with bumps. He struggled to control his breathing. He remembered what his captain always told him– *slow deep breaths, not fast shallow ones.*

"Don't know!" A scratchy squeaky whimper, it grated him in all the wrong ways. Two more stepped in, they all had long silver hair that dangled under their metal helmets, their crystal mail and shadow plate glowed purple, with small purple wisps floating around them like fleas around a carcass. He bit so hard, the blood now seeped onto the floor. *I am as quiet as a mouse.* "Those *barbarians*, they're mad! Our turrets blasted most of them to bits but they keep coming, and they're over the wall!"

Our hunting season has no end. A strange feeling of pride came upon Domeric, that he could not describe– that he was for a moment a proud bloodhound, and not a gracious knight, that it gave him sudden joy and strength. As he endured he glared at the clueless enemy from his shadowy corner. He could feel his head start to pound with anger, and it made him dizzy. He was so mad, he strangely wanted some of the pain to return, just so he could hate more.

They stood so proud in their shiny silver, with their big guns, fancy crystal armor, and vindictive violet eyes. *How many comrades have they killed*, Domic wondered? *How many villages have they plundered, how many innocents enslaved?* The teeth tore into the tender flesh of his hands. *I'm not groaning anymore, why am I still biting?* As his jaws unclenched off his fist, they left marks, like lovers. He looked over to the other side of the room, where a rich purple banner with the crow and raven flying side by side, where the blades of the Chasseur and steed of the Sacrosanct belonged. The rage was driving him now, it was almost as hard to keep quiet as the pain.

As the vicious trio moved forward, an arrow flew into the shoulder plate of one of the Musketeers, bouncing off a clattering to the ground. A throwing blade flew into the room next, bouncing off of the wall and hitting the musketeer perfectly under his shoulder, where it caught in the crystal mail under his armpit, emerging through his shoulder blade and almost reaching his neck. *Hadrian*. He opened his mouth to make a sound of agony in the air and a pool of blood on the floor, before he fell to the ground. One of the other Musketeers stepped over the dying man and tried to aim his gun through the doorway, but was immediately porcupined with four arrows as he tried, three of them sticking into his plate and one in his visor. He flopped on the ground like a stupid fish. *Reaped and sowed, reaper*. Domic smiled.

The metal echo in the small hall died with the fiend when Domic felt the last patch of his skin finally grow back, covering the gash in his side. There was a final storm of pain, but when it weathered he could feel strength shine on himself once more. The third Musketeer jumped into the doorway with his big stocky legs. An arrow flew into his plate, he winced in pain and staggered backwards before he planted his feet, wedging the stock against his shoulders, and firing through the doorway, the crack was near deafening as the sound bounced and bounced across the walls.

Someone screamed a stark shrill in anguish, the screaming soon turned to whimpering before turning to silence. *Was that Leylo?* Domic's heart felt heavy with sorrow, his blood pulsed in anger as it rushed to the muscles in his arm and the veins in his hands. He bellowed, kicked the boxes out of his way, and flung his body at the armored bully. When he slammed into the man, his gun went off into the ceiling, though Domic's screams and howls were louder than the barrel's boom. His head hit the brick ground, but he partly did not even feel it. The slick hiss of his blade unsheathing was almost as loud as his tongues. Domic was a snake, and his bite would be fatal. He snarled as he used one hand to push the bully's head into the floor while using the other to jab his blade into his crystalmail. *Die!*

The armor was strong, the mail caught the first strike. *Shit!* His heart sank. *No, no, no.* This time he would die. His elbow bent and his forearm descended.

The blade chipped its top three teeth and left marks from its bite in the bully's plate. A metal glove smacked his face and blood dotted the ground. The pain jolted through his body, and it caused hurt and hurt caused rage, and rage was all Domic needed to plunge the second daggerpointer under the bully's flailing arm. The gray man went down in shock and agony, screaming and sliding down the crow's banner, leaving a trail of red on the purple. *As it should be.* If only his blood was blue too.

When Domic stepped closer to finish the job, the man took off his helmet. His eyes pleaded. He held his hands up in the air and winced, tears flowing down his cheeks. Domic just stared for a moment. His hands tightened around the blade.

"Please." The dying man cried out. Domic froze. "Please."

His voice was desperate and raspy. A great blue meteor sword suddenly crushed the bully's skull. Eidrick pulled it out, leaving a geyser that shot out blood and gross smells. The pool began to spill over onto Eidrick's blue boots. His face was like his sword—stern, hard, and dribbling green spider juices. Eidrick didn't say anything to Domic, but the look said everything. It felt sore, and made his legs feel jiggly. *Why did I freeze? Why am I still afraid?*

"They killed Leylo." Eidrick spat bitterly. "Fucking bastards. Was it that one?" He pointed to the body that was tainting his boots.

Domeric nodded. “We made it even.” He proclaimed with hollow pride. The Wycken were dishonorable cheats, Domeric saw it now, clearer than the red sunny sky. Leylo hit the man first, but Leylo had arrows, and the man had bullets and crystal armor. Eidrick panted and dragged his feet over to the door and shut it, his blue cloak dragged onto the mossy rocks on the ground. Mushrooms already began to sprout on the dead men, in jagged heads of orange that spewed the must of mold.

Tavick burst through the door with his boot, the oak wood slamming into the brick stone walls. Behind him, Mathis dragged Leylo’s corpse, which rolled a red carpet out for the Wycken to come in.

“We have to get deeper in the fortress...” Tavick stopped when he noticed a table with bread by the candlelight, next to it was a plate of raspberries, strawberries and pomegranates, crystal salts, and beast sweetmeats. As if it had eyes of its own, Tavick’s stomach grumbled, and he bounced over to the table and took the first loaf, holding it over the candle to give the crust a nice roast with the lavender smoke blasting it. Eidrick, once he realized there was food nearby, pounced like a dog on the second loaf, running it in the sweetmeat in a bowl beside before tearing into it with his mouth, ripping it in half, his nails digging into the dough like claws.

“You gluttons– we don’t have time for this!” Domeric’s voice must have been overpowered by the smacking of lips and chomping of teeth. He sighed before feeling the empty pit in his stomach, it twisted and turned, begging for bread. When had he last eaten a proper meal, that wasn’t salted frog legs or stale oats? *Fine*. He stepped over and grabbed the third loaf, dipped it into the red fruit juices, soaking it red and heavy and sweet– he could already taste the sugar on his tongue. He then dragged it across crystals of salt, as they clung to the crust and mixed in with the crimson fruit juices. It was tart and tangy, sweet and savory, and for half a heartbeat Domeric was home by the fire eating supper with his brother again. He rubbed the salty red off his lips, it smeared. “There were three in here. Including the one who got Leylo.” He spoke solemnly to Mathis, who sat staring blankly into the ground..

“They’re dead now.”

“The boy did most the work for that one.” Eidrick admitted between bites. He grabbed a near empty chalice of stale wine and gulped it before burping. “You should eat Mathis, it’s a long day ahead of us.” He sighed, his eyes watered a bit and his shoulders rolled back. “I’m sorry, he was a good man. This is a fucked up situation, for all of us.”

“I remember sparring with him in the yard. He had a budding talent, with much potential. We were deprived of him, but the Lords gained a great soul.” Tavick knelt to the ground and rolled his eyelids closed. He then turned to Domic, his ocean eyes upwards at him. “Is Eidrick speaking true?” Tavick looked Domic in the eyes, proud but concerned. “Did you kill him?”

“No, Eidrick finished it. I stabbed him under the arm.” Domic thought he would be speaking with pride, not disgust, but the memory of sticking the blade into his flesh upset his stomach more than the days of hunger. It smelled like metal, and when he stuck it inside and tried to twist it around, it felt like he was churning something into paste. It made his mouth taste weird, even with all the bread and fruit and crystal salt.

“Alright,” he gave the boy a tap on the shoulder. Domic gave his captain a nod. Tavick turned to the other two, who were still distracted by feeding or grieving. He knelt down closer to Domic’s ear. “Sorry I said *bastard* earlier. I didn’t know you were there.” He tapped him on the shoulder. *The old man doesn’t realize when he makes things worse.* The captain turned. “Musketeers and turrets are all over the inner walls now. There are dozens across, taking pot shots at us while we have no hope of hitting them. They came up behind us too, while you and Kieran were in the house, along with swarms of spiders.” He sighed. “Me and Eidrick and Mathis killed two of them before we fended them off. ‘Light resistance’ the scouts said. They were wrong.”

“What of Hadrian? What of the regiment?”

“Hadrian jumped off the wall to shake the bullets, he skated on the edges, I’m not sure where he is now. As for the regiment, the pegasus riders have stormed the walls and the Bladeslingers have made it through the gates.” A wide smile emerged on Domic’s face. “But...”

“You should see for yourself lad.” Tavick gestured to a ladder on the ground.

A droplet fell onto his hair as he spoke. Domic picked it up, his arms had become paler and whiter, its veins thicker and fat thinner. He laid it gently against the sill and stumbled over the top, where his ruby eyes peered into the red sky onto the fort's bricks, all stained in blood. Where the gate used to stand now lay a massive wreckage of splinters and wood and steel. The crows already began feasting on the dead, the Bladeslinger's black furs were all drenched in their demise, their blades twisted and broken and shattered, far away from arm's reach, if they still had them. A torso hanging over the parapet, an arm on the ground, a pool of guts– the crows had them all. *My people are not food*, he wanted so badly to weep. Great warriors deserved to be buried by their homes. The crows pecked. A pair of wings could be seen on the ground as well, right beside the horse. *Amelie, you free people... Why did you bring me back here?*

Purple men marched all around, their spiders crawled around them. He saw a woman on a flying horse bash into a man holding a purple shield. She had golden armor and a glowing sword and slashed the man's face clean off, even breaking the visor. Another purple man with a silver mask and a silver crate... *or boiler?... on his back holding a gun with a dragon's mouth for the barrel and holding it up against the flying horse.* Domic listened to the sound of the mouth wheezing, then watched as it shot a breath of purple smoke into the horsewoman, who began clawing at the air madly. The horse's wings began to spasm, and the golden armor made her look like a shooting star when her body slammed into the bricks. The purple plume of smoke made Domic shiver all over, and the ladder shivered with him. *Another one of the Artificer's toys. He won't find this to be so fun when I reach him. I'll kill him, I know, I know!*

"Look at that." Eidrick whimpered.

"The Wychen will pay for this." Domic growled and snarled, spit shot out through the window. The ladder fell backwards suddenly, causing him to stagger and land on his hands and kneecaps. He didn't feel the pain, only the heat.

"This wasn't them. It was our lords!" Eidrick yelled. "They knew it was a suicide mission, and they did it anyway. Domic, while you and Kieran were in this hall we scaled the watchtower to stab the turret gunner in the back." He turned to the captain. "Tell him what happened!"

Domeric was confused. “Did one of you get injured?”

“No.” Tavick’s fingers pitched his temple. “There was no gunner.”

His legs almost spilt onto the ground, like waves. “*No.*”

“Black magic.” Tavick shook his head. “The Artificer’s games. That’s why we must put a stop to him today.”

“Are we in the Render, or faery tale land?” Eidrick scoffed. “We lost two already, we should save our skins now before it’s too late, this is doomed captain and you know it.”

“I know nothing. And neither do you.” Tavick said.

“They said the fireworks would protect these ships. They said they would cover our landing and our storming of the fortress. They said the new ships would be near impenetrable, that they would destroy the walls and we could walk in! We have worse armor, worse weapons, half of us died from the turrets and the monsters! We killed five of them, and I’ll bet that’s going to be this regiment’s best. This is just another failed hope, just like the *last two times!*”

“No, you’re wrong!” Tavick shouted with bitterness. The veins in his head bulged against his skin.

“Tell yourself that, go ahead. ‘*Do your duty.*’ We went into the boiler war with ten, now we’re down to three, and we had to pick up three *barbarians* as well!” Domeric glared at him. He felt so stupid when he realized his hands went to the blood tattoo near his torso... *Get a grip.* “Do you actually think we can win this thing? Do any of you!?” He held his arms out and roared. “I’m so sick of getting soaked and shot and starved for a lost cause! I almost drowned, I was in chains for months, I took an ball to the shoulder... Tavick! Use your head! How many of our force is left do you think? Half? If even? I miss being warm by the fire. I miss my home. I miss my *family*. I shouldn’t be dying in a land I don’t even recognize!”

“Of course we can win!” Kieran yelled. “The only reason we haven’t is because of doubters such as yourself.”

“You’d think that, wouldn’t you? I give you and your brother two more battles before you’re fish or crow food. I hope the mushrooms your corpse farms are brighter than you are.” He leaned down to the captain like a devil, put his hand on his shoulder and spoke softly into his ear. “You know I’m right, we’ve seen the attack fail, almost all the Bladeslingers are dead! The rest will retreat soon enough, what’s the harm if we just see the signs and retreat early? We can fire our black flares for the others before we run! This is not cowardice, it will *save* lives.” *Get out of his ear.*

“No, no... we can’t.” Tavick’s self preservation was winning, Domic could see it on his face and in his eyes. “Our duty, our cause Eidrick, the gods will never forgive us. We have to stand for what’s right, even if it kills us. Think about the rest of the world!”

“Don’t think about the *gods*. They will not be moved by your sacrifice, and neither will the world. You’re killing us all for a fairy tale. Think about you, or me, or Domic and his brother, or Mathis’ mother. I’m sure she won’t mind losing all three sons for standing up for what’s right. What’s really going to matter? Whose lives are we actually improving? If we stay, will it change a thing? I don’t want to die for a lost cause, and I know you *don’t* either, Captain!”

On the captain’s belt were his rapier, a glowing blue *flash-lantern*, and several flare guns, one blue, one white, one black. His hands began to hover around the black grip. “Captain!” Domic cried out. “I looked up to you. I thought if I did, I could become a good soldier like you.”

“A good soldier looks out for his men. I said I was comfortable dying for this, but maybe I want to get the chance to be old too. I’ve fought for so long. I want the rest of you to live long as well. I don’t mind dying with a sword in hand, my son died long ago, and the Reavers have my wife. But... if dying is going to be so meaningless, if it’s just padding for the command’s numbers...” His head hung down. “I will not drag the rest of you to the grave with me, just because I’ve lost everything. I may be old and bitter, but you all... I will not see your lives wasted on account of *this*.”

He pointed the flare gun at the window. Domic wanted to wilt away. "What about the rest of our comrades who survived, who are over the wall as we speak?" A madness suddenly took over him. He sprinted over and swatted the gun out of the Captain's hand. "They are counting on us to help them! We are the Commonwealth, we are four kingdoms, we dominate this world! The only way a handful of schemers could destroy us all is because we don't all stand on our principles! Has justice, and courage deserted you all?" He shouted angrily. "These people." He pointed to the dead Reaver, the one he as good as slayed himself. "These people, they killed Mertos! They killed Leylo! They killed hundreds of thousands! If they conquer the world, where will we run to? Eidrick, are you going to just hide in the barn with your family while the Empire comes brazing down your fields? I will die doing the right thing before I become a slave or a coward."

Suddenly, among the spider hisses and the gunshots, the harmonic hums of the pegasus' wings began to take over the air. The beautiful screeching of bladeskates on the wall, the strums of the crossbows. "They're here, our comrades!" He shouted, his arms now wide. The kneeling Kieran looked up to him. So did Mathis. *They all are.* He felt like the world was burning behind him as he chanted. "Our comrades are here! We can beat them, we can drive them out of our home!"

Tavick took another rough harsh breath. His hand unsurely hovered over the pommel of his comet sword.

"No... no!" Eidrick shouted. "*Please.*"

The comet sword leapt out of the sheath and danced in the air, like Amelie's hair.

Reese I

– *Vanchist Armorer Corp* | *Oberath*–

Reese couldn't decide which part of today he hated more: working out the tedious supply lines of caravans and boats crossing hills, rivers, and forests, or knowing the King himself was coming, along with the immensely pleasurable company of his humble family. The dread hung over him like a noose that gently hugged around his shoulders and pulled him tightly close. Frustrated, Reese sighed and felt his eyes begin to droop and his head become heavy. He longed to open a hard leather book cover, to feel pages and their parchment between his two fingers, to hear the delicate soft sound of the flipping and softly slamming into each other. He wanted the hours to turn into days, to live one life before his next tedious task. The King wanted to be immortal, it was rumored. Let him seek his immortality in magic stones or prophecies, Reese holds his in a fistful of leather and cooked wood.

"Are you even paying attention?!" the Vanguard commander barked. *She roars like a tiny lion.* He smiled to himself. They were planning an attack. *No, wait, a counter attack.* If he had known that battle planning was this much of a nuisance he would have chosen a different career path– he should be tracing blueprints into scrolls, not paths down roads and towns besides a bunch of funny looking chess pieces. Funniest of all of them was his territory's mascot– the great Pearfin of the Shoals, fat, covered in nets, and had big orange eyes. His brave allies– a pegasus with a sword in its head and a triad of teeth edged blades, painted with blue and blood paint respectively– stood firmly next to his gracious fish god.

A counter attack... Reese analyzed the board, hopefully before Aretmis' turned red and blew up the whole room. The Royal Regiment and its horses and blades were crossing the *Sickle*, a curved lake born from a river of seawater above it. Its ships all poised in a ring of knives around Castle Ashrend,

but from the North the Wychen were coming down from them to squash them against the fortress garrison. Reese gazed upon the Sickles. *Domerick and Kieran must have beached by now. Or...* They may not have made it to the beach at all. Reese dared not to think of it...

The Redstone Bridge spanned the river that fed the *Sickles* from above, and was soon to be descended on by eight blocks of the Wychen's painted purple crows. Commander Ralf, *the Scorpion Lord*, led five, while the other three were led by that *wicked* Lorynce. Eight, excluding the one crow block in *Castle Ashrend*, didn't seem like much when compared to the three blocks of the VRegiment, six blocks Artemis' Vanchists and four blocks for the King's Royal Legion, but blocks were just troops. *If troops were what won war nowadays, I would be out of a job.*

If only. The Wychen's guns and turrets and magic grew stronger by the day. Artemis' forces were underfed, overextended, exhausted, and the sounds of hissing spiders and grinding gears were grounding their morale down. That, and losing half of their comrades each year. Artemis won a dozen great battles across Oberath, but most of her men never got to hear the songs about them. She let out a tired exhale, and much of her patience had gone with it. "Maybe this wouldn't be so difficult if you had helped me with this earlier." She growled.

"I was busy."

"Busy with books?" she asked mockingly.

"Exactly, unless you want to be married to an illiterate moron." Reese knew that as impressive as her flashy battle tactics were, none of them would work if he wasn't so phenomenal at his job.

"Is being married to a literate moron much better?" She jokingly returned. Reese chuckled and she briefly smiled, before catching herself and immediately putting on a stern serious face. *One day I'll get to her*, Reese told himself. It was rare to get through her tough skin, but he couldn't help but try, even on a day as doomed as this. It was such a beautiful sight to behold, where a man like him and a woman like her could hold hands, wed in a monastery, and make love. He thought of his olive tanned fingers wrapped around her pale slender hands, as they danced to the sounds of the hunter's drums and the sailor's conches.

If these were the kingdom's final moments, they would be his last thoughts. Had he been born in any of the two thousand years that preceded him, that freedom would be lost. It was generally frowned upon for people of different territories to mix, especially one of the "savage" Chasseur, who were scorned for their "barbaric ways" and culture of death almost as much as they were for their last uprising against his liege. But new times meant new inventions, and new inventions meant the innovators got a say for once. Besides, he had never really understood the poor perception of the Chasseur anyway. He looked at his wife, dressed in the beautiful vibrant red cloth and rich black furs of a true warrior, covering the upper half of her torso as blood-red tattoos resembling sharp blades followed from where the cloth and furs ended and traced the edges of her obliques down to the bottom of her abdomen. The tattoos did well to accentuate the muscles around her waist, cutting off right by the hollows and ridges of her abdomen muscles that looked carefully chiseled from marble. *That is what a woman should look like*, Reese thought to himself. He remembered the way she would dance, how her hips with blood tattoos that glowed red in the dark would move like the waves on the water. Over that lay the royal cloak, and its self-righteous blue coloring, which covered the gorgeous battle garments in a wrapper of cultural appeasement.

Artemis placed her black leather gloved hands flat on the map top, overlooking the battlefield that encompassed the Render's land that was just South of the Brynnic's Shoals and East of the Terra's Glades. Her arms stretched wide like wings and bridged the map end to end. The Sacrosanct's Meadows were, of course, safe and sound, though the Musketeers will come riding down their roads soon enough at the current rate. She looked bitter. Ralf had been her rival for the better part of a year, they exchanged blows in the Shoals twice, and her victories left him with a vengeance. Now he came for her, with Scorpion Riders and Dragons and many Muskets. She hoped to bait him out and attack Lorynce when he least expected, but Lorynce himself was nowhere to be found, and his men wrapped around Ralf tightly.

“It won’t work, it will take too long. They have most of the river basin, and you know how little faith I have in the Ashrend assault. *To send my family into the fire so recklessly.* Now they come storming down Redstone Ridge with sixteen thousand, two of their most modern armies. Ralf will get his vengeance by slaying by our brothers first, and after he’s done with them it will be us.” She sounded as hollow as a tree. “And we still are being pushed back, and we still have no *damn* answers about their weapons!”

Reese sighed. He studied the art of crafting, building, smithing, alchemy, all his life. Anytime they had captured Wychen muskets or turrets or ships, the foundations they used were completely different from anything Oberath had seen in the last thousand years. How can they copy a weapon with no base to work off of? “We’ve killed most of the monsters. The ballistas are better than we thought— we laid waste to five hundred just today. *And we have my star cannons.* This can work. He’s angry and heedless, he’ll let his guard down.” Ralf was cunning and resourceful, but his main saving grace is his superior technology. All it takes is a couple mistakes however, no matter how great your ships or good your guns.

“They’ll be back in a day. Our men won’t be. Neither will the regiment, which will be lost if the bridge is taken.” A rock was in Reese’s throat. “After that, we lose any chance of killing the Artificer, and the Render’s days become numbered.” She groaned in despair. “I’ve won so many battles, I’ve outwitted them, outplayed them, my men are ten times more brave and fierce, and yet it doesn’t matter because of their *damn toys*. And magic. And their... their steam things!”

“Factories?”

“And their damn factories! If I had one fraction of what they had...” She kicked the table and pieces bounced in the air. One of the Pearfins dropped into the lake. “And I told them not to attack that fortress, I told them it would make us weak, but the *King* didn’t listen.”

“Ashrend has been supplying Ralf’s army for the last month. Something had to be done. And the King needs answers, and you know that more than anyone. Even if it’s not a total success, if the men can get their hands on any of the Artificer’s notes or tools...”

“I doubt it. That fortress gets more impenetrable by the day. We lost our chance to take it half a year ago, and this is just them refusing to admit they should have hedged their bets. Now look at what happened! The invasion is going to be thwarted, and they took advantage of the absent ten thousand to screw us!” Reese’s arms felt heavy, he thought of a bolt piercing the ships in two, of Kieran being killed by a storm of arrows, of Domic being drowning in the sea. And even if they survived the battle, even if they somehow won, they would instantly be greeted by Ralf’s forty thousand marauders. Reese didn’t notice he was crying until a sudden saltlake formed on the map. He used to pray the Furnace War would end before either of them saw battle firsthand. *Domic belongs in the laboratory with me, not in the field.* It was like handing a sword to a poet. Domic always had a look of wonder when Reese showed him his work, and Kieran always dreamed of running a merchant guild of hunters. If he threw a blade, it should be at a beast, not a man. *They are beasts*, Reese wanted to tell himself, like he used to the first time he put an invention of his in Artemis’ hands, but he knew better than that now. He wasn’t built for war, he couldn’t blind himself enough.

Artemis was the only one who was built for war. She wasn't just good at it, her personality was designed for it. She was creative, competitive, and cold. Other lords were at the mercy of conventions and doctrines. Artemis had no such weaknesses. She reveled in doing the unexpected. Tricking people is her specialty, whether it was the enemy or her own. He walked beside her, wrapping his arms around her waist and laying his head on her shoulder. Her furs were soft, like a pillow. She sniffled a bit, and for a moment she was not the King's Tiger but a small housecat. "I know you're worried. Anyone would be. If anything happened to them I—" Artemis turned her head to him, giving him that look. Reese cleared his throat. "The Regiment will be safe if we hold the lands North of Redstone." Reese gazed upon a network of streams and ditches that introduced the bridge. "We ought to advance on the river pits as soon as possible. Have King Maverick ambush Ralf, send two of our blocks to support the King. Make it seem like we mean to take them on, and use that distraction to screen our Vanguard as they enter the pits." Reese was careful when he uttered those words. He drank and sang and played cards with dozens in Artemis' courageous Vanguard. "Once we're in, it'll take the whole night before they can get them out. The Regiment will have time to prepare." In his heart, Reese meant to say retreat, but did not dare to speak life into ill omens. *Maybe Dimeric would kill them all.* He talked about it all the time, which Reese always found to be slightly disconcerting. Artemis' mouth tightened as she stared down the board and all its pieces. Her eyes were burning as she stared down Ralf's crows, and their raisin feathers. "It could work. It *could*. But could isn't good enough— we can't base the entire plan on Ralf meeting us head on. He's angry, not stupid. They *want* us to gamble on the bridge. They know they have us in the palm of their hand, they just have to squeeze us out." Artemis balled her gloved fist. "They smell blood in the water."

"Good!" Reese exclaimed. "Let them think they have us beat, they will surely bite the bait!" He smiled but she scowled as she placed her slender fingers against her temple. "It could work." Reese whispered softly. They could hear the sounds of boots stomping on the wet soft grass, getting closer, closer.

“It could... but...” Artemis sighed as the tent’s flaps flung open. The sound was the end of an era. The King was growing angsty, paranoid, and weary of losing his lands. He had won many battles yet the war effort was collapsing. He blamed the Lords, and those who received the most blame received an axe to the head. This may be their last day on earth. He glanced at his wife once more, at her wavy long hair, at the dimples around her nose. Two tall bearded men in platinum armor holding diamond axes burst through the tent’s flaps, they moved rigidly like puppets into the corners of the tent where they could stand and sulk properly. The next two walked in– both were young, fair skinned, blue eyed, tall, handsome, and walked like they had sticks up their asses. Even though Reese had seen the Icarus multiple times, he still gaped like an idiot as they entered.

King Maverick Icarus was as handsome as a man could realistically look without being made of marble– his square jaw was cleft and strong and filled out with a stubble, his eyes were diamond sharp and sapphire blue, his cheekbones were high set and wide. He donned a simple navy blue cloak, and golden and platinum plating under. The winged horse on his armor glowed gold. The most distracting thing about him was not his dressing or his comeliness but rather his *Excalibur*, a massive diamond sword that was so absurdly huge they said that Maverick had to literally grab the scabbard with his left hand and pull it down to be able to reach the handle with his right. The blue shine could be seen, trying to claw its way out of the sheathe.

Beside him was Arryk, or the *Coward*, as Reese and the rest of Oberath preferred to call him. He was beautiful like his older brother, only less dashing and more dainty. Maverick had his dirty stubble but Arryk had his clean shaven diamond chin. Maverick’s eyes were black bagged and striking, but Arryks were jumping with joy and doe-like. Arryk wore a big blue tunic with its embroidered golden sigil, and its giant wings. His sword, *the Parity*, was much shorter and thinner than his brother’s, and a bit curved. *How symbolic*. Arryk loved battle but hated planning and logistics and anything that made a battle possible. Arryk allegedly could not read, which astounded Reese. *How could someone so noble be so simple? And who would want to live their life without ever flipping through a good story?*

“King Maverick, Prince Arryk” Artemis welcomed them in a warm tone, then made a poor attempt at a curtsy.

“My liege,” Reese welcomed him as well, with a little less enthusiasm and a little more sarcasm than his dear wife. He turned to Arryk, and welcomed him in the most plausibly deniable condescending tone he could. “Lord Arryk”. He then proceeded to do the shittiest bow of all time.

“Prince Arryk” the brat corrected him. “You’ll address me as–”

“Why don’t we get started with business.” Maverick clasped his hands together and let out a tired fake smile. His teeth were still pearly white, even though he had such a dark grin. He looked at Artemis, with his eye bags that looked like great shadows. “We need to fix this. Do you have a plan?” The crickets and birds outside grew louder, or maybe the tent grew quiet. The silence waited patiently before Artemis’ eyes made that twinkle– when Reese saw it, a wave of relief slammed into him. Even with their family, careers, and nation on the line, the thrill of war always brought a tiny glimmer of wonder on her face, though you have to peer into the cracks in her eyes to see it. “Reese, how many river boats do we still have?”

“Over a dozen, I believe.” One of the only saving graces, though he could not possibly see the point. *Is she going to evacuate the Regiment by river? A surprise attack by shore, maybe?*

She looked at Maverick, her obsidian eyes now full of unwavering resolve. “We’re going to send half our troops to board our river boats and make our way through the Redstone River.”

“To reinforce the bridge?” Arryk confidently chimed in.

“No, we’ll land West of the bridge” Artemis quickly shut him down. Reese saw Arryk put his head down in the corner of his eye.

“Go west of the bridge? When... Now? Why?” Maverick questioned.

“No, when they have it.” Reese turned to look at her.

Maverick scoffed. "What do you mean, *when* they have it? Your orders were to halt the enemy advance. I don't see how..." Maverick stared for a bit before he smiled. "You're clever, real clever. More than I can say for this coward." Arryk made a face before crossing his arms and pretending like he wasn't bothered. "Your boats on the West and your men from the East... my men from the North... and the Regiment from the South below the bridge. They'll be penned in like pigs. Will it be enough?"

"With my forces it could." Arryk chimed. "I'll send my ground horses to reinforce the South and we can use both our Pegasus forces to ambush them on the bridge." *Fool*. Only an idiot would try to bring horses into the Southern Render, unless they felt the local beasts could use more horsemeat.

"We do need more strength." Artemis noted. "But not grounded cavalry, not in that area. Too many cliffs, too many beasts. I don't believe we can spare the airspace for more Pegasus either."

"She's right. Besides, you are not to abandon your mission to the Glades." Maverick stated.

"But there are plains in the Render, and I have no fear of the beasts."

"Then you are a fool. A brave fool, I would say, if your track record didn't argue otherwise. You would be of more use to our family with Terra." Maverick spat.

He groaned. "There is little glory to be won in the Glades, what good can I do for a people who have lost a third of their territory in two years? Like you said, my King, they're weak! You all just want the glory for yourselves." He grumbled. "My cavalry are as fast as they are fierce. They are not called the *Grounded Comets* because they fall too wild beasts. They are as much use to destroying Ralf and Lorynce as Artemis' Vanchists!"

"*Glory*. You pay too much mind to vanity." Maverick scoffed, his platinum armor glimmered as he did so.

"Your cavalry's speed is why you must go to the Glades." Artemis explained. "The hills and clearings will be perfect for you, and the lands North of Castle Greenhouse are filled with them. Don't focus too much on the battles. This is a war of resources, not warriors. We need wood for more ships, stables, and charcoal, and the trees in the Glades are said to kiss the clouds. You would contribute more to winning the war there than in this battle."

“There will hardly be a war anymore if they descend the bridge. Please let me help.”

“You will help. We need rangers, you could help with that. The men on the bridge will be easy targets.” She continued. She looked to Maverick for approval, and he nodded. “Gather many mounts. In fact, gather as much strength as you can. Have enough strength to send off a force of rangers to the bridge, use your flyers to drop them off and rafts to ride the river.”

“Rally the locals.” Maverick added. “The men, the women, anyone who can use a bow or club. This is a total war, total war demands total commitment from the people. Give them a deal of your strength and mounts to support our ambush on the bridge.”

Reese exhaled sharply. “Marand may take issue. Those are his people you mean to take, many of whom he wants to rally to protect his homeland. He will not want his men to die so far from him and his home. Like Arryk said, they have their own problems.”

“Marand will join them then, if he wants to keep his people close. Have Marand lead his Rangers to the bridge, Arryk can reinforce the defenses until he returns. *Arryk*.” He spoke sharply to his brother. “You are to hold the treeline and liberate the Hilltops. You remember why right?”

“Yes Maverick– to serve as a staging ground for your invasion of Castle Greenhouse!”

“I didn’t mean to say it aloud!” Maverick sighed, his sweaty skin glistened in the candlelights. “I know you’re good with commanding troops and swinging swords, but don’t forget the grand strategy. You have my faith, but *you will not overextend or improvise*.”

“Of course, my King” He bowed.

Reese began to breathe easier again. “With Artemis, Maverick, the Regiment and Rangers coming from all sides... will they have any way to make it off the bridge?”

“They can jump, but that’s what the rangers on the rafts will be for.” Artemis explained. “Our only main concern is if they use their superior power to punch through the trap, but if we strike fast enough from the sky they will stand no chance. I’ll deploy a splinter force to bait them in.”

“Are there other updates?” Reese asked the King. *In the invasion of Ashrend, perhaps?*

“Marand killed Commander Thragde, putting an arrow in his skull. Hid in the ruins of a mausoleum, and shot him and his royal guard while they were laying one of their comrades to rest– his son I believe.”

“He fights dishonorably.” said Arryk. “Thats a savage thing to do, even in war.”

“I wish you would fight dishonorably.” Maverick sneered. “This is a great victory for the Terra, one they desperately needed. I’m sure that’ll be a load off your mind– one less enemy to run away from.” Maverick eyes drifted across the board. “Admiral Dunkirk’s fleet in the Shoals have stalemated the Wychen armada as they tried to take another one of our chain islands”

I know what’s happening in my own hometown, thank you very much. “What of the battle of Ashrend?”

Maverick sighed. “There is little word of Ashrend so far, but what little we have does not bode well. Few ships made it onto the shore, and their defences are far stronger than the scouts reported. My generals suspect they kept most of their turrets hidden until the ships had left the docks. *Third times the charm.*” He scoffed bitterly. “A victory at the bridge and a dead Lorynce or Ralf may make up for this, but even still... We can keep beating them in the field, yet that only buys us time. We need to get to the root of this technological discrepancy and rip it out. Ashrend, its mystic power and the Artificer’s operations, would have been indispensable. We need a Core Castle back in our hands, and soon, Castle Hearthmark isn’t enough arcane to fuel our experiments.” Reese began to massage Artemis’ arm and rub her skin, trying his best to keep her with him. He could feel her seething. She had advised against the invasion more times than he could count. “I know they are your brothers. I’ve lost a brother, as you well know. They are counting on you to be strong, whether they are living or dead. Don’t let his death be an excuse for cowardice.” Maverick stood up, his blue eyes gleaming over the board. “Let’s show them that our light can be as blinding as it is guiding. For all of the Commonwealth, the living, and the dead!”

Artemis’ scared dismal face was conquered by a furious smile, the same face she made when she and Reese would go to the Render on their rare days off to track down beasts. *It was time for the hunt.*

Percius Kenning II

– *Castellan of the Render* | *Oberath* –

Authors Note: Haven't written this chapter (it's a little draining) but basically...

Percius plans a massive counter attack following Ashrend's mostly successful defense. While most of the attackers have been killed, another wave of invaders is arriving, and many of the survivors are still on the shores. He sends the Artificer's squads, including Bellacca, to give chase to the attackers as they retreat, planning to quell any chance of the next wave's chances. Percius and his men ambush Domic's squadron, and trick them into running to the paintings. There they use the magical painting trap to capture them, and Tavick is sadistically gassed to death by the Artificer (Percius has a PTSD attack that reminds him of his father, and dissociates heavily, so most of the incident isn't shown).

Sable II

– Constable | Amberwick –

The ice bottle of wine felt so cold in her hand, and for once, the breeze was warm, as did the sunshine. She saw him running, jumping the grass, trying to catch the leaves that fell onto his head. His hair was loose and tangled. Then the wind grew cold, so cold, and her blood with it. Soon she was ice, her veins frozen, and then she was in a solid block. Her boy was in a block as well, and then the winds blew harsher and harder. The ice shook. She pressed her hand against the ice wall, and tried to push, but when she did and it cracked, it broke to pieces. While she felt her body crumble to debris, her eyes saw her boy shatter and crumble as well. The tears froze before they blew away. When her eyes opened, the sweat beaded her skin like hives. The orange sky spun and the leaves with it, the moon stayed in place. It was massive, and recently, which had horrified the Constables and Marshals alike, it grew more massive each day. *Like my problems.* How could they let it get so late? Had she been out for that long? *I have killed us all.*

“Are you alright?” He called, his voice like a lute. It made her chest feel light, and like her face was burning in the wind. It felt like a rope had just dangled down from heaven, and she could climb up out of hell with it. *It’s not real.*

“I already questioned him.” Jayce said.

“Who are you?” Sable shouted, ignoring him. She was shaking, her teeth clanging against each other maddeningly.

He smiled, his teeth were sharp and shiny, his eyes were glistening from the moonlight. “I don’t know. I’m struggling to remember who I am right now.” He moaned and put his hand to his head.

“Here.” She instinctively put the wet cloth to where his hand was. The shock when she realized it froze her body. Her skin tingled.

“Thanks.” He said awkwardly. His freckles dotted his nose all over, and his hair tangled in just the exact ways. And his eyes... *Control yourself*. She inhaled and began to cough.

“He’s full of shit!” Jayce cried out. “When we bring him back to Carpenter’s Square, we will squeeze the truth out of him!”

“He could be telling the truth, he probably was in a vegetative state.” Samara pointed out.

He looked at her, shocked. “You think he came from a plant?”

She stomped on the ground. “No!”

“I assure you, I’m not a plant. I’m not a liar either.” His voice was gentle, so soft. He stood up, his tunic was dyed copper and embroidered with amber, along with amber earrings that dangled down and danced in the wind. His tunic was short sleeved, and under it was a long white sweater that caught the leaves like a net. His brown trousers were perfectly clean and perfectly fit for his long dangly legs. He had nothing but two long sticky blocks by his waist.

Samara held up her windlock, the moonlight bouncing off the gears near the copper handle.
“Do you know what this thing is?”

“A... gun?”

“You know what guns are?” She shouted. “What kind of guns do you have where you’re from?”

“I don’t know where I’m from! I told you a thousand times!” He cried out. *Leave him alone.*
A coldness stopped her from saying it. She stood up and stared at him.

“Do you come from beyond the great ravines?” She asked. “Do you? Or beyond the lake?” Her voice was stern.

“What can I say to prove it to you?” He sighed and rummaged his brittle fingers through his rustled hair.

“Explain this.” She tossed the book to him. He flipped through it. “What is *Sacroscant*? What are the *Rangers*? How did you make waterproof paper? What is the *flabellum*?” Her constable instincts took over. Her caliced hands went to a lasso around her waist.

“I don’t know! I may as well have grown up in that pool.” His hands went to two sticks that were attached to the belt near his waist. They glowed amber when his hands pressed against them, the orange specks flying off in the wind with the leaves. “What the hell!” He shouted like a dummy.

Sable's eyes grew big. When the speck rose in to meet the clouds, they looked like small embers. The air grew cold, again. "They're coming... you do know what *they* are right?" She questioned the boy. He shook his head. Where their campfire blazed, a big rocky hill sat to their backs, and a massive forest and a stream that buffered between to their front. She stood up, though her limbs felt weak. She slammed her boots against the dead leaves and climbed up the mound, before taking on a bird's view of the area around them. Orange haired, longed limbed, the trees all dance in the wind, their branches swishing around like windmills. The gusts blew in Sable's face and her hair danced on her skin. She held her binoculars and peered against the tree lines and hilltops, and she saw one tree's orange hair turn gray, before its bark withered away, and its limbs sunk to the ground. Her stomach sank. The corruption moved through the trees, like worms, eating away at nature and leaving their waste behind. The boy stumbled upon the ledge. Jayce held the nozzle up to his face. "Try anything *boy*, I dare you." Jayce tried to put on a mean face. Sable glared at him. "Don't worry, Samara's watching the camp. While you survey the area, I'll watch our prisoner."

"I have a name you know. *Rodge*." His big earthy eyes narrowed.

"*Rodge*, can you defend yourself?" She asked in a whisper. "And lower your tone."

"Are those the *Shades*?" He asked, flipping through his manual. She watched aghast as the ink began to complete the page on its own, even giving a sketch of its long limbs and gross rainbow eyes. She stared blankly for a moment. Whatever ghost was drawing the image before them, it had a steady hand and an artisanal eye. *Don't think hard about it. There's bigger things to worry about.*

"We need to find shelter," she commanded. "When the night grows even darker the Shades will come out, then the Reapers, then the Leapers." She pumped the bolt on her *Windlocked*, pressing her fingers gently against the brass and letting them slide down the sleek metal. She stepped on a dead apple as she motioned to the others.

"Where are we going?" Samara asked. Owls called out with her.

“There’s an abandoned town a few relays west.” She explained, puffing in the night air. “We’ll hold up in one of the buildings.” The moon was big, but its glow hadn’t gone dark purple just yet. Jayce was a fool for bringing them out here. She reached into her satchel, her hand rummaging around old drawn maps and pictures and drawings.

“As if it needs saying,” Jayce snorted. “You would know if you went outside more.” *If you knew, you should have taken us there.* Sable was used to doing the thinking for the group. She took out several wrong maps before finding the right one, she then carefully folded the others before sliding them back into the satchel.

“Why should I?” Samara rebutted. “I’m fine with my books and candlelights.”

“Your candlelights cannot hold a candle to the sun, and you learn more about this world by actually partaking in it than hearing stories about it.”

“The sun can burn your skin, and damage your eyes. And my candles smell like lavender.”

“What do you make of this *Rodge*? Do you like the indoors, or outdoors? Do you have indoors?” Sable asked softly as she could, though her voice always had a rasp to it that she couldn’t shake. She looked to the boy for his answer as she opened her map, the thin aged paper delicately flapping in the wind while she scanned.

He smiled. A breeze bounced his hair while he crunched leaves with his boots. “What do indoors around here look like?”

Sable looked at him skeptically, but when she looked upon the curiosity in his eyes her guard forgot itself. “It depends, we move from camp to camp, from town to town. But usually, we fashion ourselves a study, usually wood, and many teepees for hunting or fishing.” *One foot after another, we have places to be.* Her boots marched, but her mouth babbled, oddly. “Mostly, we build a big saloon, or make one out of some ruined building, fill it with paper lanterns and flowers.” She sighed. Rodge’s eyes lit up like fireflies, which gave Sable a strange sense of relief. “We’ll be safe once we’re there, but we can’t cross the valley in the dark. We can hold up in the saloon at the town hall. Once we’re there, we’ll have to be careful. There could be husks, or marauders. We should keep an eye out for food, parts, horses, seeds, and medicine.” *And booze.*

Rodge laughed. "I think I'll stick to the indoors, if they're filled with candles and booze and the outdoors are filled with monsters." They led their horses carefully through the wooded trails, Sable's fingers gripping tightly against Dylebon's leather reins. The smell of rotten apples and pumpkins was strangely sweet and pleasant. "Will I get a horse?"

"If you don't, you'll be dead!" Jayce joked.

"We'll find one for you Rodge, don't worry!" Samara seemed way more trusting of the boy. Jayce, for all his buffoonery, could at least keep his constable instincts about him. It made her proud to see him grow under her command. "And," Samara went on. "We'll find you a good Windlock. Do you like accuracy, or damage?"

She saw a wide smile then, like he was asked to pick a flavor of pie for dessert. She was the same way when they offered Sable her first lock. "Damage. Wait, no, accuracy. Accuracy is more versatile, isn't it? It's better if we're patient and plan things out?"

Sable felt a pleasant surprise at that. "I chose damage. I was wrong. I liked to get up close, but that's because I had no fear."

"Are you afraid now?" Rodge asked.

"Yeah, not of death. These fools look up to me, it would be really embarrassing to die in front of them." She spoke in a whisper, and held her lantern high with one hand, leading Dylebon with the other. She looked at the stars and the patterns of the layout of the trees. The wind blew many things, but some parts of the world you could cling on to. "Dawnberry is to the West."

"The place is said to be haunted, so watch yourself *boy*." Jayce sneered. "It was a flourishing town that kept the Shades outside of their walls for centuries. They say they infiltrated from inside, then killed everyone but the babies, who they stole off from their cradles."

"*They* sound like they have a bit of a problem." Rodge joked, big dimples forming around his cheeks as he smiled. "Tell me more about *them*."

"They're..." Samara was about to start with her scholarly tangent.

“They’re dangerous.” Sable cut her off. “They hunt us and we have no idea why, they come with the darkness. In the day, they usually sizzle up in the sun, so they either retreat from where they came or hide in small caves, holes in the ground, or buildings if they’re lucky enough.”

“Where they came? Where do they come from?” He was equally scared as he was curious. It reminded her of a time before she took the absurdities of the world for granted.

“The Ravines, massive cracks in the ground South of the Treeline Tribe. It’s where they come from, and where the edges on our map are. They say they appeared centuries ago, but we can see the land beyond. It looks so beautiful, like it’s *teasing us*.” They passed by a hill that marked the entrance to the town. Sable handed Dyelabon’s reins to Jayce before she clambered up the hill. She looked across the town, in all its empty glory. Weeds grew where old gardens were, dandelions and crabgrass growing over the dirt that used to be sorghum and squash. The gate and walls were rotten, the fountain in the center of town was full of muck and moss, and worse of all husks roamed the streets and every corner, but the old signs were still a little readable, and you when you looked upon the cobweb filled buildings your mind could still place folk and furniture in them.

The husks trudded on the ground with their arms dangling, loose purple rot and black moss and tar covered their bodies. Samara claimed they used to be people, but there were no “people” left in the Husks. “Where do we hitch our horses?” Jayce called out.

“We don’t.” She said begrudgingly. “We let them loose.”

“What!?” Samara cried out. “We can’t! *Baila* will get lost!”

“They won’t, we’ll track them or they’ll come to us. If we hitch them and Shades or worse, the Reapers, come about then they will be slaughtered. If we leave them, only the Reapers crave horsemeat, and they are as slow as they are rare.” The sky grew darker still. Samara solemnly kissed her black Baila on the nose before letting her loose. Jayce patted his on the neck before giving it a ‘go boy!’. Sable held her neck and pressed her forehead against Dylebon’s, sharing a breath before parting ways. “They will be fine, and we need to worry about ourselves.” She grunted as they all climbed over the hill and gazed upon the husks.

“*What the hell are those things?*” Rodge was horrified.

“Nothing good, follow my lead, and we’ll live.”

“Ooh, are we building a fire? ” Jayce’s voice jumped with joy.

“*I’m* building a fire. I don’t need you burning down the entire valley. *You* need to make Rodge a paraglider.”

“Can’t Samara do that? She’s better with fabrics anyway.” Sable looked at Jayce’s messy mismatched windguard fabrics, blowing in the air with the leaves, next to Samara’s gorgeous neatly folded set of berry reds and oranges.

“Fair point.”

“Besides, we need a big fire. Look at that wall! How could you deny a pair of helping hands?” *How could I?* She thought to herself sarcastically.

“Alright, you know what we need– leaves and pinecones for starters, then bundles and bundles of sticks–”

“I know, I know!” Jayce knelt down and swooped a batch of twigs off the ground. The brass of the windlock delicately bounced on Sable’s shoulder as she went to a nearby tree to shake the cones out from its leaves.

“I can help.” His wide smile was eager. Samara looked up at him, before flushing and looking away. Her face was like one of the ripe apples Dyelabon likes.

“You can stay with me! I want to show you how this works.” *Oh, poor Jayce.* She took out sticks from her satchel and took out a flat of fabric before she formed a crossbar with the sticks and stretched the sheet as tightly as possible around it. “This is a *glider*.” She sounded so glad, so in her element. “We hold them and... well... glide in the air.”

“Is that so?” Rodge chuckled. “Let me write this down in the manual. Do you have a quill?”

Sable caught herself laughing for some reason. *I shouldn't laugh at a time like this.* The sticks grew to a bundle, and the bundle to a fat stack that almost blew over in the gusts. When she walked off, she spotted an odd squirrel or fox out of the distance, each time making her blood jump and her hands almost teleporting to the stock and trigger of her Windlock. The smell of smoke spoiled the apple scented air. Sable cut back through fig trees to find the massive bonfire that Jayce had begun, he must have struck flint against the crumpled leaves on top of a bed of sticks and small logs. Wood fell from Sable's arms down into the fire, and embers rose up to the sky. She and Jayce two more trips for firewood each, while she heard Samara chatting up the fountain boy. *Rodge, that's his name.* It rolled off Sable's tongue so easily.

The smoke grew darker and thicker, and rose so high it could join the clouds. Jayce rubbed his palms together as he admired his masterpiece. "Look at that! Might be the biggest fire we had to escape the Quarry." *Why would you bring that up?* Of all the Constable expeditions she went on, that was the one she hoped to forget the most when she found her lips kissing the lid of the whiskey bottle.

"*I'm sorry Rodge.*" Samara rarely sounded so hollow. "I don't know why I keep messing it up." She angrily threw the glider on the ground, where the fabrics were all messy and tied the wrong ways. Her hands and voice shook with the trees. "Somethings gotten into me, my hands..."

"I think you're just nervous!" Rodge reassured. "Don't fret too much."

"It's okay Samara," Sable calmed her down. "I'll help make another." She rummaged through her big statchel. "*Maps... food...* wait Jayce did I get my fabrics for you?" *I should remember.* Ever since she fell by the fountain, her memory has been a little doozy.

"You don't get it, I'm supposed to be good at this." She whimpered as she sat on the floor in defeat.

"Let's see if I have anything," Sable watched in complete shock and horror as Rodge reached into the satchel and pulled a glider out that was three times the size of its container. "Whoa." Rodge laughed. "I feel like a magician— you know when they like pull those fabrics out of your mouth?"

"*How...*" Sable grumbled as she put her hand to her head. *How.*

“What the fuck!” Jayce yelled. “Give me that thing.” He snatched the Satchel and stuck his hand in it, and tried to rummage around for things, but there was no sound besides Jayce’s hands smacking into the leather sides.

“Is this glider good enough?” Rodge held the triangle of wood and spooled yarn.

Sable just stammered. “I suppose. Samara, did you explain to him how this works?”

“She did.” Rodge answered before she could. “The fire’s updraft is strong enough to carry us over the wall, where we will land on the roof of the bar?”

“The windows.” Sable corrected. “When we’re in the air, stay close to me. Don’t get lost.”

“And don’t let your fingers slip, I’m guessing?” Rodge smiled. “For some reason, I’m more scared than excited.”

“Wanna race there?” Jayce asked as he bit some berries he found in a bush. *Please tell me you checked if they were poisonous.* Last time he didn’t Jayce was stuck in the outhouse for a whole afternoon.

“Jayce, don’t get my...” She stammered. “Friend killed please.”

Jayce went first, predictably, over the smoke he shot out into the sky and began to drift among the stars. Samara flew next, her body gracefully flying and gliding in the air, the fabrics on her windguard dancing like the colorful feathers of a bird.

“You’re nervous?” Sable’s stern face melted into a smile.

“No!” He was lying, Sable had an eye for that. His face was as brave as he could make it, but there was a shakiness in his breath.

“It’ll be scary at first. I was a little scared when I first tried, but when you finally realize how beautiful the world looks from up there, your screams will turn to laughter.” Rodge awkwardly held the glider above his head. “Round your shoulders. And don’t slouch so much, make sure your grip is tight.” She chuckled as she pressed his shoulders back and wrapped his fingers around the strongest bend of the wood. “There’s small grips there, its hard to notice but it’ll help if your palms get sweaty.” A sudden nervousness seems to overtake Sable. She had never seen someone actually fall from one, if this Rodge’s first day in this world... A twisting knot formed in her stomach. “Make sure you do not lose your grip. *Please.*”

He took a deep inhale and smiled. “Don’t worry so much. This looks fun. I’m just scared I’ll embarrass myself.” He jumped as he opened the glider, and when the smoke rose against the fabric Rodge’s legs were hoisted up to the sky, and the gusts spun him in a circle in the air. She heard him whooping and screaming in terror and joy. Sable flew up next. The air grew so thin when she glanced at the world below them. The wave of bending trees circled the lands as the gusts blew from the mountains in the West down to the trees and over the lakes, through the dark abandoned towns, and past the valleys and ravines. Among all these sights, she could only look at Rodge, and his flapping wool sweater which looked like a white flag in the wind. He laughed, and even though she had seen the sight a hundred times, when he was laughing she suddenly remembered how magical of a sight it was, and laughed with him.

Like birds, they hovered and glided over the town, over the wall, over the snarling husks, and as they began to glide down and down, Sable took the lead in front of Rodge and descended toward the Tavern. “Legs out, like this.” She felt like she was teaching him how to use the swings. Her feet shot out, her boots a spear ready to stab the window. He followed suit, and together they crashed through the pane of glass and onto the creaky woodboard below.

Prince Arryk I

– *Icarus Dynasty* | *Oberath* –

Prince Arryk's white horse trotted with grace on the loose lily pads his Foraging Corp had laid throughout the Glade's various bogs and mires, making soft squishes and squelches. He had sent them northward, under the leadership of Sir Gellard Yealts, ahead of the rest of the army to seize poisonous herbs and hunt local game in the Swamplands, while his Survey Corps were sent southbound to probe the riverline for enemy movements, under Sir Donnel Delton. *You can do this*, Prince Arryk monologued in his head as he stared himself down in one of the puddles that kept him company. *You look great*, he told himself. His porcelain smooth face, beautiful glowing blue eyes and luscious blonde hair went great lengths to ensure that Arryk's beauty on the inside could also be seen on the outside. He almost thanked the gods for blessing him with such comely features, but then he reminded himself these were the fruits of labor not fortune— hours of meticulous scrubbing and styling with milk soaps and herbal washes and ambergris oil and oakwood combs. He looked great, sounded great and smelled great. He was great. But how great was he truly when sat next to the thousands of men among the Cobalt Legion, each from their own corners with their own stories and their own dreams and own faces? What of the entire Terra woods, and its hundreds of thousands of different villagers, hunters and alchemists and foragers and planters? What of the entirety of Oberath? Among all the others, will heads still turn to him?

The others? What did Maverick always say? *We're the ones who soar. Those down below call us small but they spend their whole lives living in our shadow.* There were millions of men in Oberath but only two men with the name Icarus. *Only two.*

You can do this, he clarified again. Fireflies lit up the night sky, and were most of the only light the Cobalt Legion's Vanguard had save a few torches they held. The fireflies danced perfectly around the embers of the torch Arryk held. As the men trotted along, the pads became more and more worn and sporadically placed, and the muddy water grew greener and greener, to where Arryk couldn't make out much of his face, save for when the fireflies would blast their lights in unison, giving Arryk a quick glimpse into his sapphire eyes. Beside him trot the most seasoned warriors in the Vanguard, forming a ring of gold around their Prince Icarus. Arryk went through the speech again in his head, pondering all the opening formations he could take. He thought of leaving them hanging by his sides as he usually did. *Too awkward*. He thought of crossing his arms. *Too serious*. He thought of clasping his hands together in front of him. *No, too meek*. What if he clasped his hands together behind his back? *There we go*, he boasted to himself, *this is how a prince general should look*.

He put on a charming smile in the water mirror, then played with his hair for five minutes until each strand fell perfectly onto his face before reciting his speech in his head, where his voice was as imposing as it was booming. *I am Prince Icarus, the accomplished Commander of the Cobalt Legion! I call upon you, men of the forest, of the capital, of the... the...* A crisp sound rang loud throughout the room as Arryk smacked himself in the face, hard enough to leave a red mark on his right cheek. Some of the horses neighed and shuffled backwards in an alarmed panic. One of his men, Ranger Dayle, panicked. "What's the matter my prince?"

The Lumiknight Felix chuckled. "Its so easy to see the greenies, even among this forest." Dayle was one of the Rangers they had hired with Vesper's 'funds'. Arryk would not likely forget the feeling he had when he first walked through the doors– their imposing hooded cloaks and glowing green nets and beautifully sharp looking leatherwear. On their backs were massive bows and venomous arrows that glowed green and purple, boomerings of ironwood and burmbark, and a massive bug net they would infamously use to lob hives of hornets at their foes. They were formidable on the field and majestic to the eyes, and were well worthy of joining Arryk's ranks and feasting with him in his halls. "The Prince needs to think, and when he is, the rest of us aren't here. Do well to remember that." Felix smiled. Just like the Rangers, Arryk could only style himself with the most notable and gracious looking men, and his longest standing comrade at arms Felix was of no exception. Like a loin, he had ferocious violent talent and a coat to envy.

Arryk continued, blocking the fools from his mind. Colorful faeries flew in circles over his head, glowing red or yellow or usually blue. *The fireflies, the faeries, my audience.* Arryk took another deep breath before dramatically clearing his throat again. *I am Prince Icarus, the accomplished general of the Cobalt Legion! I call upon you, men of the forest, of the capital, of the Commonwealth! We may come from different families, eat different suppers, sing different songs at our weddings, say different farewells at our funerals, but we suffer all the same!* He imagined himself drawing his meteor blade, the Parity, and pointing it at the audience, the sun glimmering off the tip of the sword and onto the crowd. *Those monsters, those vicious villains, those Reavers! They take our land, they burn our houses to the ground, they butcher men, women, and children alike! And they won't stop there- they won't stop until your friends, your parents, your siblings, your children, are all dead in the ground! But I, Prince Arryk Icarus, hero of the Battle of the Meadowshire, will end their... their...* Arryk sharply exhaled in frustration, then slapped himself in the face four times, each harder than the last. His cheeks stung hard, and wore red handprints. *You are the Prince, brother of the new King Maverick, son of the great Percius,* he thought to himself. He took another breath, and began speaking out loud. The walls of his mind were thick but Felix's snickering could almost be heard through them. *You are the Prince, brother of the new King Maverick, son of the great Percius,* he thought to himself. *You wield the hero's sword. That's it!* He proclaimed. *These forest dwellers have never even seen a Sacrosanct lord, let alone the great handsome Prince of Icarus! I will have them struck by awe with the sight I give their eyes and the promises I give their ears. They will follow.*

He felt a soft hand fall gently on the cap of his shoulders. “Sorry my Prince, I know you don’t like being disturbed, but in the wake of such a catastrophe...” Arryk zoned back in. There was a massive gap in the pads in front of him, and three flailing pieces of metal, as well as panicked horses. “I would have let you join them, only I had assumed you couldn’t swim, nor hold your breath, for you would keep yapping even if you were underwater.” Ranger Dayle and Sir Martin laughed but stopped when Arryk turned around with a scowl. Ranger Dayle was almost twice Arryk’s age, with a long black stubble and hollow cheekbones while Sir Martin was a plump younger lad with big buckteeth. Felix had long light brown hair tucked in an elegant ponytail, and wore a long black eyepatch, which was a shame for his other eye was as blue as it was striking.

“Show some damn respect!” he angrily barked. “Don’t forget who you’re talking to! Get the horses up, and lay more lilies, do we have more starters?”

“Only a few left.” Sir Martin said as he laid the large seeds on the water’s surface and they exploded into veins first, which carved green webs in the murky water before they slowly connected all together and filled with chlorophyll. Dayle pressed his hands on it to test the integrity of the pad before licking some of the chlorophyll off his fingers.

“How’s the speech? I’m not saving you from a mob again.” Felix taunted.

“You didn’t save shit. I had that, much like I have this speech.”

“Do you know? That’s good then, we can talk about some important matters.”

“Such as?” The pads had solidified. Arryk was first, the others followed, the rest of the train waited patiently for Arryk to cross and for the other Lumiknights to swim back aboard. “I believed we figured everything out.”

“Two things. The armorer corp is going to be low on funds, they tell me. They needed the sapphires and pearls you traded for the Rangers in the tavern for boots and gloves. They planned to buy them at a cheaper price from local tradesmen, and didn’t expect the expense given that we worked the budget beforehand.”

Arryk scoffed at that. “An opportunity for warriors arose, Rangers and Lumiknights, bows and bolts, that’s how we beat an enemy— not footwear.”

“You're wrong my Prince, respectfully. Having degraded boots is a nightmare in these bogs, not to mention using a bow with no gloves. You wouldn't believe the stinging pain when the string rubberbands onto your bare skin– you wouldn't know since we always keep extra of the best equipment for you.”

Fair enough. “The other problem?”

“Did you send the Farrier Corp to take Reindeer from the local herders?”

“I did. We need the mounts for our great offensive.”

Felix groaned. “My prince, you cannot just steal the mounts from the locals. Sorry– you can't just steal from the locals in general.”

“Stealing? It's not stealing, the crown–”

“You can't just *take* from the locals. Better?”

“I can and I did. The royal family has a precedent to quarter soldiers or take necessary supplies such as food, water, gear *and animals*, and I simply exercised that prerogative.”

“Your memory is outstanding. I can't say the same about your idea to win over the locals with a speech right after *taking* their animals.”

“They were issued notes, notes that they can exchange for gems with the crown's bank when the battle's over.”

“When the battles are over they might not be alive to get it back. They would have preferred having them for themselves, or at the very least given to the Marand's Rangers. Their love of Marand is what inspires them, not the crown or these blue banners. This isn't the Meadows or your precious Castle Hearthmark.” *Hearthmark*. It had been long since Arryk stepped foot in his home, and he hoped to keep it that way. Sneering, scheming, and breathings from Maverick and Vesper, that's all Hearthmark had to offer.

“They love Markus.” Ranger Dayle admitted. “Across all of the Glades they speak tales of his Rangers liberating villages all over, leaving the Wychen sleeping with one eye open. They say the secret is never to meet them head on, straight into their war machines and monsters. Instead, wait for their machines to destroy the ground for you, then hide amidst the rubbles and ruins and shoot them in their behinds.”

“That is the Terra way, not the way of the Sacrosant, or anyone who walks under the Cobalt banners.” Arryk explained. “Our armies excel at power and strength, mounted charges, artillery based tactics. We aren’t suited to that type of warfare.”

“Our Prince is correct! The sun may set in the east today.” Felix joked before Arryk shot him another dirty look. The men had crossed off the lilies and onto the ground, where roots dug up and twisted into the ground all around, causing some of the horses and men to trip– the former sometimes onto the latter. Sir Martin reached down to pluck one of the roots from the ground and put it in his mouth, the sound of the crunch was starchy. The buzzing of bugs and singings of songbirds were louder than the mushy sounds of boots stamping footprints onto mud. Some men sang along with the birds, others tended to the wounded, others drank elixirs and wines, as if Arryk couldn’t see them doing so in the corner of his eye. It was against the rules of course, but whether they would be punished depended heavily on the general attitude of the day, and so far today was nothing but sunny and uplifting. “You have a great mind for tactics my Prince, but politics and people are another matter. If Marand is as popular as we’ve heard, then we will either have to win him to our side or somehow completely sway the people. That all being said, there is some good news for us. The Foraging Corp found poisonous herbs all over, we have enough for all our arrows, bolts, and even for some of our swords, and better yet, we have enough food to last months. They caught not only boar but moose fish and tiger as well. And the nuts– they say it rains chestnuts and pinenuts in the Glades like it does water in the Meadows. We met some locals who are helping us tap the trees for syrups as well. The foragers are pleased, as is your Raider Corp, who just picked up twenty rangers who were split off from Marand’s Legion.” Felix continued.

The sixty Rangers we hired plus another twenty— we could make the Raider Corps three hundred strong. “This place certainly has its perks. No wonder the Wychen want it so badly.”

Slimes hopped around them, jellike creatures with translucent jiggly bodies that held barks, moss and lichen inside, only discernible as living due to their great hops. “What do you think of this place, compared to the Meadows?” Felix asked.

Maverick and Vesper had no love for the Terra, they saw them as “acorn-eaters” and “primitive skunks who smelled like hogshit”. *The plains of Hearthmark...* Maverick and Vesper lectured him many a times on the superiority of the Meadows. His mind fed him a list of agricultural and logistical and economic and cultural inferiorities, but when the setting sun pierced through the tree cover that hung over fifty feet high, and the sunbeams cut into the misty air where the speckles of water glowed, Arryk only smiled. “It’s beautiful.”

The chirping of owls greeted them as they road into the center of the dwelling, a once bustling center of commerce now transformed into a military outpost, where men once hacked at meat with knives smiths now hacked at knives with hammers, and where children played capture the flag in the yard they now marched in small squadrons under militia coaches. The houses fashioned inside and outside of trees, with hallways going inside and out, were filled to the brim with archers and workers and healers, carting supplies and wounded up and down the corridors.

“Sir Martin, help the men organize the dwellers will you? Ranger Dayle, I have a task for you.” Arryk smiled. “Felix? You’ll want to hear too.” Felix came closer. “Our Raider Corp picked up twenty Rangers from Marand, plus the sixty of you, gives us near a hundred. Our Raider Corp was already two hundred strong, you have just enough to do some real damage while still able to slip by the trees easily, Vesper’s spy says that Malkan sent a new commander to replace the one slain by Marand. They say she’s a woman, she’ll be as green as they come. Ride out with the Raiders, find this girl Commander and come back with her head or not at all.”

“It is as good as done, my Prince.” Ranger Dayle proudly stated before riding off, calling his fifty-nine retainers as he did so. Amidst the chaos, Arryk and Felix walked outside the crude spare room in the dwelling’s local mess hall and made their way to the yard, while the rest of his Cobalt Legion began to pull the forest dwellers in the yard. *They must all be here to hear their salvation.* Arryk had a kick in his step as he excitedly strode, Felix trudged behind him with a quiet steady pace.

Scores of well-equipped soldiers and civilians with old dusty weapons awaited their arrival when Arryk dramatically barged open the doors.

“Arryk the Prince!” Felix yelled with booming volume and an undying conviction.

The crowd was made of three groups, Arryk’s Lumiknights stood in the front-left, the Rangers to their right, and the villagers stood behind them. The Lumiknights, dressed in their iconic cobalt chainmail and armed with their standard issue rapiers and crossbows, loudly cheered as they welcomed Arryk onto the podium. Arryk smiled back and spread his arms wide out to embrace his men’s love, but as he turned his eyes from his men to the locals, he was hit with a heart-wrenching disappointment.

The Rangers looked weary and tired. They were still wearing their classic green cloaks, but most had shown signs of wear and tear, brown from mud, ripe with holes, some were even charred. Their net masks had been mostly torn, few were glowing green now. They had huge black eyebags and tired dead stares as they looked back at the golden prince. Most had their fingers wrapped around and glued to their old wooden bows, though Arryk couldn’t tell if it was out of anger or out of habit. It wouldn’t matter much regardless- most of the men had near empty quivers. The local village conscripts were made mostly of men, but there were a considerable number of women who stood as clerics and archers, equipped with small pouches filled with herbs and composite bows made from bark and vine. The village men mostly held clubs, small wooden blades, and woodcutter axes made of stone. They all had slim limbs, malnourished faces, and eyes that were each either lifeless or seething with rage. Many who were in no fighting condition- the elderly, the children, the pregnant- still joined the crowd to bid their soldiers and family farewell.

Why are they not cheering? Don't they see me? Arryk asked himself. Then he understood- the forest dwellers were always said to be patient and peaceful, they were simply waiting for him to begin his speech. Arryk mentally prided himself on his open mindedness before he cleared his throat. "Men, oh and woman, and... children I suppose..., we come from different peoples and places, yet here we stand united!"

"Yes!" The Lumiknights ecstatically cheered. The cheers noticeably were less loud among the other members of the audience.

"We have a common enemy to face! It is fortunate for you that the royal crown has sent its finest soldiers to help the Terra and all its inhabitants" Arryk's voice boomed with an undeterred determination. Cheers once again rang from the front left of the crowd. "With the finest soldiers, comes finer experience. The Lumiiknights offer not only their men and equipment, but their expertise in military strategy as well!"

"Will they teach us how to run away as fast as them?" a crowd member jeered, and laughter among the villagers soon followed. The jeerer came from the villagers, he carried heavy black bags under his eyes, burnt clothes on his back, and a small child in his arms. The Lumiknights glared at the heckler, though he stood unfazed. Part of Arryk wanted to have Felix drag that man out of the crowd and cut out his tongue in front of the whole audience, but that would be unseemingly of a prince.

"We will work together! Not as soldiers strung together by politics, but as united people of the Commonwealth defending our rightful lands from a monstrous force! Now I understand that you all have been fighting, some for days, some for weeks, some for months! And it feels like no matter how many we fight back, victory seems out of reach." Arryk raised his hand to his mouth and stifled his artificial sorrow. Then, he lowered his hands as his face brought back his charming charismatic demeanor. "Fret not! Our royal strategists have devised a plan- we work in tandem with the Vanguard and King Maverick's Paladins to pincer the bulk of the Reavers! Our role in this operation is to pierce the forest the Reavers hold by the Pinestone Ravine, then from there, we will strike the East as the Vanguard strikes from the West and Maverick strikes from the sky! After this triumph, the Reavers will be battered, and from there, our true victory will begin! Not a victory of a battle, but of a war!"

“Wait, what!?” The jeerer yelled. “We’re pushing forward? And not even forward in our home, but in someone else’s? Are you insane?”

“My home was burned to the ground! The Reavers are at our doorstep, yet you ask us to die in a place we don’t even know?” a woman next to the jeerer shouted. The rest of the villager crowd agreed.

“No!” Arryk protested. “This operation will, in the long term, help the war effort, and will help the crown defeat our enemy! And a victory for the crown is a victory for all!” Arryk proudly proclaimed.

“What victory is that? We are barely surviving as it is, you send us all in some battle in some foreign land?” Markus, the leader of the rangers, had stood up and joined the hecklers. His cloak was a richer green, displaying a deep dark moss colored engraving of a great willow tree. A glowing-green netsuit covered his skin. “If Maverick wants us all to die anyway, we should all die here, bow in hand!”

Arryk barked back with a frustration building in his throat. “Maverick doesn’t want you to die- none of us want *any* of you to die! And you won’t, this offensive is not some thoughtless hail mary.” Arryk insisted. “This plan will succeed- with your help of course!” He stammered to correct himself. “And you won’t be using bows or any wooden forest weapons, we are no longer waging defensive guerilla warfare, the Lumiknights will provide silver high-grade swords and spears for all you to use! We have vigorously trained and well-bred horses and pegasuses from the Lancesteed, and we will charge at them with a strength they would never expect!”

The crowd yelled out in anger, while all the militia stood up to quell the crowd. “Lose our wooden weapons!?” the jeerer shouted. The jeerer put his child down on the ground, the woman next to him quickly scooped the child up as the jeerer began walking forward. “First you want us to die in some land beyond our forest, then you ask us to set aside the weapons we have known for generations?” The jeerer stepped closer and closer to Arryk’s podium, receiving stares of anger from the Lumiknights and of respect from the rangers.

“Have you no respect for our culture? Do you royal lords look down upon us that much? What of our women, what would they fight with?” the jeerer asked.

“They can use our swords as well!” Arryk proudly exclaimed. A quiet yet sharp smacking sound rang from the podium as Felix’s face went straight into his palm. *Oh shit, you idiot*, Arryk berated himself. The bows were originally the woman’s weapon for the forest dwellers. Women were gatherers and foragers who needed to defend themselves from beasts afar, and anytime they had to go to battle women would do so with a bow and quiver.

“Woman holding swords? They have wielded bows since the beginning of time, just as our men will wield wood and stone weapons of the forest!” the jeerer yelled. The rest of the villagers and rangers clamored in agreement.

Seriously? Who the hell actually cares? Arryk thought to himself. “We are simply using the best tools for the job! I understand how your feeling-”

“You understand how we’re feeling? You?” The jeerer had jumped up on the podium. Now that he was closer, the tears and burns on his old battered clothes were more apparent. Felix’s hand subtly hovered over the handle of his rapier as the jeerer walked closer to Arryk. “Does he understand how you all are feeling as well?” The jeerer delivered the question to the rest of the crowd, of which they responded with a resounding “No!”.

Felix paced over and stood between the two, and whispered into Arryk’s ear. “This isn’t going well. Maybe you should let me take over for a bit.”

“No... no I can fix this” Arryk whispered back. Though, he frankly had no idea how to save this travesty. Maverick would surely brand him if their entire plan failed because Arryk couldn’t convince a band of villagers and forest fighters to do their job. Anxiety and frustration and fear began to jet through his veins. *What would my sister do?* He pondered. She was always so good at convincing people to do what she wanted. Vesper would tell him to be straightforward, logical- to appeal to what they really want. What did they want? They obviously didn’t want him, or his plan, or even his men and weapons. *What did they want?* Arryk asked himself. He stared at the jeerer, his worn down clothes, his dead yet bitter eyes. Arryk remembered the child he was holding earlier.

“Why don’t you listen to your babysitter?” the jeerer mocked and laughed.

Arryk put on a hard stern face and aggressively paced towards the broken man. “You want me to be honest with you? With all of you!?” His voice erupted with a blunt, impatient, and genuine coldness in its inflection, but with it, a sense of genuinity. “I’ll give you the same advice that you would get from any rational person with a basic survival instinct. Start thinking about your survival now, and your family’s. You’re *losing*. You’re *all losing*- badly I might add. You fought heroically, to the last man, to the last fiber of energy in your bodies, and where has that gotten you? Each night you go into battle, loud and proud and vicious, and come back as wounded broken defeatists without a single thing to show for your valor in battle. What happened to the last village that you all lost to the Reavers? How many people there survived?”

“... None” the Jeerer bitterly admitted.

“Exactly. None. And that’s exactly what’s going to happen to every forest dweller in this crowd if we don’t turn this war around. We aren’t fighting bandits or warriors, the Reavers will kill *everybody*. They’ll kill you!” Arryk pointed at a random member of the crowd. “And you!” He pointed to another. “And you!” he pointed at a tired boy- the boy’s little sister and mother silently stood beside him. “And they won’t just kill the soldiers, will they? They’ll kill your parents, your siblings, your children, and enslave the rest, then they’ll burn your homes and forests to the ground so those slaves have somewhere to toil. Is that what you all want?”

“You heckle me because I won’t let you die with your customary weapons in your familiar homes, but will your children care what weapons their parents held when they fell if the Reavers come to slaughter them?”

“... No” the jeerer confessed, and quiet yet noticeable murmurs of agreement echoed throughout the crowd.

“I need you all to stop asking yourselves how you want to die and what notions of glory or honor you want to carry with you when you do so. I need you all to instead ask yourselves, ‘What’s going to happen if we don’t win the war we are obviously losing’, ‘What’s going to happen to my family’, ‘What’s going to happen to my home?’. The crown wants all the Reavers dead, and we’re willing to deal with you all to make it happen. You all call me a coward, and weak. Sure, whatever. You probably also wish King Maverick was here instead. But he’s not, and he won’t be. Now I am here, with a division of trained troops, generals with experience in strategy, an arsenal of fresh titanium weapons, a strong monetary backing from the crown, mounts, grounded and flying, from the Lancesteed, and a much stronger desire to shed Reaver blood. They may have us beat if you look at a map, but their forces are spread thin, their supply lines extended long, and all we need is a big kick to make their house of cards come crashing down.

We have the kick, this is a plan several major military branches have sanctioned and are actively participating in, and if the kick succeeds- which it will if you help me- the Reavers will be weakened *everywhere* and the war will shift in our favor. I am *respectfully* asking you to join me.” Arryk now pointed at the jeerer, but his body and voice still addressed the crowd. “Will you help this tired dying man, and help him die in a way he wants, followed swiftly by your wife and children!? Or will you help me, and actually *kill* those sons of bitches that have ruined your lives!?”

“I stand behind you!” a soldier in the Lumiknights loudly cried.

“I will stand behind you!” an emaciated woman cried out, her voice barely carrying enough strength to finish her sentence.

The rangers turned to their leader. Markus looked back in a bleak acceptance. “I have no love for this cowardly prince, you all know that.” Markus admitted to his men. “But a coward saves his own skin, and I’m sure the rest of the crown will skin him alive if he loses this battle as well. We need to set aside our pride for our families, for our homes! I will do my duty to protect the forest and its people, and I will stand behind Prince Arryk.”

“Arryk the Prince!” Felix shouted in triumph.

“ARRYK THE PRINCE!”

Domeric Raimes III

– *Bladeslinger* | *Oberath* –

His boots dragged on the mud. Kieran was screaming at him to hurry up, but Domeric could not, he could not even want to, he couldn't even feel despair or shame as his legs lugged on the ground. He could only feel the damp air on where his claws had marked his cheeks with the ugly red, the same red that dotted his skin with those monstrous tattoos. *How have my legs not broken?* They had all leapt from the rock face, and tried to skate down, yet Domeric was never good at skating. Kieran had bested him at that, Kieran was the better man– the better soldier too. That was why even though he was younger, it was his arm that was going in circles and his mouth opening and closing begging him to come. *Come with me*, he heard him say, his face turned to a great big smile. *Come with me, come with me*. He closed his eyes and opened them. His hair grew long and choppy, with a navy base and prismatic shards at the jagged edges. His black fur jerkin morphed into a rustic tunic with the metal teeth, his trousers the blue leather uniformly etched. She smiled at him. *Come with me! We can live!*

He felt less like a person and more like a marionette; his movements uncontrollable and predetermined. Even with his will collapsing, his legs seemed to never stop putting one after another. His knee scraped so hard against one of the pointed rocks, it had etched a line that reached the barebone. He winced as he turned around, though even moving his neck became so hard, his eyes squinting at the silver headed gunmen in the distance. *Don't look at me please.* He tried to cover his red Chasseur tattoos as they pointed their arms at him. He sniffled a bit, his arms crossing around his torso as he cradled himself, covering the ugly gash in his side and the savage red markings of crosses, trudging slowly to Amelie. *Come with me!* Will she take me out of here again? He dreamed that he could be a gracious comely young Sacrosanct knight in his final hours, saved from having to don his brooding black and savage red. *I can dream... Amelie said that if I can dream...*

A crack of gunpowder and a burst of clay. Domic knew that it sounded like the back of his hand. It meant they missed and he was still alive, as pathetic and slow of a target he was. He thought about the gorgeous flying knights, and their beautiful long blonde hair, and their rearing white coated pegasus, he thought about how their heads exploded like a firework when the gunners took them by surprise on the wall. One of them danced in the air so elegantly, so quick and gracious, and they hit her.

Yet they missed Domic again and again. He started to laugh. *This is a true cruelty.* He laughed as he looked at the beautiful sky, the sun had almost completely set now, and the air was iridescent pastels of purple and orange while the red darkened around the clouds. Domic reached his long arm out. Her rainbow hair flapped like a flag. Her hair was navy blue. *The Sacrosanct blue.* He coughed red into his hand as he stared. He did not deserve the blue banners. He did not deserve to enjoy a joyful last sight before he died. Amelie told him to wake, to go up, and he should have ignored her. *Tavick...* He groaned and cried as he walked. *I got you killed, likely Eidrick too.* It was all his fault, he was so dumb and naive. *I know, I know,* he told himself sarcastically before breaking into a fit of laughter.

Mad, mad... he heard the Wychen calling him mad and pointing and snickering. The clay roared in laughter with them, jumping in the air and screaming. The scratches on his face made him feel like an old birch tree, his skin had blistered and begun small tears where his nails dug, the way the trees bark stripped off piece by piece. *Tavick drowned in the gas. Your pain is a fraction of his...* Why couldn't Domeric have taken his spot? He would have gladly done it too. His life could have been important. The moist air seeped into his open wounds. He groaned, he wheezed, and he did not remember well what happened. Only drifting between the big rocks, through the clay.

In a few random blissful moments, Domeric would chuckle and feel like a sailor, like he was with Reese again with Hadrian pulling the ropes on the sail, Kieran on the rudder, and Mathis at the wheel, and he would laugh and chuckle and maybe even smile. But then he remembered Tavick spent the last of his life choking on smog, and that Eidrick was rotting that monster's dungeon, and that Leylo was dead, and that the Artificer and all his fellow monsters were dining on sweatmeats and wine and laughing, and a sadness would strike the smile off. *My fault. That, I do know.* Mathis cried with him at least, he whimpered and trudged. *I am not alone.*

At some point, they began to run behind the massive rocks on the clay beach, Domeric climbed a few, though he didn't know how he found the strength. They began to sprint and run and chase, for some reason. Hadrian laughed as he leapt from rock to rock. Domeric felt his dry mouth tighten. *He's having fun. Our captain is dead and half our crew gone and our nation in despair and he's kicking the clay and smiling, like a child playing in the rain.* Domeric just sighed, and chuckled and cried. Kieran had stopped speaking, before there would be "Are you okay?" and "Can you keep going?" but now when Kieran turned around his eyes grieved for his brother. *He thinks his brother dead.*

My cheeks sting. He giggled and placed his hand against the carving from the nails, before turning around in a daze. The giant rocks that dotted the Ashrend shores formed a small labyrinth, and the failed Bladeslingers were running and screaming as they came pouring through the rocks. The red sun basked them all.

One of the boys, a Bladeslinger, stopped running and turned back, with a stick held high and a white cloth fashioned around it. He waved it left, he waved it right. It floated in the crimson sky like a dove. In front of the rocks formed a small impasse. Domic heard Mathis crying to keep running, but he just stared at the surrendered boy. A mop of silver hair poked through the rocks, then her silver boot, then that... *boiler*. It screeched.

The dragonhead breathed its purple smog all over the boy, who placed his hands on his head as he fell to the ground, before he started convulsing. She stomped on his chest as she approached with her tall purple boots. The smell of the smog and gas was all too familiar. Finally, Domic remembered how to be shocked, and he shrieked and sprinted, as he heard men screaming behind him. He was sobbing as he ran through between the rocks, trying to calm himself. He tried the four second inhale exhale but it only reminded him of the captain, and he cried harder. *Where's my brother?* The panic's grip was iron. He needed something warm. He ran, he barreled through Lumiknights who called him *barbarian* but he kept sprinting. When he finally cleared the rocks near the jagged shore, he saw more ships on the horizon, coming towards the bay. For a brief moment he thought salvation had arrived, but when he turned right, the hope dimmed like a sun behind the clouds.

His black eye swayed with the rest of his body on the rope, which tugged his neck so tightly. Four Lumiknights surrounded the pinata, their hands on blue banners and diamond scabbards. "*Mathis!*" Domic cried as he prowled over. He had no idea what he was doing, he had given up, he told himself so, but Mathis was young and scared like him. Mathis showed him how to bake bread and oatcakes without making them burnt or stale. "Why did you do this?" He scorned them so.

The tallest of the bunch had a long goatee and massive eyebrows, and the oldest of them by a long shot. The three smaller ones had the same height and hair— parted straight down the middle. *Just like your body when I am done with you.* "I'm sorry?" The tall one answered, offended. "Don't you mean why did you do this *sir*, savage? And to answer your question, he rabitted, so we gave him Maverick's justice."

"As if the King would approve of such barbarism!" Domic yelled.

He scoffed, “Did you just call me a barbarian.” He looked him down, on his skull ornamented tribal garb, on his blood war tattoos. Domicer tried to cover them with his hands.

“He was scared! He didn’t deserve to die! And what do you mean he rabitted? We are retreating!”

“No you’re not.” One of the shorter ones said. “You’re going back in there. Artemis and Maverick are facing off against Ralf and Lorynce, they won’t be able to reinforce the fortress. We’re hitting them again.”

You mean I’m hitting them again. “That doesn’t give you the right to murder! You don’t know what we went through–”

The tall bully slammed his hilt into his stomach, Domicer’s head pecked the ground like a bird as he tried to brace his stomach. In a fit of rage and tears and madness, Domicer drew his blade. *I was one of the best fencers in our lance. I can beat him– I can!* He screamed and slammed his blade into the tall bully’s stardust sword sending it into the clay. Domicer smiled. *I did it!* Then he was on the ground, when one of the shorter ones kicked him in the stomach again, the other his leg, the other his chest. His hands didn’t do a good job at blocking the hits while he was on the ground. His anger turned to anguish, his roars to wails. The boots stormed on him. *Pain is an old friend.* When they finally left, he was still laying there. He lay and stared at the stars. He could make out the trident, the horseman, and the winged arrow. Reese and him used to lay on the sands of the Shoals, and Reese would point at them. “No matter where you are,” he would say, “You can find home with the stars. The world is always here for you, if no one in it is.” *What constellation could get me out of this? World, please show me something.*

“Up.” Hadrian panted, his breath misting in the air. “They said we are going back in. On your feet, Dom.” Domicer did not respond, and Hadrian waited for what seemed like hours. “Dom? I know you can hear me.” He kicked Domicer in the leg.

“I’m not getting up.”

“Why not? Don’t you want vengeance?”

“I don’t want any more violence. I don’t want any more war. *Death is so horrid and cruel.*” He looked at his blade. “We’ve all suffered so much haven’t we? I wanted so badly to make them suffer for once. But why would I want such a thing? I heard them scream, our friends, our foes, it hurt my ears so much.” His head hung down. He could feel a tightening noose chaffing his neck. “I couldn’t protect my captain. I couldn’t protect Mathis. I couldn’t kill that guard either. I’m not meant for violence. I hate it. I want no part in it. They can win and I can die. I’ve made my peace.” *I want to see my mother.* Domicer felt the anger again. *Worthless. Weak.* His skin still burned and stung from the clawmarks. He thought of Tavick’s wife, of how he had a son once. How much fun he must have had, teaching him out to ride a horse, how to use a sword. Domicer imagined Tavick on the riverboat with Eidrick, smart enough not to listen to a fool. He finds his wife again, they have another son, one not like Domicer—this one was strong and smart and successful, not a bastard barbarian. *Why did he ever care about me?* If only he hadn’t, this could have all been avoided. *Creak... Creak...* The sound of the rope Mathis swung by kept playing and kept playing. *Make it stop! I’m sorry!* The stinging from his scars became worse when the salt from his tears began to seep into them. He wanted to stop crying so bad but the more he tried the more they poured salt into the wounds. He imagined Eidrick in the cell as the guards dragged him out and beat him bloody. He rubbed at his face, and began thrashing to get the tears off. The distant smell of the gas was in his nose. In his ears was the choking and stuttering, gasping for air. His head pounded, and he began choking and stuttering as well. If only to make it worse, Hadrian just stared at him, just to humiliate him more. Domicer wanted to slam his fist into his smug face, but when he tried to ball his hands his knuckles betrayed him, and so did his legs, as when he fell he could not even will himself to stand up. “Why are you just watching me?” He cried out.

A sparkle appeared in Hardian’s eyes and a jingle in his voice. “What are you doing?” He asked curiously. “Aren’t you angry?”

“Of course I’m angry!” He bayed like a feral dog. “I am angry and I hate so much.”

“Really?” Hadrian asked in a strangely generous tone. “Then why are you hurting yourself instead of others?”

Domeric growled. “You’re not some brave warrior. You’re a monster like them. A piece of shit who just likes killing.”

“That’s exactly who I am, and that’s exactly who you are too. You just don’t know it yet.” He pointed at Domeric, his finger right up against his face. “Violence. You talk about it like it’s some horrible aspect of our lives, yet it’s the only true and fair thing we have.” He pulled out a blade from his trousers. It was the blade that he lost in the clay when the bullies beat him into the ground. It was the one he trained and sparred with as long as he could hold a weapon. It was the one he swore to put in the Artificer’s skull. It was the one that he couldn’t use to kill that bully. “Take it.” Domeric didn’t reach for it. “*Take it.*” Hadrian’s voice sunk deep.

“I will not.” Domeric hissed.

“Look at you. A bastard boy who dreamed of glory in war and couldn’t even make it through his first battle without breaking. A *barbarian*, a bastard boy of a lowly race doomed to serve and beg for affirmation of a people who will never have a modicum of respect for him. What a pathetic existence. And the boy won’t even fight back.”

“You said it yourself then. Leave the boy. Go and kill them all yourself because that’s who you are and that’s what a monster like you loves.”

“I don’t see why you detest violence so much in a world where peace doesn’t exist. Violence—you hate it yet it is the only thing a lowborn boy like you actually has. And it’s always there, it’s always been in every corner in every place in every world in every person’s life at every second. Whether its two merchants haggling over each other in the market place to decide who will feed their kids or whether its two lords arguing over who will wear the crown, violence is always there. The competition has seeped its way into every facet of society, the trade, the church, the courts, the *fields*. The only form of violence that I can stomach is two men with blades in their hands. War is a true violence, where the human spirit supersedes the gold or lands or blood that have.”

Violence is the purest form of self expression. We don’t choose what gods we worship, we don’t choose to be born in the right family, we don’t choose what people we belong to. We don’t choose the master we serve or how we serve them. We act like we did, but we didn’t. This world decided all of that

for you. Men march into battle under banners they didn't choose, sporting colors they may have never truly liked, holding whatever weapons that were thrown in their hands. But violence, how you fight, that *is* your choice. You can choose how you are when your back is against the wall, when all choices of your life lead to one final stand. You get to choose how this world remembers you in your last moments, and what scars you leave on it. The only true way to know someone is to have them try and kill you. Your violence is who you really are. Some men fight with pride and composure— methodical and graceful strikes of the sword. Some fight with fear and panic, manically swinging their blade like a cornered child. Some watch and listen and prowl and wait. Some are feral, some use their teeth and their nails and will screech and bite and scratch. Some fight with sadism, some with vengeance, some with love or loyalty. What will you fight with?"

You saw what they fought with. Turrets. Monsters. Guns, black magic, and thick crystal plate. Did they even have to lift their fingers? You call them cowardly? They are calling you so small that they can't hear you.

When they gassed your captain, they could have just shot him. But they didn't. They wanted to see what the gas would do, and how it would make him suffer. Killing you isn't beating a rival on the field, it's crushing an ant with a boot, rubbing it around on the ground, watching its legs fall off as it shrivels up and dies, and then moving on with your day with a smile" Domic could feel his blood boil.

"That's their violence."

Your Sacrosant friends beat you to a pulp and hung your friend. Hung him for a feeling of fear from a battle they didn't even fight in. Then they knocked the blade out of your hand and beat you into the ground because you insulted them. Because you're a barbarian and they're not and that makes them better than you. They don't try to understand and they never will, because they walk and talk and fight with an empty arrogance. That's their violence."

Hadrian snatched Domic's hand and put the blade's handle in his palm. His oily eyes danced in the moonlight. His voice grew soft and gentle, like a lover, as he spoke straight into Domic's ears.

"Introduce them to a bit of your violence. Ask yourself- are they really better than you? If we pull the curtains, clear the smoke, shatter the mirrors, are they *actually* better than you, or is it just for show?

Give them a show of your own. Show the sinners that your mercy was a privilege they should have been grateful for. Show the dark heretics that they should get out of their seats for you. Show the golden frauds that they ought to speak to the *barbarian* more softly. You want to win more than them, you deserve it more than them. Even the playing ground by showing just how much you really hold back. You see Dom, the thing about war that *I* love the most? *It's actually fair*. War is your world. Violence is your scripture. Killing is your life.” The blade danced in his palm. “*Take it.*”

The handle was so smooth.

Karina Kenning II

– *Dark Arts Academy* –

The Fissures cracked the ground that Karina’s wagon bounced on like ice. White blankets covered all the ebonwood and pine trees while the shadows began to pulse and weave throughout the air, hiding the moon and stars in certain spots like splotches of void. The ground was so cold that the air got only warmer as it rose from the ground, making distant trunks of trees and chunks of rocks on the ground look elevated in the air. Karina pressed her quill against the paper, it etched the shadow permanently against it.

Sweet Percius,

As expected, the position is mine. An entire Legion is now under the command of the Kennings. After I conquer the Glades and you run the Render as Castellan, our name will go down in the tomes, in the same study halls you and I sat in before. It is a great thing to be a part of, to be so young and so tall on the ladder. I'll pay you a visit, soon after I crush the coward Arryk. I know you will do the same to the Royal Regiment.

Kary

Percius. One of the few men she could actually stand, one who was actually reasonable, patient, clever and not at the mercy of his impulses like so many others. *He's related to me. Of course he's one of the exceptions.* "They say the Glades have more rifts than the other three territories, and by no short margin. Is this so?"

Gareth Petron, a famous former prodigy of the Dark Arts Academy and the Castellan of the Glades joined her company in the antique carriage, with crystal lights and velvet seats. Their driver wore a huge hat to pair with his huge beard, he slammed the reins into the horses as he took them to the nearest ravine gate, through tundra plateaus and *fissures* all over the ground. "It may, my lady. We still have to finish surveying the shoals." Gareth sighed. "I hope it's the case however. It would make the two of us indispensable." She wanted to laugh. *Us?* He took a small tin case of herbs, and put some in his mouth and began to chew, it dotted his lips with a dark green juice. "I hear the invasion of Ashrend is being thwarted as we speak."

"I have great faith in my brother and no faith in the Royal Regiment. Two times they tried to storm the shores, and two times we had a great mushroom harvest."

“It will be a third soon. Ralf and Lorynce descend down Redstone Bridge with two of our most modern armies, sixteen thousand men between the two of them. When we trap the royals in the river between the garrison and the two armies... the Render may be entirely ours by the year’s end. In some ways I envy your brother, the predator chains in the Render are so fascinating– an entire ecosystem that runs on death, held hostage by the hive mind of fungi. And he’ll have the whole region to himself, free from Maverick’s grubby fingers.” Karina always pitied the Chasseur. *Fighting beasts, feasting on the mushrooms that bloomed on its corpse, building blade from its bones, how savagely miserable.* The Wychen don’t fight beasts, they make their own. “But, the Glades... no other area quite satisfies my curiosity.”

The carriage cut through the snow. Decades past, there would need to be an armed escort, but the Castellan of the Fissures, Ivory Jenkins, had purged all the bandits in the region in his quest to transform the Fissures into his surveillance state. If you said a wrong word, you would be plucked and thrown to mine in the Depths or forage in the Freeze. The fourth and last Castellan, Rickard Bakere of the Shoals, was rumored to be a former smuggler, who Lorynce picked over a dozen scholars, had been charting some of the most lucrative shipping lanes Oberath had seen. Of all four Castellans, Gareth was most infamous, and most poised to stand in her way. All of them besides Percius were known to pursue their personal ambitions over the war effort. *Those cowards. How dare they do exactly what I’m trying to do?* “Gareth, what about the Glades do you like so much?” She looked into his eyes with as much performative curiosity as she could.

“Most ecosystems are stable– the Render for instance. The dead get filtered through the Redstone River, they feed mushrooms, they feed beasts that hunt other beasts and those beasts turn to mushrooms. Entire wars worth of battle between beasts and the life forms hold their form for dozens of centuries. In the Glades, when life grows so fast that the biomes split into biomes which makes the animals split and the plants split with them– you see all sorts of creatures. It’s remarkable. An alchemist can spend a lifetime studying the plants, a butcher studying the different gamey meats, a Lorekeeper the different species. I’m excited to spend most of my life there.” He took a deep breath, exhausted from the gushing.

“That’s thrilling.” She lied. “I’d much like to step foot into these ‘Glades’, and experience the wonders firsthand. To have such good scenery for when I destroy Prince Arryk’s Legion...”

“Are you that confident?” Castellán seemed skeptical. *Skeptical*. It made Karina almost twitch. “His Legion is trained by Felix Hawkins, and their men’s martial talent is second to none. Arryk may be a coward and foolhardy, but he has a good mind for tactics and is one of the best swordsmen alive, not to mention his men seem to believe he’s some sort of savior.” The wagon bumped on a few rocks.

She scoffed at that. “Savior? The only thing he saves is his own skin, usually with his tail tucked between his skinny legs. I’ll have his head on a spike. He has a pretty one, I hear.”

“Are you sure about your odds?”

“*Am I sure?*” Her voice suddenly dropped to a deep base and growl, the wagon skid off a sheet of ice as the driver led them on an icy path down a small mountain peak that protruded awkwardly through the cracked ground, half of its tip over the line of the ground, the other half under it. Castellán Garth rocked in his seat and almost hit his head on the door, but Karina did nothing but stare at him closely. He looked scared, frightened even. Her fingers were hot, her eyes were large and slanted, like a glaring owl. She gently smiled. “I think I can handle myself fine.” The Castellán may not have been as keen as she had been credited for. Arryk had his spikes but in the end he was still a naive impatient boy, which is why his tactics revolve around huge charges and raids.

Simple and predictable. He may be a sound tactician and swordsman however... *I am a prodigy of the most prestigious academy in this world, a Commander through merit, my scores make me one of a thousand. I walked into that audition hall with four men and left as the sole survivor, a commander, and our dear Emperor’s savior. Commander Arryk is nothing to me.* They said Arryk could not even read! Karina would not be bested by an illiterate spoiled boy who thinks swinging swords and winning wars was the same.

They passed by a lake where a cold mirage plastered a pinewood grove onto the water in some straight edged shapes, though the moonlight still glimmered off the lake surface. The carriage came to a harsh stop, and Gareth bounced a little. She stepped out to gaze among the winter winds that crashed against her face. The stars were all distorted by the different mirages and shadows in the air, it made the sky look like cracked purple-black glass. The purple fur coat she wore— whose hood drooped over her head with fur that covered up to her brow— did well to shelter her. Gareth gave a shrill shiver as he stepped into the winds with her, his breath smoking like a dragon. *He thinks this is cold?* She wanted to scoff. The snow kept a glint of the sky as it powdered onto the pair. Gareth tossed a small amethyst at the carriage rider, who gave a brief thank you before riding off. Fractures in vision could be seen— almost akin to when the heat was so great the air looked distorted, only they looked like rectangles instead of waves— coming up from the ravines below. “I hope things go the way you hope, or else the Emperor may never trust a woman again. No pressure.”

She felt none. She had played this exact scenario over in her head a thousand times, in class, in the yard, on her rides, while she bathed, while she tried to sleep. The scenario where glory was right there, and she just had to reach her hand out and grasp it. The two of them closed in a ravine, where the air’s distortion started to mess with the head. *Don’t look too close.* It was no surprise Sacrosanct said the Fissures could drive men mad. Along with the distortions, the warmth from the Glades shot throughout and basked Karina’s soft face with heat. She tore off her coat, revealing the long slender shoulders and arms of hers, as well as her metallic stockings. By the ravine’s door lay a massive coil of metal that was tied around a massive pole in the ground with the purple crow’s banner flying at its head. The whip-like sounds of metal wire echoed throughout the underground as Karina grabbed the metal and tied it tightly around her slim waist.

She stood on the rock's edge, turned around, keeping her legs close together and stretched her arms. "I hear Marand has been on a rampage throughout the Terra. He may set his eyes on Castle Greenhouse next, though, I'm sure you will thwart him no problem. *No pressure*, of course." She smiled deviously before doing a backwards summersault down into the velvet abyss, and as the fractured sky grew more and more distant and the winds blowing against her back became harsher and harsher she smiled. Many students pissed themselves the first time, including Percius, but after Karina's first time the only thing she wanted was to go again. The warmth of the Glades felt closer and closer as she kept falling and falling. Time and physics seemed to forget themselves as she grew closer to Oberath's bottom, her hair started to flail about. The purple grew richer and the air grew thicker and plumes of mist started to surround her like she was a smoking ham. Through the smoke she could see the lush green canopies of the Glades where the only thing higher than the tree tops were the fireflies and pollen in the air. She could see the rapids and cliffs and bellowing beasts of the Render as they munched on mushrooms that grew on decomposing bodies. She could see the clear spikes that served as beaches and the thunderstorms that cooked the sands to glass in the Shoals. She saw the delicate pastures, floating islands, and river canals in a warm summer drizzle in the Meadows. *The Glades*, she thought. *Take me to the Glades*. She closed her eyes.

She dreamt of a great fire in the Fissures. The fire turned cold and white, like burning ice, and scorched the Academy of the Dark Arts, the fields of taro and ebonwheat, the palace and Carrow's throne, burning all and leaving nothing but ashes and shadows. Wychen men women and children were crying and screaming, running with pales of water and their babies. The embers danced around the sky and cluttered her eyes, but when the flames started to clear, she saw two shadows in burning ruins. A woman pointed at the two shadows and screamed. A boy, with a skinny sharp jaw and long muscular arms, with a smirking grin and a giant blade in his hand, and next to him a girl or woman, tall and lean with no other discernable features outside of a big gun in her hands, and embers that did not dare come close to her skin.

The fire cleared. When she opened her eyes, she climbed onto the mossy rocks, the spring air going up her nose. *How long has it been?* The moon told her it had been a few hours but her mind told her it had been days.

She smiled when she saw the big meat pie waiting to greet her. Malkan was bulky and large, a big present wrapped in a velvet shell that looked like it was soon to pop. By his sides were two retainers— middle aged bearded men with big axes and bigger bellies. They held the purple crow's banner up high where it blew in the spring wind.

"A woman!" His breath smelled like wine and cloves. He laughed. She did not, even if she knew she probably should. "I forgot you were a woman, dear gods, I haven't seen one out here in so long! One that wasn't green or blue of course. You look a lot like your brother. Please give him my regards."

"Of course, my prince." She curtsied. "I hope I will come to enjoy the Glades as you have!" The woods were as gorgeous as she had heard, and the sky was bare and naked and unfractured. She loved it, she wanted to stare into the sun until it burned her irises off. The birds sang for her arrival as well. *How nice.*

"Enjoy?" He bellowed. "Is that what they call fucking and eating and drinking my way through the dwellings!?" She awkwardly laughed with him. "Oh don't deny it," he continued. "I know *they* say it. That's how *they* see me, my dear father and brother. Lorynce wonders why I drink so much. '*You won't live as long if you do, you fat fool*'. Has he considered he just makes me want to die sooner? Same with my father... I hope you had a good first impression!"

"He was..." She struggled to find a white lie. "Most honest."

"Honest! You have a way with words, I bet that's why you're still alive. He killed at least one I take it!"

She exhaled sharply and gave a sarcastic face. "Well..."

“All of them!?” He laughed so hard he started to choke on his green spit and purple wine. “Ah my dear father. I used to scorn him for never being there but that was actually a massive blessing! Oh, I know, the *Malkan*, the *evil gluttonous lustful Malkan*. Let them call me ‘lustful’ all they want, if the point of life is to make offspring then I am the greatest living being of all time. The Malkan Army, they are calling it, hundreds of my bastards, many half green half purple.”

“That’s great to hear, my Prince.”

“Malkan is fine. I’m not Lorynce, you don’t have to kneel around me. Anyone who survives a trial with my father deserves some respect. I hope it was not just beginner’s luck, for your second trial begins now. Arryk has sent his premier forces West, we hear. I’m not sure what he’s planning.”

Am I the only one with foresight here? She slyly smiled before acting dumb. “The boy is loud and dramatic, and brings a stampede of steeds wherever he goes. We will see soon enough.”

Malkan took a slurp from one of the four colored vials tied to a rope around his neck. Its juices were thick and viscous. She could see his pupils get larger. “I suppose we shall. Our scouts found that Arryk has twice the strength that we expected along with four times the horse. He rallied mercenaries all over the Meadows and Glades as well as the local militia and Marand’s Rangers to his cause. Whatever he’s planning, it’s big.” *Like you.*

“Then every second counts.” She smiled. “Do you have my army?”

“Sir Loslow will show you the way.” He gestured to one of his crystal mailed retainers. “Our late commander’s last order was to hold the western groves, you’ll find most of his old Legion there.” The fat man and his other retainer began to walk towards the ravine. The back of his robe was covered in scratches and holes. “The death of your predecessor has left our lines in disarray. Arryk will try to seize the moment. I entrust you and Gareth to keep him in line, lest you disappoint my dear father.”

“Are you heading to the palace, my prince?” She asked skeptically. He didn’t answer, only dropped into the pit like an anvil, followed quickly by his remaining guard. The purple lights dimmed when his massive shadow cast into the hole. Sir Loslow scarcely spoke as they followed half a dozen trails across the Glades, weaving between hills and marshes, stepping on dirt paths and lily pads, passing by fluffy reindeer and wet slimes as they went. One would think it would be easy to get lost, but the late Commander had sent his Survey and Foraging Corp to carefully etch various symbols of spiders and wolves and such into the massive trunks to guide the way while they carved paths through the massive trees. Loslow focused on the one that looked like a scorpion with a massive pincer. When they saw the scorpion for the last time, wooden walls surrounded by trees that held peaches and beehives on their arms welcomed them. The purple crows could be seen, the fabric gently weaving in the wind. Sir Loslow gave a bow before walking off, having not said a single word the entire journey. *Malkan must have ripped out his tongue.*

The massive gates awaited them. A guard in dirty unpolished armor shouted as he aimed his barrel at the pair. “Who goes there!” When she got closer, he put the barrel down. “Get out of here girl, this is a battlefield!”

She stared at him for a moment, trying to process the man’s audacity before another boy opened the gates. “Step aside sir.” The guard nodded. The boy had a deep purple coat with buttons, along with shiny silver embroideries on top. “*Commander Kenning.*” The spring leaves in the air caught onto his shirt, where a pair of binoculars strung around his neck.

She smiled. "That has a good ring to it, don't you agree?" A man shouted an order and the wooden gates heaved against the mud, dragging a trail in the mud. The slimes bounced eagerly as she entered the town, trying desperately to avoid getting mud on her boots. *I much prefer the snow.* As she squished her way through the trails, the boy, Captain Rumlo, gave her an earful about the local developments in the Glades, many of which she already knew, or predicted, to be more precise. With Thrage dead, the line was in disarray and many of the men in the area had been killed or captured. Amidst the chaos, Arryk quietly amassed a grand number of horse and militiamen north of Castle Greenhouse, where Gareth was expected to arrive shortly. "With Ralf taking the bridge and Percius throwing back the invasion of Ashrend, destroying Arryk on top of that will spell the end of the Commonwealth. Should I tell the men to start moving near the clearing?"

"No, you shall not." She said sternly. "He won't be there. Keep them behind the hills South of Castle Greenhouse. If he moves on the castle, we have the numbers to double siege him." She proclaimed confidently. "As the Old Emperor Orphys did when the Fissures established their first colony." She smiled, a siege around a siege, Arryk could not see it coming. "We will conceal our soldiers among the greenery, then when his back is facing us we come out of the shadows and stab him."

"A wise plan, my lady, but..."

"But?"

"How are you so certain that Arryk will try and take Castle Greenhouse? It's a fool's errand that even he's not fool enough to try. The castle is nigh impenetrable."

"Nigh, but not totally. And Arryk has the strength to do so, with his extra mercenaries and cavalry and Terra militia, and more importantly he has the audacity. He was a coward for leaving the last Core Castle, what better way to vindicate his name than retaking one? When he does, and we trap him again, he will not dare retreat. It will be his last day as a prince. If you're worried the task is too tall for him to try, let's make it easier for him. We'll pull back the skirmish line, as well as the defenders near the dwellings that lead up to the Castle."

"What about Gareth? He's held up in the Greenhouse." Karina looked at him and smiled. She saw a grin on the boy's face when he realized.

“Did you catch the Coward?” She asked him.

“His raiders, right in his tracks. Sir Donloes has led some two hundred men across the streams in canoes in the darkness. They are coming straight for this camp tonight, in fact.”

She snorted. “He thinks it will be that simple? Let’s put him in his place.” Rumlo’s smile did not fade. “You want something, don’t you?”

“I feel as if I deserve some more esteem for my achievement.”

“Esteem?”

“The Sentry Corps have been your greatest asset for some time, we deserve more of your resources than the Survey Corps! Preparation is key, like you always said! Because of us, we will have Arryk’s Raiders feeding crows tonight!”

“Because of *me*, I sent you there because I knew he would try something reckless like this, do not forget yourself, Rumlo.”

“There’s plans, and executions.”

“You want a higher budget? You will have it when you help me deal with these Raiders. Send word out to your men, start putting mud and camouflage on, and gather guns.” He nodded and ran off, while she followed the trail to the camp center, where the smoke stacks rose high and the men were dancing and drinking and singing.

She wanted to dance herself, when was the last time she had done so? She hadn't treated herself to something like that in ages, yet when the banging drums and the singing of the men reached her ears her feet couldn't help but dance a little. She killed a couple of ants by accident. *My first blood*. One day, she would have someone she could bear to dance with, whose feet could match hers. She saw the dumb young stable boys and squires, serving their Musketeers like the good boys that they were. She saw a gaggle of Terra escort girls, in their grasssilk dresses and twisting their long twirly green hair and fairy eyes, blushing red like idiots as their drunk degenerate buyers straddled them. It peeved Karina in a strange way, and her breathing grew hot. A man twice her age with a crooked smile and cleft chin stomped over. *Squish, squish*, his boots clamped against the mud. He reeked of alcohol, his eyes were pale and ugly, his hairs were sparse and poorly trimmed. He towered over her in his sweaty button shirt. "Our commander will be here soon. What's a Wychen maid like you doing out here?" His breath smelled of old onion and booze. She scrunched her nose.

"Who's to say I'm a maiden?" She said, concealing the viciousness under a bubbly tone.

The men all wooed and laughed. The degenerate came up close to her. "Either way, you won't be after *tonight*." He leaned in to try and kiss her, and when his lips pried open the slightest bit she shoved her hand in to snatch his tongue and pull it out. He tried to push her back, but he was too slow, and by the time his hands slammed against her body her dagger had already separated his tongue from his head. The men all gasped in horror and shock as blood sprouted out of his mouth. She kicked him in the ribs.

“Our commander will be here soon.” She mocked his dumb gruff voice as she kicked him over and over. “Well, I’m here now.” She stomped on him again, when his wheezing and whining turned into mumbles as he had the mud. She took a handkerchief hidden inside her coat and threw at one of the gaping spectators. “Clean him up now! As for the rest of you, listen now and listen close, and spread the word. Interrupt me, ask me a stupid question, say anything other than ‘yes my lady’ and you’ll end up like this sod!” She kicked him again and he flipped over. His comrade had begun trying to clean the blood off his lips and wool jerkin. “Arryk has sent us fresh meat! Our sentries caught him trying to run across the rivers to attack us tonight! They will think we are disorganized, that we are sleeping, that we are weak and ripe for killing! Let him feed his delusions. We will smolder the fires, leave the horses hitched, and leave only a sparse number of guards. Then, once the raiders break through our gates, we are to let them get into the camp before killing all but the Terra Mercenaries. You are to take any Ranger Mercenaries prisoner if you can!”

“Why... my lady?!” One of the men stammered.

“Their loyalty is easy to bend, and they likely have little love for Arryk, unlike his devoted worshippers. I’m going to my tent for the night, and when I leave, I want Arryk’s Raiders looking up at the sky or in chains!”

Reese II

– *Alchemist Guild* | *Oberath* –

“Clear!” Reese’s hands cupped around his ear, the sound of the hollow space reminded him of a seashell. *The sound of the sea.* The sound of the storm came next, when the cannon blasted and a near deafening clap rang into the clay filled air. The red antler trees swayed, the hairs on their furry coats falling off as the ground boomed. Colorful smoke plumed into the air. *Like a rainbow consumed by the clouds.* Reese’s eyes sparkled as much as the embers in the air as he watched in awe. The star whistled and whined in the air leaving a burning trail of prismatic fire as it leapt off the clifftop they were on, and splashed into the river. The water shot out in the air before exploding on all sides, and though the waves were relays away Reese still thought for a moment they would reach land. For a moment, he felt like he was back in the Shoals, watching the beautiful waves from the sandglass beaches.

“Excellent!” Apprentice Marrisor cheered. His goggles made tan lines around his skin. He clapped madly, and so did all the other onlookers– Lumiknights, alchemists, lords, stable boys, serving girls. The spectacle made Marrisor’s apron bounce in the air. Reese laughed at the crowd.

“You all like it? I bet the Wychen will like it more! We will give it to them today at the Redstone Bridge!” Reese pumped his fist in the air. By the cannon’s tempered glass edges was a massive bag of fallen stars, their color crawled through the bag’s mouth, and to its left was a keg of whale fat. Marrisor grabbed a torch from his wife for the week, a Chasseur woman with long hair and curvy arms, she has a wide smile and wider eyes. It peeved Reese in a way, the Sacrosanct never truly cared for the woman of the Render, and cared more for their dark features and lean builds rather than their courage or culture. Marrisor had the gall to joke that he “took after” Reese, as if wedding and bedding a woman were the same thing.

A man in the distance whistled and waved, he had a banner with a great winged pair of blades upon it. *The hunt begins.* Marrisor tucked the girl under one arm and held the torch high with the other. The orange sun blazed in his downturned blue eyes. “I think we need one more test trial, don’t we all agree?” The men, reeking of ale and red in the faces, all clamored in agreement. If Artemis was at her happiest shouting orders on the field, Reese was at his when showing off his toys to a bunch of fun loving drunks. It pained him to attend to his duties. *Maverick will be proud of my sacrifice.*

Reese clapped his hands together. “Duty calls for me, as they say, so I will let my dear friend Marissor take over.” He slapped his back with his palm and walked to where the hill began, the man with the banner whistled and kept waving. “I see you!” He shouted over one of Marrisor’s monologues about progress with ominous undertones about national superiority. “You can stop whistling.” Reese huffed as his legs carried him up the clay hill, killing a couple mushrooms on the way up.

“Prince Reese,” The messenger bowed his head. Even though he had been a Brynnic Prince all his life, Reese still felt a jolt of pleasant surprise when people addressed him as so.

“Sir Mylen. What news is urgent enough to disrupt such an important affair?” He motioned in the distance where Marrisor sat on the cannon drinking while daring his woman to set it off, she laughed as she taunted and dangled the torch over him.

Mylen chuckled, he was missing a few teeth but his smile was nice all the same. His big dimples made up for the teeth. “Maverick descended upon Ralf’s northern flank. Artemis has sent Corsair Divermen up the rivers as well, and told them to set ablaze to their tents, and kill as many creatures and mounts as they can find before retreating. She also had them drop hot coals all over the river to leave as much fog as possible.” Reese was aghast at that.

“That’s a suicide mission!”

He nodded solemnly. Mushrooms seemed to crowd around his horses hooves. “We are all in debt to their bravery. During that time, our decoy force of four thousand made it onto the bridge. Unfortunately, Lorynce snuck past our navy somehow, he led a massive raiding party that demolished the decoy’s main defenses. Him and Ralf are taking the bridge as we speak.”

“Has Artemis’ attacked yet?” Reese’s chest was tight when he asked.

“She has.” He smiled proudly. “Her riverboat men drove north and met Maverick’s forces coming south— the Wychen army is cut in two. Their rear guard is surrounded. Lorynce tried to punch through and rejoin them, but a landslide sealed the pass. Now their only road forward is the bridge, to punch through the decoy and destroy the regiment whilst running for their lives.”

Reese’s teeth grinded. “That is not going to happen.”

“It will not. Which is why Lady Artemis asks that you bring two batteries of your new cannons to Trappers Overlook.”

“Only two? We have ten! We need all the firepower we can get! We can rain fire on them with forty cannons at once!” Reese shouted.

“We cannot afford that much collateral. Lady Artemis gathers the finest horseriders and plans to give chase to Lorynce and Ralf as they try to escape. She’ll catch him soon enough, she rides well.” Reese chuckled. *That she does.* “She only requires a few cannons to take out key targets as she cuts her way through the bridge. You must take great care not to kill your dear wife, my prince.”

“That I will. She would be furious with me.”

“Be careful of the Rangers on the river as well. Arryk rallied Marand and his men to throw rafts on the rapids and ambush the men on the bridge. It would be severely problematic if you killed the darling of the Terra. And one more thing,” He looked at Reese, his chubby cheeks rosy red like the grass around him. “I hear they’re sending a *dragon*. Do be careful. I must spread these plans to the Survey and Raider Corp.” He kicked his horse and it whined.

“You be careful as well!” Reese shouted as the chubby man took off. The spores in the air jolted as Mylen’s black horse barrelled through. The cheering went out again, and the laughing, and Marrisor’s shouting. “Marrisor!”

“Yes!?”

“Get the boys, have them bring two batteries. Bring Bombardier Maxwell as his crew.” He took a flask from his waist and took a massive sip.

“Two? That’s it?” He kissed the Chasseur girl on the cheek before whistling for his horse. She turned redder than her blood tattoos.

“Yes, bring them about to the outlook. Make sure to bring extra fat and extra stars. We are to cover our ladies’ offense. She’s to cut a bloody path straight to Lorynce and Ralf. We’re to take out any obstacles they have to slow her advance, and the dragon if it comes to it.”

Marrisor’s eyes turned big for a moment at that. “Right away my prince.” Marrisor ran across the ashridden ground before hopping on his spotted steed. Reese grabbed the reins on his *Polia*, and lashed at her neck as she whinnied. *So many horses*. It was a good thing most of the horse eating beasts roamed south of the river. “You’re sure the bridge won’t be destroyed?”

“It won’t. The stars burn more than they break, and that bridge is one of the sturdiest things in Oberath.”

The damp air felt like water when Reese panted as he slammed his boots into the stirrups. The wagons raced across the red fields. Mushrooms, antler trees, and massive skeletons big enough to be their own landmarks all stalked them on their journey. “Ralf and Lorynce are on the bridge!” He reminded his team, a ragtag group of scholars and Lumiknights, from all ages and all colors of personality, though Reese generally preferred the young curious type. “Our Lady Artemis’ has snared them in her trap, and now they seek to punch through! If they succeed, they’ll destroy our comrades by Castle Ashrend, and our comrades will be at the mercy of the Wychen, while we will be at the mercy of our King. They say he has beheaded men who have failed him. Do you want to lose your heads today!?”

“No!” They shouted eagerly.

“Today, we will return home with medals! Today we will return home with Lorynce’s ugly head!” They cheered and clamored. Marrow vines hung from the bone and blackwood trees like nooses all around them. The mushrooms sprouted on roadkill and lost logs.

“Did you hear of the flood? A river twenty relays northwest overflowed, smashing one of Lorynce’s cavalry charges. Blessed for us, but cursed for the poor village that was flooded. Gods be with them.” Grenadier Maxwell reported. Reese sighed, tucked his head down, and bit his tongue.

“This place is an ill omen. The land reeks of death and gleams of blood.” A young brown headed squire said solemnly.

“This place gives me the creeps.” Cried one of the Lumiknights. “I miss blue grass, I miss the sunny drizzles and the pastures.”

“I miss the flying islands. I’ll take that savage woman there one day, see how amazed she is by the Stardust Castles!” Marrisor cried. “It’ll be a real step up from their bone mud tents.”

Reese scoffed at that. “She’ll be less amazed than you think. I reckon you’d be amazed when you see their cities, dug and entrenched in the skeletons of ancient behemoths. The only thing you can show that amazes her is your purse.” He sneered bitterly.

“I didn’t pay her.” Marrisor said shyly. Reese laughed for a moment, before taking a second look. His eyes look sunk and embarrassed.

“You didn’t? You win her over with your titles then?”

“Must have been my famous charisma.” Marrisor joked. “She shares our affinity for machines, that’s all. She had me take a look at her Bladeskates. Insane, those things are. She said the blades didn’t respond to the environment right, that the veins were off. I tried taking a look, and I think if it was for any other woman I wouldn’t be able to make heads or tails of it– but I looked at the way she tucked her legs in and smiled and some genius came over me.” Suddenly, his horse buckled as its hoof got caught in one of the many snakeholes that dotted the Render’s northern grounds. He groaned as he palmed his kneecap, Reese slowed his horse to a trot.

“Came and went!” Grenadier Maxwell joked from the back of his wagon, sat atop jars of fat and beside a barrel of stars. The glass clinked as the wheel bounced on mounds of mushrooms and moss. Reese sighed and got off his horse. He could hear the wagon slow.

“Maxwell, there’s no need to wait for me.”

“But you’re acting Captain of the Armor Corp!”

“Yes, which means I excel in making the weapons, not using them. I’ll see Marrisor makes it to the outlook without issue. Besides, you know setting up is my least favorite part. Make sure they’re well spread out, and pointed to the bridge’s center. If Artemis charges in, clear any obstacles in her path, and be ready to deal with that dragon if it comes down to try and breathe her out.” Reese liked the way the clay and red grass felt against his leather boots. *I wish I was wearing my sandals now.* Red spores dangled over Marrisor’s head, spinning in circles. “Up now, comrade.” Reese grabbed him by the elbow and hoisted him up. Marrisor’s spotted horse, which looked much like a skinny cow.

“I was serious, you know.” Marrisor coughed. “This isn’t like the brown haired girl at the sables. Or the fairy girl at Castle Greenhouse. Or the sailor girl in the fisheries.” He said as he slowly climbed aboard his saddle.

Reese almost choked on his laughter, remembering how Marrisor would scream as the boat rocked, while she smiled and basked in the seawater. “She had your heart broken, and your purse emptied. ”

“I wonder if she was able to get out of that business. Charting trading routes, that was what she wanted. She loved the storms.” Marrisor continued to reminisce about how the women he paid to pretend to love him didn’t actually love him, and how each of them had different hobbies and passions and looks that he never paid enough attention to until after they were gone. Reese tried to laugh or banter with him, but the sick twisting in his stomach and the faintness in his hands reminded him of the one thing they were there to do.

When they reached Hunter’s Outlook, Grenadier Maxwell was already ordering small barrages onto the bridge from a distance. The stars whistled and the cannons rang their glass as they boomed. The Redstone Bridge was as gracious as it was huge, with its glowing ruby red ridges and parapet, with glowing black bearings, which had red insignias around its pier caps. The rusty water of the Redstone River below it spanned a massive six relays, red jellies and frogs could be seen squirming about. On the bridge the Wychen’s smog began to spread around the sky, and as it did, it spread and cracked the air around it. *They are trying to hide.* Reese placed the binoculars up to his head. In front of the massive cloud of smog that ate the bridgetop, he could see a massive scorpion with fat pincers along with a dozen hammer wielding soldiers beside it, desperately trying to hold off the advance. He saw a golden angel with golden hair and shiny armor on a white winged horse come swooping down like a seagull and chop one of the soldiers in two. A barrage of flares and arrows and spears then went into the rest of the soldiers, some of them getting stuck in the massive scorpions scales as its stinger swung about, catching the pegasus knight, throwing the girl off her horse as she fell into the river. The horse legs leaped off the rest of its body in a cloud of red, as its wings now lay still, then the stinger flung the horse off its point. The scorpion’s prickly long legs stood firm as it held its ground, even with a spear sticking out of its femur.

“Fire! Kill that thing!” Maxwell waved his arm in the air, and the eight stars flew in the sky. They were as bright as they were gorgeous, and when the colorful balls smashed against the scorpion and the surviving Wychen men around it, a ring of flame blew out. The scorpion exploded in a plume of entrails and guts, and the men around turned into flailing puppets as they baked in their armor. Reese’s goggles began to shake, his breath now clouding the lenses with mist. His breathing was heavy as he saw the beautiful and elegant flames dance with the men, twirling them in circles, dragging them on their knees, pulling them close. He could not hear them scream, only see their mouths open as their melted gray skin fell into them. The rainbows, when they had laid their partners to rest, flourished in the air and rose to the sky. Water welled in the binocular’s windows.

“Oh my god...” He put the binoculars down. He’s been the reason men have been crushed by ballistas or zapped with thunder, but this was something else. He hated how grossly magnificent it looked. He hated watching them scream in his eyes and hearing it in his head.

“Lady Artemis is moving in!” Marrisor pointed in awe. Even without the binoculars, he could see her stampede cut into the smog. With them, he could make out her beautiful glowing red tattoos as she rode past fire, corpses, and musketballs. An arrowhead of horse, coated white brown black and chestnut brown, broke through the ranks of the purple men as they followed their leader. Soldiers with dark four pronged lances came out to challenge her, but her horse reared up and she took her great massive blade, *Vantage*, with its great red veins and curved jagged edges, and carved the four men up like pumpkins, leaving smiles in their chests and holes in their eyes. Stars landed a fair distance in front of her, the heat from the dispersing rainbow flame clearing the smog around as the defenders panicked, now unveiled to the world. The horses cut through them like a knife through butter. A Musketeer aboard a makeshift tower from ebony boards and ladders tried to take a shot at the Huntress, but a pegasus knight smashed into him, causing his gun to fly off and his body to take a dive into the river. Reese’s eyes curiously followed him into the river, where his arm was bent backwards as he tried to flail his way up to the surface. On the river a group of rafted rangers, clad in their green netsuits and white wood bows, notched their arrows at the drowning man. *Rescue or a quick death*, Reese hoped. It was the latter, and the Wychen man sank to the floor as the Rangers filled him head to toe with glowing arrows. Artemis’s cavalry had now punched far into the smog, far out of sight. The roaring of the dragon finally came cutting through the air. *Finally, Lorynce is taking us seriously*. He saw it come from the corner of his eyes, sweeping down and breathing purple smog onto the bridge top, causing dozens of horsemen to crumble to the floor. The dragon roared and soared upwards, making loops in the air as it flew upside down.

“Fire! Up high!” Maxwell’s men launched in the sky, to no avail, though the dragon had to fly off course to dodge the stars that slammed against the cliffsides, making small iridescent avalanches.

“Careful!” Reese shouted. “Do not hit the Rangers on the river!”

“The dragon, what do we do!? It will destroy the cavalry charge! It will kill our lady!” Marrison cried. *No, it won't.* Reese stared in astonishment as a golden caped Pegasus knight with a massive meteor sword flew over the dragon's head, then leaped off his flying steed before burying the massive glowing blue sword into the skull of the monster so deep that the crossguard touched its head. Purple goo shot out the hilt like piss, it splattered over into the air as the dragon's wings spasmed. Its long neck cranked and almost threw Maverick off before he grabbed onto one of the spikes that protruded on its head. It snarled and screeched, the pitch was enough to make Reese's ear bleed, and the sound was so loud it was near deafening even from all the way up the cliffs.

“What the hell just happened!?” One of the Lumiknights cried out.

“He did it, the *King!* The Dragonslayer!” Maxwell began cheering and clapping, and was joined by the rest of the canoneers as the dragon fell in the air, its wings tucked tightly to its body as its purple eyes shut. It fell into the water, just as the stars from earlier, from the sound of the crash to the massive plume of water. Maverick leapt off the dragon's falling body, where his golden gilded Pegasus came and did a barrel dive through the air before letting Maverick grab the horncap.

He could see the men wave their weapons and blue and red and yellow banners in celebration as they pointed at the dragon's dead sinking body and the King's gracious steed. He moved the binoculars down to where the smog had been pushed back, where his Artemis was in there in the smoke, thrashing, fighting for her life, standing strong with the weight of her kingdom on her shoulders. He desperately scanned the smog's entrance for her. Then he saw it, a curvy shadow of a muscled woman with half a man in her hand. Her arms were wiry and carved, and her veins coursed through her forearm as she lifted the man's bloody upper torso. She held the *Vantage* in her left hand, the veins in the bone blade was pulsing as its edge had blood stuck to its teeth, and Ralf's ugly severed corpse in her right, his entrails and guts flying in the air like a flag. The mud and blood and sweat all smeared across her face, but they did all but accentuate her pretty lips and gorgeous obsidian eyes as her messy black hair blew with the black smoke and purple gas in the wind. She let out a cocky smirk as the blood dripped from her hair down to her mole-covered nose, before throwing Ralf's corpse onto the bridge floor and the men started to cheer and throw their hands up in her name.

